

Official Report of the
One Hundred Fifty-sixth
Semiannual General

CONFERENCE

of The Church of Jesus Christ
of Latter-day Saints

held in the Tabernacle
Salt Lake City, Utah

October 4 and 5, 1986

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THE ONE HUNDRED FIFTY-SIXTH SEMIANNUAL GENERAL CONFERENCE OF THE CHURCH OF JESUS CHRIST OF LATTER-DAY SAINTS

The 156th Semiannual General Conference of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints convened in the Tabernacle on Temple Square in Salt Lake City, Utah, on Saturday, October 4, 1986, at 10:00 A.M.

The general sessions of the conference were held at 10:00 A.M. and 2:00 P.M. on Saturday and Sunday, October 4 and 5, 1986. The general priesthood meeting was held in the Tabernacle on Saturday, October 4, 1986, at 6:00 P.M.

President Ezra Taft Benson presided at all sessions of the conference and conducted the Sunday morning session. President Gordon B. Hinckley, First Counselor in the First Presidency, conducted the Saturday morning and Sunday afternoon sessions. President Thomas S. Monson, Second Counselor in the First Presidency, conducted the Saturday afternoon and general priesthood sessions.

Television and radio stations carried portions or all of some of the conference sessions to large audiences throughout the world. In addition, the general sessions and the general priesthood session were carried via satellite transmission to more than one thousand stake centers. The general priesthood session was also carried by closed-circuit transmission to approximately nine hundred locations in many countries.

General Authorities present

The following General Authorities of the Church attended one or more of the general sessions:

The First Presidency: Ezra Taft Benson, Gordon B. Hinckley, and Thomas S. Monson.

The Council of the Twelve:
¹Howard W. Hunter, Boyd K. Packer, Marvin J. Ashton, L. Tom Perry, David B. Haight, James E. Faust, Neal A. Maxwell, Russell M. Nelson,

Dallin H. Oaks, M. Russell Ballard, and Joseph B. Wirthlin.

The First Quorum of the Seventy:
Presidents: Dean L. Larsen, Richard G. Scott, Marion D. Hanks, Wm. Grant Bangerter, Jack H. Goasland, Robert L. Backman, and Hugh W. Pinnock. *Additional Members of the Seventy:* A. Theodore Tuttle, Franklin D. Richards, Theodore M. Burton, Paul H. Dunn, Hartman Rector, Jr., Loren C. Dunn, Robert L. Simpson, Rex D. Pinegar, J. Thomas Fyans, Adney Y. Komatsu, Gene R. Cook, Charles Didier, William R. Bradford, George P. Lee, Carlos E. Asay, John H. Groberg, Jacob de Jager, Vaughn J. Featherstone, Royden G. Derrick, Robert E. Wells, James M. Paramore, F. Enzio Busche, Yoshihiko Kikuchi, Ronald E. Poelman, Derek A. Cuthbert, Rex C. Reeve, Sr., F. Burton Howard, Ted E. Brewerton, Angel Abrea, John K. Carmack, Russell C. Taylor, Robert B. Harbertson, Devere Harris, Spencer H. Osborn, Philip T. Sonntag, John Sonnenberg, F. Arthur Kay, Keith W. Wilcox, Victor L. Brown, H. Burke Peterson, J. Richard Clarke, Hans B. Ringger, Waldo P. Call, Helio da Rocha Camargo, H. Verlan Andersen, George I. Cannon, Francis M. Gibbons, and Gardner H. Russell.

The Presiding Bishopric: Robert D. Hales, Henry B. Eyring, and Glenn L. Pace.

Emeritus General Authorities:
Eldred G. Smith, Sterling W. Sill, Henry D. Taylor, Bernard P. Brockbank, Joseph Anderson, and John H. Vandenberg.

Other authorities present

Other Church authorities in attendance included Regional Representatives, presidents of stakes and their

¹President Marion G. Romney was excused due to ill health.

counselors, presidents of temples, bishops of wards, and presidencies and members of the Aaronic and Melchizedek priesthood quorums.

Many general, stake, and ward auxiliary officers also attended.

FIRST DAY MORNING MEETING

FIRST SESSION

The first general session of the 156th Semiannual General Conference convened in the Tabernacle on Temple Square in Salt Lake City, Utah, on Saturday, October 4, 1986, at 10:00 A.M. President Gordon B. Hinckley, First Counselor in the First Presidency, conducted this session.

The music for the opening session was provided by the Mormon Youth Chorus with Robert C. Bowden conducting and Clay Christiansen at the organ.

Prior to the meeting, the Mormon Youth Chorus sang "Hark, All Ye Nations!" without announcement.

President Hinckley made the following remarks:

President Gordon B. Hinckley

With that stirring music we welcome you this morning where is convened the first general session of the 156th Semiannual Conference of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.

We are met in the Tabernacle on Temple Square in Salt Lake City, Utah. Our beloved prophet, President Ezra Taft Benson, who presides at this conference, has asked me to conduct this session.

We welcome all who are participating in the large audience assembled in the Tabernacle and the overflow gatherings in the nearby Assembly Hall, where Elders Theodore M. Burton and Hugh W. Pinnock are

seated on the stand. We also welcome the many others who are receiving these conference proceedings by satellite transmission, radio, cable, and television.

We acknowledge the General Authorities of the Church, all of whom are in attendance except President Marion G. Romney (who recently celebrated his eighty-ninth birthday). We also acknowledge the Relief Society, Young Women, and Primary general presidencies who are seated on the stand. We extend a special welcome to government, education, and civic leaders who are present.

The Mormon Youth Chorus, under the direction of Brother Robert C. Bowden, with Brother Clay Christiansen at the organ, opened this session by singing "Hark, All Ye Nations!" The chorus will now sing "The Lord Is My Shepherd." Following the singing, the invocation will be offered by Elder Hartman Rector, Jr., a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

The chorus sang "The Lord Is My Shepherd."

Elder Hartman Rector, Jr., offered the invocation.

President Hinckley

It will now be our privilege to listen to President Ezra Taft Benson, President of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.

President Ezra Taft Benson

The Book of Mormon: A gift from the Lord

My beloved brethren and sisters, today I would like to speak about one of the most significant gifts given to the world in modern times. The gift I am thinking of is more important than any of the inventions that have come out of the industrial and technological revolutions. This is a gift of greater value to mankind than even the many wonderful advances we have seen in modern medicine. It is of greater worth to mankind than the development of flight or space travel. I speak of the gift of the Book of Mormon, given to mankind 156 years ago.

This gift was prepared by the hand of the Lord over a period of more than a thousand years, then hidden up by Him so that it would be preserved in its purity for our generation. Perhaps there is nothing that testifies more clearly of the importance of this modern book of scripture than what the Lord Himself has said about it.

The Lord's witness of the Book of Mormon

By His own mouth He has borne witness (1) that it is true (D&C 17:6), (2) that it contains the truth and His words (D&C 19:26), (3) that it was translated by power from on high (D&C 20:8), (4) that it contains the fulness of the gospel of Jesus Christ (D&C 20:9, 42:12), (5) that it was given by inspiration and confirmed by the ministering of angels (D&C 20:10), (6) that it gives evidence that the holy scriptures are true (D&C 20:11), and (7) that those who receive it in faith shall receive eternal life (D&C 20:14).

A second powerful testimony to the importance of the Book of Mormon is to note where the Lord placed its coming forth in the timetable of the unfolding Restoration. The only thing that preceded it was the First Vision. In that marvelous manifestation, the

Prophet Joseph Smith learned the true nature of God and that God had a work for him to do. The coming forth of the Book of Mormon was the next thing to follow.

Think of that in terms of what it implies. The coming forth of the Book of Mormon preceded the restoration of the priesthood. It was published just a few days before the Church was organized. The Saints were given the Book of Mormon to read before they were given the revelations outlining such great doctrines as the three degrees of glory, celestial marriage, or work for the dead. It came before priesthood quorums and Church organization. Doesn't this tell us something about how the Lord views this sacred work?

The Lord's warnings

Once we realize how the Lord feels about this book, it should not surprise us that He also gives us solemn warnings about how we receive it. After indicating that those who receive the Book of Mormon with faith, working righteousness, will receive a crown of eternal glory (see D&C 20:14), the Lord follows with this warning: "But those who harden their hearts in unbelief, and reject it, it shall turn to their own condemnation" (D&C 20:15).

In 1829, the Lord warned the Saints that they are not to trifle with sacred things (see D&C 6:12). Surely the Book of Mormon is a sacred thing, and yet many trifle with it, or in other words, take it lightly, treat it as though it is of little importance.

In 1832, as some early missionaries returned from their fields of labor, the Lord reproved them for treating the Book of Mormon lightly. As a result of that attitude, he said, their minds had been darkened. Not only had treating this sacred book lightly brought a loss of light to themselves, it had also brought the whole Church under condemnation, even all the children of

Zion. And then the Lord said, "And they shall remain under this condemnation until they repent and remember the new covenant, even the Book of Mormon" (D&C 84:54-57).

Has the fact that we have had the Book of Mormon with us for over a century and a half made it seem less significant to us today? Do we remember the new covenant, even the Book of Mormon? In the Bible we have the Old Testament and the New Testament. The word *testament* is the English rendering of a Greek word that can also be translated as *covenant*. Is this what the Lord meant when He called the Book of Mormon the "new covenant"? It is indeed another testament or witness of Jesus. This is one of the reasons why we have recently added the words "Another Testament of Jesus Christ" to the title of the Book of Mormon.

If the early Saints were rebuked for treating the Book of Mormon lightly, are we under any less condemnation if we do the same? The Lord Himself bears testimony that it is of eternal significance. Can a small number of us bring the whole Church under condemnation because we trifle with sacred things? What will we say at the Judgment when we stand before Him and meet His probing gaze if we are among those described as forgetting the new covenant?

There are three great reasons why Latter-day Saints should make the study of the Book of Mormon a lifetime pursuit.

Book of Mormon is the keystone

The *first* is that the Book of Mormon is the keystone of our religion. This was the Prophet Joseph Smith's statement. He testified that "the Book of Mormon was the most correct of any book on earth, and the keystone of our religion" (*History of the Church*, 4:461). A keystone is the central stone in an arch. It holds all the other stones in place, and if removed, the arch crumbles.

There are three ways in which the Book of Mormon is the keystone of our religion. It is the keystone in our witness of Christ. It is the keystone of our doctrine. It is the keystone of testimony.

The Book of Mormon is the keystone in our witness of Jesus Christ, who is Himself the cornerstone of everything we do. It bears witness of His reality with power and clarity. Unlike the Bible, which passed through generations of copyists, translators, and corrupt religionists who tampered with the text, the Book of Mormon came from writer to reader in just one inspired step of translation. Therefore, its testimony of the Master is clear, undiluted, and full of power. But it does even more. Much of the Christian world today rejects the divinity of the Savior. They question His miraculous birth, His perfect life, and the reality of His glorious resurrection. The Book of Mormon teaches in plain and unmistakable terms about the truth of all of those. It also provides the most complete explanation of the doctrine of the Atonement. Truly, this divinely inspired book is a keystone in bearing witness to the world that Jesus is the Christ (see title page of the Book of Mormon).

The Book of Mormon is also the keystone of the doctrine of the Resurrection. As mentioned before, the Lord Himself has stated that the Book of Mormon contains the "fulness of the gospel of Jesus Christ" (D&C 20:9). That does not mean it contains every teaching, every doctrine ever revealed. Rather, it means that in the Book of Mormon we will find the fulness of those doctrines required for our salvation. And they are taught plainly and simply so that even children can learn the ways of salvation and exaltation. The Book of Mormon offers so much that broadens our understandings of the doctrines of salvation. Without it, much of what is taught in other scriptures would not be nearly so plain and precious.

Finally, the Book of Mormon is the keystone of testimony. Just as the arch crumbles if the keystone is removed, so does all the Church stand or fall with the truthfulness of the Book of Mormon. The enemies of the Church understand this clearly. This is why they go to such great lengths to try to disprove the Book of Mormon, for if it can be discredited, the Prophet Joseph Smith goes with it. So does our claim to priesthood keys, and revelation, and the restored Church. But in like manner, if the Book of Mormon be true — and millions have now testified that they have the witness of the Spirit that it is indeed true — then one must accept the claims of the Restoration and all that accompanies it.

Yes, my beloved brothers and sisters, the Book of Mormon is the keystone of our religion — the keystone of our testimony, the keystone of our doctrine, and the keystone in the witness of our Lord and Savior.

Book of Mormon written for people of today

The *second* great reason why we must make the Book of Mormon a center focus of study is that it was written for our day. The Nephites never had the book; neither did the Lamanites of ancient times. It was meant for us. Mormon wrote near the end of the Nephite civilization. Under the inspiration of God, who sees all things from the beginning, he abridged centuries of records, choosing the stories, speeches, and events that would be most helpful to us.

Each of the major writers of the Book of Mormon testified that he wrote for future generations. Nephi said: "The Lord God promised unto me that these things which I write shall be kept and preserved, and handed down unto my seed, from generation to generation" (2 Nephi 25:21). His brother Jacob, who succeeded him, wrote similar words: "For [Nephi] said that the history of his people should be engraven upon his other plates, and that I

should preserve these plates and hand them down unto my seed, from generation to generation" (Jacob 1:3). Enos and Jarom both indicated that they too were writing not for their own peoples but for future generations (see Enos 1:15–16, Jarom 1:2).

Mormon himself said, "Yea, I speak unto you, ye remnant of the house of Israel" (Mormon 7:1). And Moroni, the last of the inspired writers, actually saw our day and time. "Behold," he said, "the Lord hath shown unto me great and marvelous things concerning that which must shortly come, at that day when these things shall come forth among you.

"Behold, I speak unto you as if ye were present, and yet ye are not. But behold, Jesus Christ hath shown you unto me, and I know your doing" (Mormon 8:34–35).

If they saw our day and chose those things which would be of greatest worth to us, is not that how we should study the Book of Mormon? We should constantly ask ourselves, "Why did the Lord inspire Mormon (or Moroni or Alma) to include that in his record? What lesson can I learn from that to help me live in this day and age?"

And there is example after example of how that question will be answered. For example, in the Book of Mormon we find a pattern for preparing for the Second Coming. A major portion of the book centers on the few decades just prior to Christ's coming to America. By careful study of that time period, we can determine why some were destroyed in the terrible judgments that preceded His coming and what brought others to stand at the temple in the land of Bountiful and thrust their hands into the wounds of His hands and feet.

From the Book of Mormon we learn how disciples of Christ live in times of war. From the Book of Mormon we see the evils of secret combinations portrayed in graphic and chilling reality. In the Book of Mormon we find lessons for dealing with persecution and apostasy. We learn much about

how to do missionary work. And more than anywhere else, we see in the Book of Mormon the dangers of materialism and setting our hearts on the things of the world. Can anyone doubt that this book was meant for us and that in it we find great power, great comfort, and great protection?

Book of Mormon draws people nearer to God

The *third* reason why the Book of Mormon is of such value to Latter-day Saints is given in the same statement by the Prophet Joseph Smith cited previously. He said, "I told the brethren that the Book of Mormon was the most correct of any book on earth, and the keystone of our religion, and a man would get nearer to God by abiding by its precepts, than by any other book" (*History of the Church*, 4:461). That is the third reason for studying the book. It helps us draw nearer to God. Is there not something deep in our hearts that longs to draw nearer to God, to be more like Him in our daily walk, to feel His presence with us constantly? If so, then the Book of Mormon will help us do so more than any other book.

It is not just that the Book of Mormon teaches us truth, though it indeed does that. It is not just that the Book of Mormon bears testimony of Christ, though it indeed does that, too. But there is something more. There is a power in the book which will begin to flow into your lives the moment you begin a serious study of the book. You will find greater power to resist temptation. You will find the power to avoid deception. You will find the power to stay on the strait and narrow path. The scriptures are called "the words of life" (D&C 84:85), and nowhere is that more true than it is of the Book of Mormon. When you begin to hunger and thirst after those words, you will find life in greater and greater abundance.

Blessings of reading the Book of Mormon

Our beloved brother, President Marion G. Romney, who celebrated his eighty-ninth birthday last month and who knows of himself of the power that resides in this book, testified of the blessings that can come into the lives of those who will read and study the Book of Mormon. He said:

"I feel certain that if, in our homes, parents will read from the Book of Mormon prayerfully and regularly, both by themselves and with their children, the spirit of that great book will come to permeate our homes and all who dwell therein. The spirit of reverence will increase; mutual respect and consideration for each other will grow. The spirit of contention will depart. Parents will counsel their children in greater love and wisdom. Children will be more responsive and submissive to the counsel of their parents. Righteousness will increase. Faith, hope, and charity — the pure love of Christ — will abound in our homes and lives, bringing in their wake peace, joy, and happiness" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1980, p. 90; or *Ensign*, May 1980, p. 67).

These promises — increased love and harmony in the home, greater respect between parent and child, increased spirituality and righteousness — are not idle promises, but exactly what the Prophet Joseph Smith meant when he said the Book of Mormon will help us draw nearer to God.

Response to the Book of Mormon brings eternal consequences

Brethren and sisters, I implore you with all my heart that you consider with great solemnity the importance of the Book of Mormon to you personally and to the Church collectively.

Over ten years ago I made the following statement regarding the Book of Mormon:

"Do eternal consequences rest upon our response to this book? Yes,

either to our blessing or our condemnation.

"Every Latter-day Saint should make the study of this book a lifetime pursuit. Otherwise he is placing his soul in jeopardy and neglecting that which could give spiritual and intellectual unity to his whole life. There is a difference between a convert who is built on the rock of Christ through the Book of Mormon and stays hold of that iron rod, and one who is not" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1975, p. 97; or *Ensign*, May 1975, p. 65).

I reaffirm those words to you this day. Let us not remain under condemnation, with its scourge and judgment, by treating lightly this great and marvelous gift the Lord has given to us. Rather, let us win the promises associated with treasuring it up in our hearts.

In the Doctrine and Covenants, section 84, verses 54 to 58, we read:

"And your minds in times past have been darkened because of unbelief, and because you have treated lightly the things you have received —

"Which vanity and unbelief have brought the whole church under condemnation.

"And this condemnation resteth upon the children of Zion, even all.

"And they shall remain under this condemnation until they repent and remember the new covenant, even the Book of Mormon and the former commandments which I have given them, not only to say, but to do according to that which I have written —

"That they may bring forth fruit meet for their Father's kingdom; otherwise there remaineth a scourge and

judgment to be poured out upon the children of Zion."

Testimonies of Saints who accepted the challenge

Since last general conference, I have received many letters from Saints, both young and old, from all over the world who accepted the challenge to read and study the Book of Mormon.

I have been thrilled by their accounts of how their lives have been changed and how they have drawn closer to the Lord as a result of their commitment. These glorious testimonies have reaffirmed to my soul the words of the Prophet Joseph Smith that the Book of Mormon is truly "the keystone of our religion" and that a man and woman will "get nearer to God by abiding by its precepts, than by any other book."

This is my prayer, that the Book of Mormon may become the keystone of our lives, in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

The chorus sang "The Spirit of God" without announcement.

President Hinckley

President Ezra Taft Benson, President of the Church, has just addressed us, followed by the Mormon Youth Chorus singing "The Spirit of God."

We shall now be pleased to hear from Elder James E. Faust of the Council of the Twelve Apostles.

Elder James E. Faust

Follow the prophet's counsel

I humbly and prayerfully hope that what I have to say will be received in the spirit that I would like to convey. We have just heard the prophet of God. He is a watchman on the tower. He has raised a warning voice. I would urge all

to listen and follow his counsel. It is tremendously important always to be in harmony with those who, according to Paul, have "watch for your souls, as they that must give account, that they may do it with joy, and not with grief" (Hebrews 13:17).

Isaiah spoke of a people who did not care to listen to their prophets and seers, who were urged, "Say to the seers, See not; and to the prophets, Prophesy not unto us right things, speak unto us smooth things, prophesy deceits" (Isaiah 30:10). Nephi explained, "The guilty taketh the truth to be hard, for it cutteth them to the very center" (1 Nephi 16:2).

President Spencer W. Kimball spoke of the duty of prophets. He said:

"I am sure that Peter and James and Paul found it unpleasant business to constantly be calling people to repentance and warning them of dangers, but they continued unflinchingly. So we, your leaders, must be everlastingly at it; if young people do not understand, then the fault may be partly ours. But, if we make the true way clear to you, then we are blameless" (*Love Versus Lust*, Brigham Young University Speeches of the Year, [Provo, 5 Jan. 1965], p. 6).

I wish to speak today of unwanted messages. My purpose in doing so is to attempt to give strength against mistakes, suffering, heartache, and anguish.

Blessing of heeding an unwelcome message

May I begin by sharing with you a personal experience from a time many years ago when I received an unwelcome but valuable message from my devoted father. After World War II was over, I was married and wanted to get on with my life. My memorable mission was finished before my military service. I was not anxious to become a student again and go back to the university where I had started some eight years before. My intended course would require another three years of intensive study, discipline, and poverty. With all of this in mind I said to my father, "I don't think I will go back to school. I'll just get a job or start a business and go forward in my life." Now, my father had completed law school after World War I as an older student with a wife and three children.

His response was typically direct. He said bluntly, "What can you do?" His answer was so brutally honest that it hurt, but I could not ignore it. I went back to the university and completed the course. This frank but well-intentioned message changed my life.

Rich man disregards an unwanted message from Jesus

In the time of Jesus, a certain ruler asked the Savior a very significant question and received a hard answer which he did not want to hear. With the hard answer came a great promise. The meaningful question the rich man asked was, "What shall I do to inherit eternal life?"

Jesus answered, "Thou knowest the commandments, Do not commit adultery, Do not kill, Do not steal, Do not bear false witness, Honour thy father and thy mother."

And the ruler answered, "All these have I kept from my youth up."

The unwelcome answer then came from the Master: "Yet lackest thou one thing: sell all that thou hast, and distribute unto the poor, and thou shalt have treasure in heaven: and come, follow me."

When the ruler heard this, "he was very sorrowful: for he was very rich."

"And when Jesus saw that he was very sorrowful, he said, How hardly shall they that have riches enter into the kingdom of God!" (Luke 18:18, 20-24).

How people handle their earthly riches is among the great tests they have in life.

"New doctrines" taught by Jesus are often unpopular

This same Jesus of Nazareth spoke much novel doctrine which seemed hard to accept. Some said, "What new doctrine is this?" (Mark 1:27). Jesus did not speak of revenge nor of getting even. He spoke of loving our enemies and doing good to them that hate us, of blessing those that curse us, and of

praying for those which despitefully use us (see Luke 6:27-28). He counseled his followers, when smitten on one cheek, to "offer also the other; and him that taketh away thy cloke forbid [him] not to take thy coat also" (Luke 6:28).

Another interesting new doctrine was to go beyond loving only our own and being good just to our friends. Another strange idea Jesus taught was to lend goods and money, hoping for nothing in return. The Master counseled us to be merciful, to judge not and condemn not, and to be kind to the unthankful and to the evil (see Luke 6:34-37). He also spoke of being careful "when all men shall speak well of you" because all men spoke well of the false prophets (Luke 6:26).

The promise for those who can do this is great: "Ye shall be the children of the Highest" (Luke 6:35).

Respect the Sabbath day

May I mention two or three other messages which seem no longer popular? One is to respect the Sabbath day. While the Savior himself cautioned against extreme forms of Sabbath day observance, it is well to remember whose day the Sabbath is. There seems to be an ever-increasing popularity in disregarding the centuries-old commandment to observe and respect the Sabbath day. For many it has become a holiday rather than a holy day of rest and sanctification. For some it is a day to shop and buy groceries. The decision of those who engage in shopping, sports, work, and recreation on the Sabbath day is their own, for which they alone bear responsibility.

The Lord's commandment about the Sabbath day has not been altered, nor has the Church's affirmation of the commandment to observe the Sabbath day. Those who violate this commandment in the exercise of their agency are answerable for losing the blessings which observance of this commandment would bring. The Lord has spoken in our day concerning the Sabbath

day. We are to keep ourselves "unspotted from the world" and "go to the house of prayer." We are to rest from our labors and pay our "devotions unto the Most High" (D&C 59:9-10). The Doctrine and Covenants reminds us: "And on this day thou shalt do none other thing, only let thy food be prepared with singleness of heart that thy fasting may be perfect, or, in other words, that thy joy may be full" (D&C 59:13). The blessings for those who do righteousness are supernal. They shall enjoy "peace in this world, and eternal life in the world to come" (D&C 59:23).

Honor parents

Another transcendent but often unheeded message which peals down from Sinai is "Honour thy father and thy mother" (Exodus 20:12). I have frequently walked by a rest home that provides excellent care. But it is heart-rending to see so many parents and grandparents in that good care facility so forgotten, so bereft of dignity, so starved for love. To honor parents certainly means to take care of physical needs. But it means much, much more. It means to show love, kindness, thoughtfulness, and concern for them all of the days of their lives. It means to help them preserve their dignity and self-respect in their declining years. It means to honor their wishes and desires and their teachings both before and after they are dead.

Some years ago I created a stake on one of the islands in Japan. As usual, we held many interviews with the leaders to become acquainted with them. One of the men had moved to that area from Tokyo to take care of his aged and ailing father and his father's business, which was in difficulty because of the father's ill health. After the father died, the son went to his father's creditors and acknowledged his father's debts. He requested time from those creditors so that he could assume and pay all of his father's outstanding obligations. In our interview I asked him how he was

managing to meet this responsibility. He answered that he was getting along quite well and that he would be able to handle his father's debts. The Lord saw fit to call him to be one of the leaders of that stake.

Besides being one of God's commandments, the kind, thoughtful consideration of parents is a matter of common decency and self-respect. On their part, parents need to live so as to be worthy of the respect of their children.

I cannot help wondering about parents who adopt the attitude with their children, "do as I say, not as I do" with respect to using harmful substances, going to inappropriate movies, and other questionable activities. Children often take license from their parents' behavior and go beyond the values the parents wish to establish. There is one safe parental rule: do not just avoid evil, avoid the very appearance of evil (see 1 Thessalonians 5:22).

Deal honestly with others

I should like to speak of one more strong message. It is frequently astounding to see the dereliction of people in keeping the standards of ordinary fairness and justice. This delinquency manifests itself in so many ways. It is sometimes evident in commercial transactions, as well as in private contacts. Injustice to others is manifest even in the way automobiles are sometimes driven. This unfairness and injustice results principally from one person seeking an advantage or an edge over another. Those who follow such a practice demean themselves greatly. How can those of us who do not practice ordinary fairness and justice have serious claim on the blessings of a just and a fair God?

Do some of us seek to justify our taking of shortcuts and advantage of others by indulging in the twin sophistries, "There isn't any justice" and "Everybody does it"? There are many others who seemingly prosper by violating the rules of God and the stan-

dards of decency and fair play. They appear to escape the imminent law of the harvest, which states, "Whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap" (Galatians 6:7). Worrying about the punishment we think ought to come to others is self-defeating to us. Brigham Young counseled that unless we ourselves are prepared for the day of the Lord's vengeance when the wicked will be consumed, we should not be too anxious for the Lord to hasten his work. Said he rather, "Let our anxiety be centred upon this one thing, the sanctification of our own hearts, the purifying of our own affections" (in *Journal of Discourses*, 9:3).

Avoid rationalization

Many modern professors of human behavior advocate as a cure to an afflicted conscience that we simply ignore the unwanted messages. They suggest that we change the standard to fit the circumstances so that there is no longer a conflict, thus easing the conscience. The followers of the divine Christ cannot subscribe to this evil and perverse philosophy with impunity. For the troubled conscience in conflict with right and wrong, the only permanent help is to change the behavior and follow a repentant path.

The prophet Isaiah taught, "Woe unto them that call evil good, and good evil; that put darkness for light, and light for darkness; that put bitter for sweet, and sweet for bitter!" (Isaiah 5:20).

During all of my ministry, I have been fascinated by the manner in which Jesus hardened the bone and spirit of his chief Apostle, Peter. When Jesus told Peter that he had prayed that Peter's faith would strengthen, Peter affirmed that he would go with the Savior to prison or to death. Peter was then told that the "cock shall not crow this day, before that thou shalt thrice deny that thou knowest me" (Luke 22:34). After the predicted three denials, the powerful, unwelcome, but steel-hardening message came: Peter

heard the cock crow. "And he went out, and wept bitterly" (Matthew 26:75), but this strengthened Peter to fulfill his calling and to die for the cause.

Listen to the still, small voice for life-changing messages

There is one unerring voice that is ever true. It can always be relied upon. It should be listened to, although at times this voice too may speak unwelcome warning messages. I speak of the still, small, inner voice which comes from the divine source. As the prophet Elijah learned, "the Lord was not in the wind; and after the wind an earthquake; but the Lord was not in the earthquake:

"And after the earthquake a fire; but the Lord was not in the fire; and after the fire a still small voice" (1 Kings 19:11-12).

One single unwanted message may be a call to change our lives; it may lead to the specially tailored opportunity we need. I am grateful that it is

never too late to change, to make things right, to leave old activities and habits behind.

I wish to testify that the prophetic messages of this conference will lead any who will listen — and follow the counsel given — to the promise of the Savior, which is peace in this life and eternal life in the world hereafter. I so testify in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

Elder James E. Faust of the Council of the Twelve Apostles has just spoken to us.

The chorus and congregation will now join in singing "Put Your Shoulder to the Wheel," following which Elder Marion D. Hanks, a member of the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy, will speak to us.

The chorus and congregation sang "Put Your Shoulder to the Wheel."

Elder Marion D. Hanks

Importance of daily decisions

In the early days of the Restoration, the Lord commanded one of his servants to "declare glad tidings" and to do this "with all humility, trusting in me, reviling not against revilers" (D&C 19:29-30). In the constructive spirit of that directive, I desire to bear my testimony this morning about the vital effect in our lives and the lives of others of the day-by-day decisions all of us are making — and where we can find help in making them.

A teacher once wrote of the unanticipated consequences of some of our decisions. We didn't really ever intend those consequences, but we followed the paths that led to them. "He who chooses the beginning of a road chooses the place it leads to," he said. "He who picks up one end of a stick,

picks up the other." And it is not only our own course we are affecting when we choose the beginning of a road; we inevitably travel with others, and sometimes we bring anguish and distress to those we love and to other innocent persons.

Agency a peril and a privilege

Over this pulpit President David O. McKay taught us:

"Next to the bestowal of life itself, the right to direct that life is God's greatest gift to man. . . . Freedom of choice is more to be treasured than any possession earth can give" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1950, p. 32).

The oppressing presence of problems all about us — personal, family, and in our society — accentuates the

peril as well as the privilege of free agency. The ancient Psalmist surely seems to be singing to our time: "Have mercy upon me, O Lord, for I am in trouble" (Psalm 31:9).

Why is there so much trouble? "With all that fairway, why do we spend so much time in the rough?" someone said.

Part of the answer is that without opposition and testing, free agency loses its meaning. Opposition, tribulation, afflictions, the refining fire are part of the eternal plan.

Choose sound sources of guidance

Much that happens to us in this life we cannot control; we only respond. But much of the pain we suffer and inevitably impose upon others is self-induced through our own bad judgment, through poor choices. Where can we look for help?

The ancient prophet Micah perhaps surprisingly seemed to rule out the nearest and most normal sources of assistance — family, friends, and leaders. Some of us have perhaps experienced a measure of the deep disappointment he felt because of Israel's rebelliousness when he declared that "the good man is perished out of the earth" (Micah 7:2). He spoke of princes and judges asking for rewards, and of great men uttering "mischievous desire" (v. 3). For Micah, the source of help was clear and sure: "Therefore I will look unto the Lord," he said. "I will wait for the God of my salvation: my God will hear me" (v. 7).

Jeremiah warned "the man that trusteth in man, and maketh flesh his arm, and whose heart departeth from the Lord" (Jeremiah 17:5). Other prophets have similarly spoken.

Does this mean that we may never have confidence in the integrity of others? Must we never trust parents or friends or caring counselors or humble servants of God? This is obviously not the meaning of the scriptures, which

themselves are the record of revelation and inspired instruction; what they are emphasizing is the *care* we must exercise in *choosing* counsel or example.

Beware of unwholesome sources of guidance

There is accessible, for those who will accommodate it, much that is *not* uplifting or wholesome, which sometimes seems so perverse in its portrayal of marriage, and of the family, and of personal integrity that the undiscerning might be led to believe that this is the normal way for people or families or neighborhoods to behave.

Only last week a comment was made by an assistant United States attorney general after she had witnessed a popular play in which drug use was made to appear acceptable and even desirable: "We perpetuate the falsehood that drugs make you cute, bold, insightful, philosophical or chic," she said (Lois Haight Herrington, quoted by Godfrey Sperling, Jr., "Tolerance for Drugs Is Undermining U.S. 'War' Commitment," *Deseret News*, 24 Sept. 1986, sec. A, p. 9). And a columnist, in quoting her, added an interesting line: "Our society still sanctions the use of alcohol. There is really no more dangerous drug — and certainly none that has done more damage or wrecked more lives over the years — than alcohol" (Sperling, sec. A, p. 9).

Seek help from the Lord

But most of us also have available sound sources of wise guidance if we will look for them. There is great power in trust and love, and, of course, we must learn to trust because our confidence in the integrity of man supports our confidence in God. Yet, in matters of lasting importance, one must not rely only on "the arm of flesh" at the expense of looking to the Lord in scripture and in prayer.

Perils of immature, thoughtless choices

In World War II, I had an experience aboard a United States naval vessel in the South Pacific that was a powerful example of the virtue of wise choices and the peril of making decisions that are immature or impetuous, or are made in the heat of emotion, or that go thoughtlessly along with the crowd.

The young man aboard my ship was obviously special. He was modest and able and promising, and it was a blessing to be with him on the few occasions when our particular duties during wartime made it possible to be together.

But circumstance dictated that much more of the time and attention of my young associate was spent with others with whom he worked intimately in the compressed life of a crew aboard a ship at sea. These associates had lifestyles and a view of values that were far removed from those to which this choice lad was accustomed. Gradually, the circumstances and the daily pressures began to take their toll on a not yet fully stable young man.

One day in a far-off port, I observed him almost furtively preparing to go ashore in the company of some of those experienced individuals who were taking him into town for one of their "good times," as they supposed. In the navy, these periods off duty were ironically called "liberty."

I had a brief moment with him as he went over the gangway and tried to warn him that this adventure was perilous and that these men meant him no good. His furtiveness turned to defiance, and he plainly told me that he was a big boy now, able to make up his own mind, and that he would do as he chose.

The consequences of the decisions he made that day — and those that were made for him when, through their iniquitous "help," he had lost the power to think for himself or govern his own behavior — were different than he ever intended or could imagine. In his im-

maturity, he rebelliously chose the beginning of a road without thinking where that road would lead him. The place at which he arrived in the next few hours was one which he would never in his right mind have chosen.

When he returned to the ship, overleave overseas in wartime, out of control, and in custody of the shore patrol, he became subject to severe discipline. I cannot forget his tearful anguish as he awaited his ordeal. He could not even remember anything of the most serious of the tragedies that had occurred to him. All he could recall was lifting a glass they pressed on him, not knowing that they had drugged the drink, and then all was blank. They had proceeded to take him on their rounds with them.

The charges against him, indelibly imprinted on his previously perfect service record, were heartbreaking. I won't forget his tearful anguish as he said over and over, "What will I tell my mom? What will I tell my girl?"

He had time now — and the disposition to listen and to think. We read together the sweet counsel of the Lord concerning Christ's atoning sacrifice and his mission of redemption and of forgiveness and mercy (see Alma 42).

Beware of those who wield evil influence

About two thousand years ago, the Apostle Peter wrote in remarkable detail of our times and what is transpiring in them as individuals, young and old, are sometimes led into tragedy by others who have no wholesome interest in their happiness or their future. These "others," and the results of their evil influence, are clearly described. I pray that some who sorely need it, or some who can help those who sorely need it, will hear these remarkable words. They come from the book of 2 Peter, chapter 2:

"The Lord knoweth how to deliver the godly out of temptations, and to reserve the *unjust* unto the day of judgment. . . .

"But chiefly them that walk after the flesh in the lust of uncleanness, and despise government. Presumptuous are they, selfwilled, they are not afraid to speak evil of dignities, . . .

" . . . of the things that they understand not; . . .

"Having eyes full of adultery, and that cannot cease from sin; beguiling unstable souls: . . .

"These are wells without water, clouds that are carried with a tempest; . . .

"For when they speak great swelling words of vanity, they allure through the lusts of the flesh, through much wantonness, those that were clean escaped from them who live in error.

"While they promise them liberty, they themselves are the servants of corruption: for of whom a man is overcome, of the same is he brought in bondage" (vs. 9-10, 12, 14, 17-19; italics added).

I have never been able to refer to these powerful words without thinking about a clean young man of strong promise who followed bad counsel and bad example into tragedy, with compromise to conscience and with heartbreak to himself and to those who loved him. We cannot with impunity follow the example or heed the counsels of unwisdom or unrighteousness, or of ignorance or immaturity or ego or greed or bravado.

Consequences of evil

There is no bravery in evil, no true courage in behavior that can only result in deep disappointment. There is no lasting joy in the euphoria resulting from substances taken into our bodies which ultimately sabotage our self-control, and overcome our capacity to think for ourselves, and move us to act in ways incompatible with our best understanding.

Reasons to seek the Lord's counsel

We see much that is glorious and reassuring in good human beings, but mortal men have limitations. None of us has ever met a mortal in whom we could comfortably rest our salvation. Only one qualifies for that trust, and he is the Holy One of Israel. His love for us was and is so great that he volunteered for the unspeakable burden of carrying the weight of our sins. He is our Mediator and our Advocate with the Father. The prophet Micah spoke truthfully and faithfully long ago when, in a time of great trouble, he testified: "I will look unto the Lord; I will wait for the God of my salvation: my God will hear me" (Micah 7:7).

All of us have much to learn and need good counsel. And beyond sound human help, beyond the "arm of flesh," it is written, "Counsel with the Lord in all thy doings, and he will direct thee for good" (Alma 37:37). "He will console you in your afflictions, and he will plead your cause" (Jacob 3:1).

Mormon's last words to his son are my prayer for my children and grandchildren also, and for the children of men everywhere:

"My son, be faithful in Christ; and may not the things which I have written grieve thee, to weigh thee down unto death; but may Christ lift thee up, and may his sufferings and death, and [resurrection], . . . and his mercy and long-suffering, and the hope of his glory and of eternal life, rest in your mind forever" (Moroni 9:25).

In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

The chorus sang "Sweet Hour of Prayer" without announcement.

President Hinckley

Elder Marion D. Hanks, a member of the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy, has addressed us,

followed by the Mormon Youth Chorus singing "Sweet Hour of Prayer."

Elder Marvin J. Ashton of the Council of the Twelve Apostles will be our next speaker.

Elder Marvin J. Ashton

Bad habits bind like chains

Some years ago I had an acquaintance who had allowed himself to become a compulsive user of alcohol. He drank before he had dinner, and he would have what he called a "bracer" before involving himself in major business decisions. During a routine physical examination one day, a doctor told him that, for the good of his health, he should break the drinking habit. When I asked him what he intended to do, he said, "That's easy. I'll just change doctors."

Another acquaintance is a lovely, well-educated woman who has been a very heavy smoker. She now tells us of a few times she even woke her husband up in the middle of the night and insisted that he go to an all-night store to get her a pack of cigarettes. This couple came in contact with the missionaries, believed their message, and joined the Church. When she knew she had to quit smoking, the woman almost immediately threw off the chains of this habit and became free of tobacco addiction.

As I have been rereading the Book of Mormon, following the counsel of President Ezra Taft Benson, our beloved prophet, I have been even more impressed with the counsel father Lehi gave his family shortly before his death. He pleads with his sons with these words:

"Awake, my sons; put on the armor of righteousness. Shake off the chains with which ye are bound, and come forth out of obscurity, and arise from the dust" (2 Nephi 1:23).

Bad habits impede happiness and growth

Those words apply to us today. Who among us hasn't felt the chains

of bad habits? These habits may have impeded our progress, may have made us forget who we are, may have destroyed our self-image, may have put our family life in jeopardy, and may have hindered our ability to serve our fellowmen and our God. So many of us tend to say, "This is the way I am. I can't change. I can't throw off the chains of habit."

Lehi warned his sons to "shake off the chains" because he knew that chains restrict our mobility, growth, and happiness. They cause us to become confused and less able to be guided by God's Spirit. Lehi also reminded his sons that their new land should "be a land of liberty unto them; wherefore, they shall never be brought down into captivity; if so, it shall be because of iniquity" (2 Nephi 1:7). He could have said, "If so, it shall be because ye have been bound into captivity by the chains of unrighteous living." Samuel Johnson wisely shared, "The chains of habit are . . . too small to be felt until they are too strong to be broken" (*International Dictionary of Thoughts*, comp. John P. Bradley [Chicago: J. G. Ferguson Publishing Co., 1969], p. 348).

The lady of whom I spoke was able to break the chains of a bad habit because she became committed to change. Some of the Lamanites under King Lamoni were able to break the chains of their iniquities of murder, indolence, and hatred when they were taught by Ammon. They became even more valiant than the Nephites because they became committed to righteousness.

Righteous living is a shield, a protector, an insulation, a strength, a power, a joy, a Christlike trait. Yes,

living a life of righteousness is a chain-breaker.

Many of us today are shackled by the restrictive chains of poor habits. We are bound by inferior self-images created by misconduct and indifference. We are chained by an unwillingness to change for the better. Is it any wonder, in our day as it was in Nephi's, that God's pleas are "awake," "listen," "procrastinate no longer," "believe me," "come back," and "seek the straight course"?

This catchy couplet fits so many of us. "Procrastination is a silly thing, it only brings me sorrow, but I can change at any time! I think I will — tomorrow!"

Shaking off restrictive chains requires action. They cannot be wished away. A declaration will never break chains. It requires commitment, self-discipline, and work.

Chains weigh heavily on troubled hearts and souls. They relegate us to lives of no purpose or light. They cause us to become confused and lose the spirit. We need to arise from the dust and enjoy the fresh air of righteousness. We need to move forward in patience, understanding, love, and never-ending commitment.

Chains of unrighteous dominion

Sometimes the chains of arrogance and domination cause priesthood bearers to lose their way and stumble. No man in The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints is worthy of his priesthood powers and blessings if he makes unrighteous demands upon his wife or family. God forbid that any man would find satisfaction or comfort in exercising this type of domination.

"No power or influence can or ought to be maintained by virtue of the priesthood, only by persuasion, by long-suffering, by gentleness and meekness, and by love unfeigned" (D&C 121:41).

Let me share some chains I have recently observed in the lives of some friends, chains that are causing mis-

direction, family destruction, loss of self-respect, and sadness.

Chains of drug abuse

I am thinking of a young husband and father who is participating in drug abuse. He stands to lose family, employment, personal pride, and his own life. His cries of "I'm hooked" tug at the soul. The use of cocaine and other drugs causes those involved to become totally chained to their addiction. Those who peddle drugs not only provide chains for others, but shackle themselves with the weights of unrighteousness as well. To those not involved, avoid drugs in any form with all of your might. To those involved, seek help to remove the chains that will drag you down and smother you. Drugs are not a "quick fix." They are a quick exit through a door which too often swings only one way — toward heartache and self-destruction.

Believe me when I tell you that some of the saddest sights I have ever witnessed in my life are people living with drug addiction. They are prisoners within their own bodies. Many feel totally helpless, dependent, and desperate. But none should feel hopeless. Lift those chains and fight back for personal dignity, peace, and purpose. Anyone who tells you drug use is the "fun" way is a liar.

Any judge who allows convicted drug peddlers to go their ways with only light penalties isn't worthy of his office.

Chains of murmuring and gossip

I am acquainted with a wife and mother who is chained securely at the present time to a life-style of murmuring and criticism. She is the first to point out faults in her husband or to repeat neighborhood gossip. How damaging is a habit that permits fault-finding, character assassination, and the sharing of malicious rumors! Gossip and caustic comments often create chains of contention. These chains may

appear to be very small, but what misery and woe they can cause!

"O that ye would awake; awake from a deep sleep, yea, even from the sleep of hell, and shake off the awful chains by which ye are bound, which are the chains which bind the children of men, that they are carried away captive down to the eternal gulf of misery and woe" (2 Nephi 1:13).

Chains of indifference

Listen to the words of a friend who understands well the meaning of this scripture, a man who was bound by the chains of indifference. But when he sought God's help and turned to righteous principles, those chains were not only broken, but smashed. This letter was received a few weeks ago.

"I was baptized into the Church in March of 1974. At the time, I was employed in a job that required my having to work on Sundays. This, combined with my lack of strength in the gospel, prevented me from becoming an active and faithful member of the Church. Over the years I neglected my daily study and prayers. Throughout this time in my life I drifted farther and farther from the Church and the teachings of the gospel. This neglect brought disappointment after disappointment to myself and my family. I was discouraged, disillusioned, and I lacked self-respect and confidence.

"On the afternoon of April 6, 1986, my wife was scanning through the TV channels in search of something to pass away another lazy Sunday afternoon when she came across the Sunday afternoon session of general conference about to begin. We decided to watch and see what was going on as we had lost complete contact with the Church, and I, frankly, could not have told you who the prophet was at the time.

"The message I listened to was a gift from my Heavenly Father, one that would turn my life around. The message stayed with me for the next couple of days. I commented to my wife how much better I felt about myself and my

relationship with others as a result of simply applying some recommended principles. We have since returned to a faithful and active involvement in our ward."

What a blessing it is to rise from the dust and the chains of indifference.

Change requires commitment and courage

One may ask, "What must I do to break the chains that bind me and lead me away from the path our Savior would have us follow?" These chains cannot be broken by those who live in lust and self-deceit. They can only be broken by people who are willing to change. We must face up to the hard reality of life that damaging chains are broken only by people of courage and commitment who are willing to struggle and weather the pain.

It is true some people do not want to change, even though they may say they do. Only you can supply the motivation, and only you can decide to change. The Church, the home, the family, friends, and those professionally trained can aid, support, encourage, empathize, and guide, but the work of change belongs to the person. Most often, it is plain hard work.

To change or break some of our chains even in a small way means to give up some behavior or habits that have been very important to us in the past. Generally this is frightening. Change involves risks. "How will people react and respond to me if I change and am different?" Even if our present way of life is painful and self-destructive, some of us think it serves a purpose, and so we become comfortable with it.

Every worthy change means risk—the risk of losing an old and damaging habit for a new and improved way of life.

If fear and an unwillingness to take the risk and challenge of the better way of life gain the upper hand, we will not be able to change. Shakespeare in *Measure for Measure* says it this way:

"Our doubts are traitors, and make us lose the good we oft might win, by fearing to attempt" (act 1, scene 4, lines 77-79).

Seek God's help to gain courage to change

Even the chains of fear can be broken by those who will humbly seek God's help and strength. It can be done with this strengthening promise in Doctrine and Covenants 122:4: "Because of thy righteousness . . . thy God shall stand by thee forever and ever."

A truly wise person will constantly move forward, striving for self-improvement, knowing that daily repentance is needed for progress. He will realize the good life is simply conforming to a standard of right and justice. The joys of happiness can only be realized by living lofty principles.

Those who are committed to improvement break chains by having the courage to try. Those who live without commitment mistakenly think it is eas-

ier to adapt their life-styles to the weight and restrictions of chains rather than to put forth the effort to change.

God help us to shake off and break the chains with which we are bound. With God's help they can be shaken off by faith, works, prayer, constant commitment, and self-discipline. May we have the will and strength to shake off the chains that would control and destroy our progress, I pray in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

The chorus sang "Oh, What Songs of the Heart" without announcement.

President Hinckley

Elder Marvin J. Ashton has spoken to us, and the chorus has sung "Oh, What Songs of the Heart."

Elder Boyd K. Packer of the Council of the Twelve Apostles will be our concluding speaker for this session.

Elder Boyd K. Packer

A child's innocence

Some years ago, Dr. Faun Hunsaker, then president of the Southern States Mission, was invited to stay at the home of a member. He arrived after the children were in bed.

He occupied the parents' bedroom, and during the night heard the door open and the sound of little feet. A little boy frightened by a bad dream had come to his parents' bed for comfort.

Sensing that something was different, the little boy felt Brother Hunsaker's face. So he spoke quietly to the child. The startled youngster said, "You're not my daddy!"

"No, I'm not your daddy."

"Did my daddy say you could sleep here?"

"Yes, your daddy said I could sleep here."

With that the little youngster crawled into bed with Brother Hunsaker and was soon asleep.

I might well conclude with that lesson on the trust of a little child. Nevertheless, without apology, I intend to moralize about innocence and our obligation to little children.

Scriptural teachings about children

There is much in the scriptures about little children.

The Psalmist wrote, "Children are an heritage of the Lord" (Psalm 127:3).

The Savior gave the ever-familiar plea, "Suffer the little children to come unto me, and forbid them not: for of such is the kingdom of heaven" (Mark 10:14).

When His disciples asked, "Who is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven? . . . Jesus called a little child

unto him, and set him in the midst of them, and said, . . . Whosoever . . . shall humble himself as this little child, the same is greatest in the kingdom of heaven. And whoso shall receive one such little child in my name receiveth me" (Matthew 18:1-5).

Then came this warning: "But whoso shall offend one of these little ones which believe in me, it were better for him that a millstone were hanged about his neck, and that he were drowned in the depth of the sea" (v. 6).

To me, the most impressive lesson is in the Book of Mormon.

Jesus "commanded that their little children should be brought.

"So they brought their little children and set them down upon the ground round about him, and Jesus stood in the midst; . . .

" . . . He commanded the multitude that they should kneel down upon the ground.

"And it came to pass that when they had knelt upon the ground, Jesus groaned within himself, and said: Father, I am troubled because of the wickedness of the people of the house of Israel. . . .

" . . . He himself also knelt upon the earth; and behold he prayed unto the Father, and the things which he prayed cannot be written, . . .

"And no tongue can speak, neither can there be written by any man, neither can the hearts of men conceive so great and marvelous things as [they] both saw and heard Jesus speak; . . .

"And they arose from the earth, and he said unto them: Blessed are ye because of your faith. And now behold, my joy is full.

"And when he had said these words, he wept, and the multitude bare record of it, and he took their little children, one by one, and blessed them, and prayed unto the Father for them.

"And when he had done this he wept again;

"And he . . . said unto them: Behold your little ones. . . .

" . . . And they saw the heavens open, and they saw angels descending

out of heaven as it were in the midst of fire; and they came down and encircled those little ones about, and they were encircled about with fire; and the angels did minister unto them" (3 Nephi 17:11-15, 17, 20-24).

There is more, much more, in the scriptures about little children.

Transgressions against children

There is a sorry side to this subject as well. I wish not to dwell on that beyond listing four transgressions which plague mankind, all of which inflict suffering upon little children.

First, that consummate physical union of man and woman belonging to the marriage covenant is now falsely proclaimed an acceptable indulgence for any two adults.

Second, the misuse of that procreative power in degraded acts of perversion is widely promoted as the right of consenting adults. This selfish behavior carries neither the responsibility nor the rewards of parenthood.

Third, the deliberate destruction of the innocent and helpless by abortion is now widely fostered—even publicly funded.

Fourth, the bodies and minds and morals of increasing numbers of little children are brutalized and abused by those who should protect them.

In it all, mankind has sown a bitter wind and reaps heartbreak, guilt, abandonment, divorce, addiction, disease, and death; and little children suffer.

If these sins remain unchecked, civilization will be led unfailingly to destruction.

Beliefs affect behavior toward children

Our behavior is not totally controlled by natural impulses. Behavior begins with belief as well.

Beliefs are born of philosophies, of doctrines. Doctrines can be spiritual or secular, wholesome or destructive, true or false.

Two doctrines misrepresent the status of little children. Each is widely accepted. Both are false!

False belief of infant baptism

The first holds that little children are conceived in sin and enter mortality in a state of natural corruption. That doctrine is false!

Each time a child is born, the world is renewed in innocence.

The revelations teach us that "the glory of God is intelligence, or, in other words, light and truth.

"Light and truth forsake that evil one.

"Every spirit of man was *innocent* in the beginning; and God having redeemed man from the fall, men became again, in their infant state, *innocent* before God.

"And that wicked one cometh and taketh away light and truth, through disobedience, from the children of men, and because of the tradition of their fathers.

"But I have commanded you to bring up your children in light and truth" (D&C 93:36-40; italics added).

Mormon taught this doctrine to his son Moroni and hence to us. I can present only a few sentences from his letter.

"If I have learned the truth," Mormon wrote, "there have been disputations among you concerning the baptism of your little children" (Moroni 8:5).

He called their disputation "gross error" and wrote: "Immediately after I had learned these things of you I inquired of the Lord concerning the matter. And the word of the Lord came to me by the power of the Holy Ghost, saying:

"Listen to the words of Christ, your Redeemer, your Lord and your God. Behold, I came into the world not to call the righteous but sinners to repentance; the whole need no physician, but they that are sick; wherefore, little children are whole, for they are not capable of committing sin; wherefore

the curse of Adam is taken from them in me, that it hath no power over them; . . .

"And after this manner did the Holy Ghost manifest the word of God unto me; wherefore, my beloved son, I know that it is solemn mockery before God, that ye should baptize little children" (Moroni 8:7-9).

Mormon told Moroni to teach repentance and baptism to "those who are accountable and capable of committing sin" (Moroni 8:10).

Eight is established by revelation as the age of accountability (see D&C 68:27).

Then, in sternness unsurpassed in scripture, Mormon warned:

"He that supposeth that little children need baptism is in the gall of bitterness and in the bonds of iniquity; for he hath neither faith, hope, nor charity; wherefore, should he be cut off while in the thought, he must go down to hell.

"For awful is the wickedness to suppose that God saveth one child because of baptism, and the other must perish because he hath no baptism.

"Wo be unto them that shall pervert the ways of the Lord after this manner, for they shall perish except they repent. Behold, I speak with boldness, having authority from God" (Moroni 8:14-16).

Read his entire epistle. It is true doctrine. It will inspire a reverence for little children. Thereafter, who could even think to neglect, much less to abuse one of them?

Study and obey God's laws

True doctrine, understood, changes attitudes and behavior.

The study of the doctrines of the gospel will improve behavior quicker than a study of behavior will improve behavior. Preoccupation with unworthy behavior can lead to unworthy behavior. That is why we stress so forcefully the study of the doctrines of the gospel.

The laws of God on marriage, birth, and nurturing of little children

may seem rigid, but they are very practical.

His law decrees that the only legitimate union of man and woman is between husband and wife. For, should that expression of love result in conception, marriage provides shelter for the child who enters mortality innocent and helpless. Marriage ensures security and happiness for parents as well.

Whatever the laws of man may come to tolerate, the misuse of the power of procreation, the destroying of innocent life through abortion, and the abuse of little children are transgressions of enormous proportion. For cradled therein rests the destiny of innocent, helpless children.

False belief that man is not a child of God

Another doctrine, equally false and widely accepted, also misrepresents the status of little children. Let me illustrate.

Years ago, two of our sons, then little fellows, were wrestling on the rug. They reached that line which separates laughter from tears, so I worked my foot carefully between them and lifted the older one back to a sitting position on the rug. As I did so, I said, "Hey there, you little monkeys. You'd better settle down."

To my surprise, he folded his little arms, his eyes swimming with deep hurt, and protested, "I not a monkey, Daddy; I a *person*!"

The years have not erased the overwhelming feeling of love I felt for my little boys. Many times over the years his words have slipped back into my mind, "I not a monkey, Daddy; I a *person*!" I was taught a profound lesson by my little son.

He is not just a person, nor just my little boy. He is a child of God.

The cycle of life has moved swiftly on. Now both of those sons have little children of their own who teach their fathers lessons. They now watch their children grow as we watched them. They are coming to

know, as fathers, something they could not be taught as sons.

All too soon their children will be grown with little "persons" of their own, repeating the endless cycle of life.

Perhaps now they understand what it means to begin our prayers, as the Lord instructed, "Our Father who art in heaven." He is our father; we are His children.

This secular doctrine holds that man is not a child of God, but basically an animal, his behavior inescapably controlled by natural impulse, exempt from moral judgments and unaccountable for moral conduct.

While many claim that this philosophy could not, in the end, lead mankind to relaxed moral behavior, *something* causes it! Is it accidental that the more widely such secular doctrines are believed, the more prevalent immoral behavior becomes?

Secular philosophy versus sacred doctrine

They defend their philosophy with collected data and say, "It is now proven to be true. Look at all the evidence on our side."

We in turn point to the sorry way in which mankind degrades procreation and the attendant suffering of both children and adults and say, "Look at all the evidence on our side."

Secular doctrines have the advantage of convincing, tangible evidence. We seem to do better in gathering data on things that can be counted and measured.

Doctrines which originate in the light, on the other hand, are more often supported by intangible impressions upon the spirit. We are left for the most part to rely on *faith*.

But, in time, the consequences of following either will become visible enough.

Adults should repent

To you adults who repeat the pattern of neglect and abuse you endured

as little children, believing that you are entrapped in a cycle of behavior from which there is no escape, I say:

It is contrary to the order of heaven for any soul to be locked into compulsive, immoral behavior with no way out!

It is consistent with the workings of the adversary to deceive you into believing that you *are*.

I gratefully acknowledge that transgressions, even those which affect little children, yield to sincere repentance. I testify with all my soul that the doctrine of repentance is true and has a miraculous, liberating effect upon behavior.

Children should forgive

To you *innocent* ones who have not transgressed, but were abused as little children and still carry an undeserved burden of guilt, I say:

Learn true doctrine — repentance and forgiveness; lay that burden of guilt down!

For we are all children of the same Heavenly Father. May not each of his children, of any age, claim the redeeming sacrifice of Jesus Christ, and in so doing, through complete repentance, be cleansed and renewed to childlike innocence?

I said at the beginning that I might well conclude with the account of that trusting little child. I think I will do just that:

"You're not my daddy."

"No, I'm not your daddy."

"Did my daddy say you could sleep here?"

"Yes, your daddy said I could sleep here."

With that, the little boy was soon safely asleep in his arms.

God grant that all little children will be safe with every one of us because their Father and their God and our Father and our God said we could be here. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

Elder Boyd K. Packer has just spoken to us.

We express appreciation to the managers and operators of the many television and radio stations and cable systems for offering their facilities as a public service to bring the proceedings of this conference to a large and appreciative audience in many areas of the world.

The Mormon Youth Chorus will now sing "On This Day of Joy and Gladness," following which the benediction will be given by Elder Keith W. Wilcox of the First Quorum of the Seventy, and this conference will be adjourned until two o'clock this afternoon.

The chorus sang "On This Day of Joy and Gladness."

Elder Keith W. Wilcox offered the benediction.

FIRST DAY AFTERNOON MEETING

SECOND SESSION

The second general session of the 156th Semiannual General Conference convened in the Tabernacle on Temple Square in Salt Lake City, Utah, on Saturday, October 4, 1986, at 2:00 P.M.

President Thomas S. Monson, Second Counselor in the First Presidency, conducted this session.

Music for this session was provided by the Murray Region Family Choir, under the direction of Owen Clark with John Longhurst at the organ.

At the beginning of the meeting, President Thomas S. Monson made the following remarks:

President Thomas S. Monson

My beloved brethren and sisters, President Ezra Taft Benson has asked that I conduct this, the second general session of the 156th Semiannual General Conference of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.

We note that Elders J. Thomas Fyans and Derek A. Cuthbert are seated on the stand in the Assembly Hall.

We welcome all who are in attendance or who are participating by means of television, cable, or radio, and many who are watching in stake centers throughout the United States, Canada, and Puerto Rico, to which the conference is being carried by satellite transmission.

We are pleased to acknowledge especially our guests who are present this afternoon, along with general and local Church leaders and members from many parts of the world.

We express our appreciation to the owners and operators of many radio and television stations and to the owners and operators of cable systems for their cooperation in making these pro-

ceedings available to members and friends of the Church in many countries.

The music for this session will be provided by the Murray Region Family Choir, under the direction of Brother Owen Clark with Brother John Longhurst at the organ.

The choir will begin this service by singing "The Happy Day at Last Has Come." The invocation will be offered by Elder Gene R. Cook of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

The choir sang "The Happy Day at Last Has Come."

Elder Gene R. Cook offered the invocation.

President Monson

This splendid choir will now sing "Dearest Children, God Is Near You," following which President Gordon B. Hinckley will present the General Authorities and general officers for the sustaining vote of the conference.

The choir sang "Dearest Children, God Is Near You."

President Gordon B. Hinckley

Sustaining of General Authorities and general officers

My brothers and sisters, as requested by President Benson, I shall now present to you the General Authorities and general officers of the Church for your sustaining vote.

It is proposed that we sustain President Ezra Taft Benson as prophet, seer, and revelator and President of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints; Gordon B. Hinckley as First Counselor in the First Presidency; and Thomas S. Monson as Second Coun-

selor in the First Presidency. Those in favor may manifest it. Any opposed may manifest it.

It is proposed that we sustain Marion G. Romney as President of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, Howard W. Hunter as Acting President of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, and the following as members of that council: Marion G. Romney, Howard W. Hunter, Boyd K. Packer, Marvin J. Ashton, L. Tom Perry, David B. Haight, James E. Faust, Neal A. Maxwell, Russell M. Nelson, Dallin H. Oaks, M. Russell Ballard, and

Joseph B. Wirthlin. Those in favor, please manifest it. Any opposed may manifest it.

As announced a few months ago, Carlos E. Asay has been released as a President of the First Quorum of the Seventy in order to serve as President of the Europe Area. In view of the action just taken, we also release Elder Joseph B. Wirthlin, who has been serving as a President of the First Quorum of the Seventy since August. Those who wish to extend a vote of appreciation to these Brethren for their faithful service may do so by the uplifted hand.

We sustain as the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy: Dean L. Larsen, Richard G. Scott, Marion D. Hanks, Wm. Grant Bangerter, Jack H. Goaslind, Robert L. Backman, and Hugh W. Pinnock. All in favor, please signify. Any opposed may so signify.

We note with sadness the passing of Elders James A. Cullimore and O. Leslie Stone of the First Quorum of the Seventy. Parenthetically, I would like to say that we note with sadness the passing only yesterday of President Franklin McKean of the Brazil Recife Mission.

With the exceptions which I have noted, there have been no changes in

the General Authorities or the general officers of the Church since the last conference. It is proposed, therefore, that we sustain all of the General Authorities and general officers of the Church as at present constituted. All in favor, please manifest it. Any opposed by the same sign.

It appears that the voting has been unanimous in favor of the General Authorities and general officers of the Church. Thank you, brothers and sisters, for your generous and prayerful support.

President Thomas S. Monson

It would now be appropriate for Brother Wirthlin and Brother Pinnock to take their places, please. Elder Dallin H. Oaks of the Council of the Twelve Apostles will be our first speaker, and he will be followed by Elders H. Verlan Andersen, George I. Cannon, and Gardner H. Russell of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

Elder Dallin H. Oaks spoke without further announcement.

Elder Dallin H. Oaks

Duty to live the Golden Rule

One of the consequences of mortality is the necessity of earning our daily bread (see Genesis 3:19, Moses 4:25). We do so as employees, as business people, and as investors. In all of our earning activities, we have the challenge of dealing fairly and considerately with others.

Our duty is clear. The Savior gave us the Golden Rule: "All things whatsoever ye would that men should do to you, do ye even so to them" (Matthew 7:12).

Satan's position is the opposite. He sponsors self-interest, raw and unrefined by any other consideration. One

of his most effective tools is the temptation to take unfair advantage in order to get gain. It has been so from the beginning.

Cain set the pattern of the world. Cain coveted the flocks of his brother Abel, and Satan showed him how to obtain them (see JST, Genesis 5:14, 23; Moses 5:29, 38). Satan taught Cain that a man could get worldly wealth by committing some evil against its owner (see JST, Genesis 5:16; Moses 5:31).

Cain killed Abel. The scriptures say that he did so "for the sake of getting gain" (Moses 5:50), the flocks of his brother (JST, Genesis 5:18; Moses 5:33). Seeing this, the Lord

asked Cain, "Where is Abel thy brother?" Cain first attempted to cover his sin with a lie: "I know not." Then he added a rationalization: "Am I my brother's keeper?" (Genesis 4:9; see also Moses 5:34).

Responsibility to be brothers' keepers

Are we our brothers' keepers? In other words, are we responsible to look after the well-being of our neighbors as we seek to earn our daily bread? The Savior's Golden Rule says we are. Satan says we are not.

Tempted of Satan, some have followed the example of Cain. They covet property and then sin to obtain it. The sin may be murder, robbery, or theft. It may be fraud or deception. It may even be some clever but legal manipulation of facts or influence to take unfair advantage of another. Always the excuse is the same: "Am I my brother's keeper?"

Those who follow the example of Cain fulfill a Book of Mormon prophecy. Seeing our day, Nephi prophesied that many would say, "Lie a little, take the advantage of one because of his words, dig a pit for thy neighbor; there is no harm in this" (2 Nephi 28:8).

Be guided by high moral standards in the marketplace

We live in a world where many look on the marketplace as a ruthless arena where the buyer must beware, where no one is obligated to do more than the law requires, and where fraud isn't fraud unless you can prove it in court.

Members of the Church of Jesus Christ have a higher standard. President Harold B. Lee said, "The standard . . . in the Church must be visibly higher than the standard . . . in the world" (*Ye Are the Light of the World* [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1974], p. 13). We are commanded to live the Golden Rule.

Despite that high standard, some who profess to be Christians seek to

earn their living by systematically victimizing their neighbors.

Some seize wealth by trafficking in illegal drugs or pornography. Traders in these products enrich themselves by transactions that ruin the bodies, minds, or morals of their customers.

Other criminals live by stealing. And not all stealing is at gunpoint or by dark of night. Some theft is by deception, where the thief manipulates the confidence of his victim.

The white-collar cousin of stealing is fraud, which gets its gain by lying about an essential fact in a transaction.

Scheming promoters with glib tongues and ingratiating manners deceive their neighbors into investments the promoters know to be more speculative than they dare reveal.

God will judge secret acts

Difficulties of proof make fraud a hard crime to enforce. But the inadequacies of the laws of man provide no license for transgression under the laws of God. Though their method of thievery may be immune from correction in this life, sophisticated thieves in white shirts and ties will ultimately be seen and punished for what they are. He who presides over that Eternal Tribunal knows our secret acts, and he is "a discerner of the thoughts and intents of the heart" (Hebrews 4:12, D&C 33:1).

Follow Christian standards in financial activities

Most of us can be relatively comfortable when a message on the Golden Rule in the workplace uses examples like illegal drugs and theft by deception. What follows is more challenging. And it should be. We cannot expect to be comfortable if we measure our conduct against the Savior's command, "I would that ye should be perfect even as I" (3 Nephi 12:48). To follow in the footsteps of the only perfect person who ever lived, we must expect to stretch our souls.

Followers of Christ have the moral responsibility of earning their livings and conducting their financial transactions in ways that are consistent with the principles of the gospel and the teachings of the Savior. Members of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints should not be involved in employment or other activities upon which they cannot conscientiously ask the blessings of the Lord.

Persons who prosecute frivolous lawsuits do not measure up to this high standard. Groundless litigation rewards some plaintiffs handsomely, but it injures everyone else by raising the price of products and services.

An employee who receives the compensation agreed upon but does not perform the service agreed upon earns part of his living by injuring others.

So does an employer who is unfair to his employees. An idealistic young professional wrote Church headquarters about the plight of migrant farm workers. He had observed treatment that was probably illegal and certainly unchristian. When I read his letter, I thought of the positive example of Jesse Knight, the great benefactor of Brigham Young Academy. At a time when most mine owners exploited their workers, this Christian employer paid his miners something extra so they could earn their living in six days' labor and rest on the Sabbath. He did not require them to patronize a company store. He built his workers a building for recreation, worship, and schooling. And Brother Knight would not permit the superintendent to question his workers about their religion or politics (see Jesse William Knight, *The Jesse Knight Family* [Salt Lake City: Deseret News Press, 1940], pp. 43-44; and Gary Fuller Reese, "Uncle Jesse" [Master's thesis, Brigham Young University, 1961], pp. 26-28).

Of course, we understand that what an employer can pay his employees is limited by what his business can obtain for its products or services in a competitive marketplace. Contracts

also impose limits on legitimate economic expectations.

Follow Christian standards in selling and advertising

Christian standards should also apply to those who earn a living by selling or advertising products in the marketplace.

The marketplace for products and services has many potential buyers who are vulnerable because they are poorly informed or excessively trusting. For example, a friend told me of a young student couple who didn't have enough money for rent, groceries, and tuition but were persuaded to sign up for an expensive self-improvement course. Can a seller ever justify obtaining personal profit by persuading someone to assume a financial burden he cannot wisely bear in order to acquire something he does not really need? The Prophet Joseph Smith taught that Latter-day Saints should deal justly with their neighbors and mercifully with the poor (see *History of the Church*, 5:401).

To cite another kind of example, an owner who keeps his business open on Sunday prevents his employees from attending worship services and being with their families on the Sabbath. Modern-day prophets have encouraged us not to shop on Sunday (see, for example, Spencer W. Kimball, in Conference Report, Oct. 1974, p. 6; or *Ensign*, Nov. 1974, p. 6). Those of us who shop on the Sabbath cannot escape responsibility for encouraging businesses to remain open on that day. Essential services must be provided, but most Sabbath transactions could be avoided if merchants and customers were determined to avoid doing business on the Lord's day.

Last year the *Deseret News* carried an article about a Salt Lake City pharmacist who stopped selling cigarettes in his drugstore. He explained, "It's just incompatible for a profession dedicated to saving people's lives to sell a product that does nothing but kill" ("S.L. Pharmacist Using Backhoe to Snuff out Cigarette Stock," 20 Dec. 1985, sec.

B, p. 1). That merchant was more concerned about his customers' welfare than his personal profits.

Sister Oaks called my attention to a similar example in the world of advertising. The magazine *Women's Sports and Fitness* does not accept cigarette ads, thus foregoing much-needed revenue. A woman columnist and physician, Dr. Joan Ulliyot, praised this policy and contrasted it to the practice of another organization:

"I am dismayed that a prominent women's sport, tennis, continues to take support from a cigarette company. Surely the top women in this sport, none of whom smoke, have the [courage] to say no to this hypocrisy and stop lending their names and prestige to sanction and glamorize a lethal product. Any role model in sport who accepts support or sponsorship from a company whose products destroy health and fitness should take a hard look at what she is, by association, endorsing" (*Women's Sports and Fitness*, Sept. 1986, p. 12).

Wouldn't it be wonderful if this same attitude of looking after the interests of others governed Latter-day Saints who are making a profit from the sale or promotion of alcoholic beverages? Consider the terrible effects of alcohol. Alcohol-related accidents are the leading cause of death of those under twenty-five. The physical, social, and financial effects of alcohol ruin marriages and family life. By dulling inhibitions, alcohol leads to untold numbers of crimes and moral transgressions. Alcohol is the number one addictive drug in our day.

The consumption of alcohol is increasing among youth. Targeting young audiences, advertisers portray beer and wine as joyful, socially desirable, and harmless. Producers are promoting new types of alcoholic beverages as competitors in the huge soft-drink market. Grocery and convenience stores and gas stations stock alcoholic beverages side by side with soda pop. Can Christians who are involved in this commerce be indifferent

to the physical and moral effects of the alcohol from which they are making their profits?

Other examples could be given, but these few are sufficient to illustrate the principle that the Golden Rule applies to our earning activities. We are our brother's keeper, even in the marketplace.

Strive to live the full implications of the Golden Rule

I am aware that this is a high standard which cannot be met overnight. But it is important to recognize our responsibility and begin to work toward it. And we should do so joyfully. The gospel is the good news. Commandments lead to blessings. The Prophet Joseph Smith told our first missionaries that when preaching we should "warn in compassion." We "have no right . . . to scare mankind to repentance," he said. We should preach the gospel as "glad tidings of great joy unto all people" (*History of the Church*, 1:280).

We should also remember that the principle that the Golden Rule governs our earning activities is difficult to apply in practice. We should not consider employees responsible for policies they regret but cannot control. A decision that is made by the owner of a market should not inflict feelings of guilt on a conscientious but powerless Christian who runs the checkout stand. Similarly, a part-owner does not have freedom to impose his standards on business policies if he has partners who do not share his moral concerns. An incorporated business may be controlled by stockholders who have no concern for the destructive human effects of a profitable product or policy.

We live in a complex society, where even the simplest principle can be exquisitely difficult to apply. I admire investors who are determined not to obtain income or investment profits from transactions that add to the sum total of sin and misery in the world. But they will have difficulty finding investments that meet this high standard.

Good things are often packaged with bad, so decisions usually involve balancing. In a world of corporate diversification, we are likely to find that a business dealing in beverages sells milk in one division and alcohol in another. Just when we think that our investments are entirely unspotted from the world, we may find that our life insurance is partially funded by investments we wish to avoid. Or our savings may be deposited in a bank that is lending to ventures we could not approve. Such complexities make it difficult to prescribe firm rules.

Apply the Golden Rule prayerfully and thoughtfully

We must rely on teaching correct principles, which each member should personally apply to govern his or her own circumstances. To that end, each of us should give thoughtful and prayerful consideration to whether we are looking after the well-being of our neighbors in the way we earn our daily bread.

The motive of Cain is at the headwaters of wickedness. Cain's sin was murder, but his motive was personal gain. That motive has produced all manner of wickedness, including murder, thievery, and fraud. That motive is also at work in the legal but immoral practices of those who get gain by preying on the weaknesses or ignorance of their neighbors. Always such activities involve Cain's ancient rationalization: "Am I my brother's keeper?"

In contrast, the Savior taught us to "love [our] enemies, bless them that curse [us], do good to them that hate [us], and pray for them who despitefully use [us] and persecute [us]" (3 Nephi 12:44). When we have that duty toward our enemies, we cannot allow ourselves to do less for our partners, our customers, our employees, and others with whom we deal in the marketplace.

Living the Golden Rule brings happiness

What a beautiful and happy world this would be if all of us would strive to live these principles to the fullest. Our efforts and influence would affect millions. Examples improve society more than sermons. Most people would rather see a sermon than hear one.

In those brilliant generations that followed the appearance of the resurrected Christ in the New World, "there were no contentions and disputations among [the people], and every man did deal justly one with another" (4 Nephi 1:2). Fourth Nephi records: "Surely there could not be a happier people among all the people who had been created by the hand of God" (1:16). We should be striving to regain that condition. As modern revelation declares, "Zion must increase in beauty, and in holiness" (D&C 82:14). One of the ways prescribed to achieve that increase is "every man seeking the interest of his neighbor, and doing all things with an eye single to the glory of God" (D&C 82:19).

May God bless us to live the Golden Rule in our earning activities. As we seek to be our brother's keeper, we will be attempting to follow in the footsteps of the Master. I testify of Jesus Christ, our Savior, whose blood has atoned for repented sins and whose resurrection has broken the bands of death for all. The fulness of the gospel was restored through the Prophet Joseph Smith. His successor, President Ezra Taft Benson, holds the keys of the everlasting gospel in our day. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Monson

Elder Dallin H. Oaks of the Council of the Twelve Apostles has just spoken to us.

We shall now hear from Elders H. Verlan Andersen, George I. Cannon, and Gardner H. Russell, sustained last conference as new members of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

Elder H. Verlan Andersen

My dear brothers and sisters, knowing as I do that this is the Lord's church, and sensing somewhat the magnitude of the responsibility which comes with my calling and assignment as a General Authority, I have prayed most earnestly for that divine help which I feel so much in need of.

Missionary work in Latin America: fulfillment of prophecy

During the past few years, my wife and I have served as missionaries in Latin American countries. This has been one of the most challenging and rewarding experiences of our lives. It has been deeply satisfying to work with those lovable and believing people and to see the prophecies of the Book of Mormon being fulfilled as hundreds of thousands of the descendants of Lehi join the Church. The day of the Lamanites has truly arrived.

The history of the Lamanites just prior to the Lord's first appearance on this continent reveals an interesting parallel between what occurred then and what is happening today. Commencing about the year 92 B.C., the Lamanites began coming into the Lord's church by the tens of thousands. That conversion miracle, which took place just shortly before the Lord's first advent, is being repeated now just prior to his second coming.

Devotion to missionary work brings joy

There is an aspect of missionary work upon which I would like to comment briefly, and that is the joy which comes to those who engage in it.

The Book of Mormon sums up the whole purpose of existence in this short sentence: "Men are, that they might have joy" (2 Nephi 2:25).

If joy is the supreme goal of life, then everyone should be intensely interested in how it may be obtained. We should be equally concerned about how

we may avoid its opposite, misery. These vital topics are discussed and illustrated in the Book of Mormon, and the information concerning them is directly related to missionary work. The book tells us that those who completely devote their lives to the task of spreading the gospel experience exquisite joy, while those who oppose it and seek to promulgate falsehood suffer a misery equally intense.

The gospel, and the opportunity to share its message, have not always been on the earth. But when the gospel is here, we should value it highly. The Lord has given us his promise that if we labor all of our days and bring save it be one soul to him, how great shall be our joy with him in the kingdom of our Father (see D&C 18:15).

Lifeblood of the Church

A number of years ago, the late President Spencer W. Kimball, who was then a member of the Quorum of the Twelve, visited the stake in which I was living and made the statement that missionary work is the lifeblood of the Church. He also said that were it not for missionary work, the Church would wither and die on the vine. That statement doubtless applies as much to us as individuals and families as it does to the Church as a whole. A failure to utilize our endowments and fulfill our callings as the salt of the earth may indeed cause us to wither and die on the vine.

Blessings of sacrificing for missionary work

I should like to discuss for a moment the enormous influence which missionary work has had on my own life. My parents, who grew up in Mexico, had not served missions prior to their marriage. But when a call came to the seventies quorum to which my father belonged for a volunteer to serve a short-term mission, he went, even though it meant leaving a farm and a

large family of small children for his wife to care for. She welcomed that opportunity to sacrifice for Church and family, and I well remember how heroically she bore her burdens during those difficult winter months.

Later, during the long, cruel years of the Great Depression, even though my parents suffered severe financial hardship, they always kept one of their children in the mission field.

My father passed away at a relatively young age, and after he was gone and we children had married, my mother asked for, and was given, permission to serve a mission in Mexico.

If there is honor attached to my call to the First Quorum of the Seventy, and indeed there is, it goes not to me, but to those whose examples of sacrifice and dedication have influenced my life so greatly. I pay tribute to them for their tireless and unceasing devotion to the Church and to their family. They have wielded an immense influence upon their ten children and their other numerous posterity.

I must not close without expressing my love and appreciation for my dear companion, who is herself a notable example of hard work and sacrifice. I think she deserves to be heard from, and so I am going to pass on to you the following thoughts that she suggested I include in my address, not expecting I would attribute them to her:

Message to grandparents

"And now a word to grandparents on missionary work. The blessings you receive therefrom reach down into your families. The grandchildren will never forget the special joy they feel at your farewell. Then, when you get into the mission field, letters start arriving containing statements like these: 'Grandma and Grandpa, I keep praying for you to be good missionaries,' or, 'Sometime I'll go on a mission just like you.'

"Grandmothers, you say you cannot leave the grandchildren? I want to bear you my testimony that you can be a lasting influence for good in the lives of those little ones by giving a year or so of your time to the service of the Lord in the mission field. The bonds of love will be strengthened, and true miracles will occur. Don't deny your grandchildren those blessings. I challenge you to put missionary work to the test."

Such is the message of my dear wife, with whom I am in total agreement. And now in closing, I bear you my own witness that missionary work truly is the lifeblood of the Church and that we have a divine commission to share the gospel with others both at home and abroad. I know, nothing doubting, that this is the work of the Lord and that President Benson is his prophet on earth today. This testimony I bear in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

Elder George I. Cannon

My brothers and sisters, the Lord's work is moving forward in Asia through the faith, prayers, and good works of the Saints and missionaries in many countries in that part of the world. A spiritual awakening is taking place, and doors are being opened. It is a humbling and uplifting experience for Sister Cannon and me to be called to serve in that choice area of the world.

I would like to share some thoughts with you as a father and grandfather.

Importance of children

First, I would like to talk to you young children. I want you to know that you are loved by your Father in Heaven and your Elder Brother, Jesus Christ. When Jesus was living upon the earth, a very important event took place:

"Then were there brought unto him little children, that he should put his hands on them, and pray: and the disciples rebuked them [or tried to stop them from coming].

"But Jesus said, Suffer little children, and forbid them not, to come unto me: for of such is the kingdom of heaven.

"And [then] he laid his hands on them" (Matthew 19:13-15).

How important each one of you is to your Father in Heaven and to his Son, Jesus Christ! They want you to be happy. They have told of some things which, if you do, will make you feel good inside. Jesus told us to "honour [our] father and mother" (Matthew 15:4). That means we need to listen to our parents, ask for their help and advice, and, as they do what is right, follow their example.

Jesus also said, "Pray always, and I will pour out my Spirit upon you, and great shall be your blessing" (D&C 19:38). I hope that each morning and evening you kneel beside your bed and pray to your Father in Heaven. As you start the day, ask him to help you think good thoughts and do good deeds. As each day ends, thank him for your blessings, and ask that his spirit will always be with you. I know from my own experience that prayer can make you a happier and better person.

I hope that you are going every week to Primary, where you can learn how to be happy and serve the Lord, and that once a week your family is holding family home evening. If your family is not holding family home evening, ask your parents if you can start having one, and then you help them with it.

Challenges and opportunities of youth

Now I would like to speak to those of you in your youth. This is a great time to be young. You are living in the most exciting period of this world's history. You are also living in the most challenging. We know there are many temptations, but we have confidence in

you. The Lord has confidence and faith in you. There is unlimited growth ahead for you if you are willing to work hard and earn it. Be happy! Be glad you are you.

Follow the wise counsel of Alma to his son Helaman given centuries ago: "O, remember, my son, and learn wisdom in thy youth; yea, learn in thy youth to keep the commandments of God" (Alma 37:35).

In one of his last conference addresses, President David O. McKay gave this counsel to the youth of the Church:

"Our body will not fulfill its purpose — it cannot — without that life-giving something within which is the offspring of Deity as eternal as [your] Father [in Heaven]. . . . That spirit within, young man, young woman, is the *real* you. What you make of yourself depends upon you as an individual. You are in this world to choose the right or the wrong, to accept the right or yield to temptation. Upon that choice will depend the development of the spiritual part of you" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1967, pp. 134-35; or *Improvement Era*, June 1967, p. 110).

O wonderful youth of Zion, pray, study the scriptures, and serve in the Church so that you can have that inner peace that Christ is your Savior and the gospel is the right way to live.

As Elder Richard L. Evans wrote: "*Oh, beloved young friends: remember life is forever — but youth doesn't last very long. Live to make memories that will bless the whole length of your life*" (*Richard Evans' Quote Book* [Salt Lake City: Publishers Press, 1971], p. 40).

Important roles of single adults

Now I speak to you stalwart single adults. You are making great contributions wherever you go. You are helping to build the individual, the home, the Church, and the community as you serve as missionaries, teachers, neighbors, and friends to those in need. Your enthusiasm, spirit, and faith are a blessing to all of us. My fatherly counsel is

to remind you of the importance of today. This is the time in which the work of this life is to be done. Be a participant. See that things happen. Make commitments to yourself and the Lord. Live outside yourself with love. A Hindu proverb says, "Help thy brother's boat across, and lo, thine own has reached the shore."

Sacred responsibilities of parents

Now I speak to you who are parents. I was reminded of a cartoon LaRue Longden, former counselor in the YWMA, would often share in her talks. It shows the early morning hours with a couple out camping. The husband is fishing with a big smile on his face. The wife puts her sleepy head out of the tent — her hair going in all directions, the mosquitoes buzzing around her face, her eyes barely open — and comments to her husband, "Tell me again, dear, how much fun I am having." As a parent, do you need to remind yourself occasionally of how much fun you are having? Be sure and enjoy being a parent. It is a wonderful and sacred responsibility.

Three thoughts I would share:

First, take time for your children. As Elder Evans counseled: "Children are shaped and molded at a very early age. . . . Life goes quickly. Don't brush them off and turn them over to others. Take time for your children — before they're grown, before they're gone" (*Thoughts for One Hundred*

Days: Volume Four [Salt Lake City: Publishers Press, 1970], pp. 34–35).

Second, live within your income. Be frugal and wise. Pay your obligations to the Lord, your country, and yourself, and then live on what is left. It takes willpower to say no when you can't afford it, but you will sleep better at night.

Third, remember constant courtship. The most important relationship upon this earth for you is between you and your sweetheart. Work at it, sacrifice for it, enjoy it. You can make your home a bit of heaven as you build for an eternity together.

The need for older members to serve

Now to those in your mature years. "Press forward with a steadfastness in Christ, having a perfect brightness of hope, and a love of God and of all men" (2 Nephi 31:20). Continue to be living testimonies of the gospel as you share your faith, love, and wisdom. You are sorely needed in the mission field. What lives you will bless as you accept the call to serve! There is so much for you to do in the holy temples. Don't retire from active service in the Lord's kingdom. You are needed!

I bear my testimony that God lives, that Jesus is the Savior, and that the gospel is for every nation, kindred, tongue, and people. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

Elder Gardner H. Russell

I think it's wonderful to have a calm exterior; I didn't know my heart could beat quite this hard. I am thrilled to be a member of the Mexico and Central America Area Presidency. You've heard from all three of us today: Elder Gene R. Cook in the prayer, Elder H. Verlan Andersen, and myself.

Now, it is with humility that I stand before you as one of the Lord's

servants with a prayer in my heart that someone, somewhere, will be touched by the Spirit of the Lord which, hopefully, will speak through me, and his or her heart and life will be changed.

Father's blessings

What a wonderful experience of love came to me just a few weeks ago

when, at my request, my ninety-one-year-old father, Dr. Harry James Russell, gave me a father's blessing as I prepared to leave for my assignment as Second Counselor in the Mexico and Central America Area.

Fathers everywhere, consider the gift of love you can give your children when you are worthy and you lay your hands upon their heads to pronounce inspired father's blessings as the family patriarch. They will feel a continuing outpouring of your love, which will keep them close to you and to the Lord. You will not have to "seek them out" later.

Invitation to less-active members

How impressed we were by the caring and outpouring of love evident in last December's message from the First Presidency. This inspired invitation to return has reached tens of thousands of the Lord's people. It is far more than a Christmas message; it is a clarion call for all to return to the Lord's church (see *Ensign*, Mar. 1986, p. 88).

Then, in last April general conference, that wonderful message in a spirit of deep love, "Please come back!" rings in our ears and has reached many hearts (see Conference Report, Apr. 1986, p. 13; or *Ensign*, May 1986, p. 10).

Responsibilities to less-active members

The Lord requires us — yes, you and me — to locate the less-active members and help them to return to the fold.

"For thus saith the Lord God; Behold, I, even I, will both search my sheep, and seek them out" (Ezekiel 34:11).

Yes, we are to both "search my sheep" (locate them) and then "seek out" (bring back) less-active members and families, with unending and unqualified love.

And in the process, we and they shall learn the true meaning of "ye

shall . . . find me, when ye shall search for me" (Jeremiah 29:13).

Servants of the Lord prepare in humility, through study of the Book of Mormon, prayer, and calling on the Lord, to actually depend on the Lord so that the Spirit of the Lord is in them.

The servants of the Lord then visit the less-active families and assure them of the redeeming love of the Lord and their love for them. They speak not only by inspiration, but by a higher law, in which the Spirit of the Lord speaks through them. Through constant prayer in the heart, what is said is by the Spirit of the Lord.

The family remembers that the Lord truly loves them and finds that the servants of the Lord love them as well. Then the Lord returns the family to the fold.

Experiences with less-active members in Central America

In my training as a new General Authority, I found myself in Costa Rica with Elder F. Arthur Kay and others. In prayer and fasting, we visited families who were less active. The stake president and bishops had fasted and prayed that the Lord would indicate to them the choice families to be visited, and the families were then notified of the planned visits.

We first entered the home of a young, successful businessman with a lovely wife and children. A former leader, he had transgressed the laws of the Church. As the Spirit of the Lord spoke through his servants, tears came to all our eyes as the couple committed to prepare to go to the Lord's house, the beautiful new temple in Guatemala, to be sealed for eternity.

Just two weeks ago, in Guadalupe, Mexico, at a stake conference, I visited three families who will be among my lifelong friends. Miracles occurred in all their lives. In one visit, a nonmember father, who has been donating an amount equal to a full tithe and who supports his wife and seven sons in the Church, was asked as patri-

arch to select someone to lead us in kneeling prayer. He looked past the General Authority, past the stake president and the bishop, and with love in his eyes asked his wife to give the prayer. What a golden moment! What a tribute to her love and patience.

This same man was unable to sleep that night, and the following morning, in a meeting with recent converts and newly returned members, gave a loving, beautiful testimony of the gospel and pledged to be baptized in another eight days.

Blessings of searching out and helping less-active members

It is exciting to see the servants of the Lord, the leaders and members, prepare as vessels of the Spirit of God to identify the families who have been distracted or have transgressed and are now less active and then to touch the hearts of these wonderful families. Yes, thousands of families are returning to the Lord. They have received in love the invitation to return, have understood the humble, loving plea, "Please come back!" They have been searched out by servants of the Lord, then have been sought out by the Spirit of the Lord and brought back as they have remembered once again the word spoken through the Lord's servants.

In these inspired visits, I do not know of a single instance where hearts of families have not been touched by the miracle of our Lord's unconditional love and his servants' caring and love.

May we assure our sometimes missing friends in the Church of our Lord's love for them and ask the Spirit of the Lord to testify through us to them of the Lord's love for them, and our love as well, and bring them back to the fold in joy.

I bear my humble witness that our leaders are inspired and receive revelation for us, that the Book of Mormon nurtures the true fountain of Christ's Spirit, and that this is the true, restored church of Jesus Christ on the earth. And I do this in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Monson

The choir and congregation will now join in singing "Joseph Smith's First Prayer," following which Elder Ted E. Brewerton of the First Quorum of the Seventy will address us.

The choir and congregation sang "Joseph Smith's First Prayer."

Elder Ted E. Brewerton spoke without further announcement.

Elder Ted E. Brewerton

My thoughts at this time will be in the form of a dialogue between me and my fourteen-year-old son, Michael, who resides with us in Argentina. I will talk about how important he is and how much the Lord and I love him. At the same time I address these critical thoughts to him, they would be the same as I would express to my son David, the eldest of my six children, or to their four beautiful sisters, my daughters, Michelle, Andrea, Leanne, and Lycia.

Importance of each person

Fathers, would you like to join me and share the same thoughts as if directed to your sons and daughters, describing their singular importance in the eyes of our Heavenly Father?

Hi, Michael, you know how much I trust and love you, don't you? Let me try to show you who you are and how very important you are as a literal son of our Father in Heaven.

President Harold B. Lee said that this understanding of who we are is "of

first importance," and without it we lack "the basis of a solid foundation upon which to build [our] lives" (in Conference Report, Oct. 1973, p. 5; or *Ensign*, Jan. 1974, p. 4).

Evidences of God

First, Mike, we know by reasoning, seeing, and the impressions of the Spirit that the Lord is a living perfect man. Many have seen him: for example, Adam, Enoch, the brother of Jared, Abraham, Moses, Joseph Smith, Isaac, Jacob, Seth, Nephi, Isaiah, Emer, Joshua, Manoh and his wife, Solomon, Sidney Rigdon, Alma, Moroni, Stephen, and John. Alma states, "Many, exceedingly great many" have seen him (Alma 13:12).

Now another evidence of God: speaking of the planets and orbs, the Lord says, "Any man who hath seen any or the least of these hath seen God moving in his majesty and power" (D&C 88:47). "The heavens declare the glory of God; and the firmament sheweth his handywork" (Psalm 19:1).

God's massive, orderly creation

Mike, let's visualize three scenes together.

Scene 1. First of all, we see before us, Michael, our solar system: our sun, together with the earth and the eight other heavenly bodies that revolve around it. We see law, beauty, order, and perfection.

Scene 2. Now, Michael, in this next scene, we see this same solar system in its place in our galaxy, the Milky Way. We marvel at the order and arrangement. Our planets are so small they can't be detected here, but our sun and its nine planets appear as one of these shining orbs and are situated about two-thirds of the way from the center, about thirty thousand light years from the middle of the Milky Way. Our planets move about the sun; the sun itself moves in a circular path at a speed of 130 miles per second, yet even at that speed, Mike, a complete turn around the Milky Way takes two hundred bil-

lion years. *This, our star system, has about two hundred billion blazing suns and is one hundred thousand light years wide.*

Scene 3. Now in this next scene, Michael, we see our galaxy, the Milky Way, in space along with other galaxies. You know, Mike, it is conservatively estimated that *there are ten billion star systems like these galaxies.* Incomprehensible? I should say! We have soared out far beyond our imagination.

What is a billion, Michael? One thousand million — that's right.

What's a definition of a million, Michael? That's good; you say a million is like your mother telling you to clean up your room 274 times every day for ten years.

How fast does light travel, Mike? That's right: 186,000 miles per second. Hold up your left fist as if it represented the earth. Now whirl your right index finger around it. If your index finger spun around it about seven times in one second, you have shown how fast light would travel around the earth.

It takes about eight minutes for light to reach the earth, and just over one second for light to reach the moon from the earth. Imagine how far light could travel in one day of 86,400 seconds. Wow! Then in one year . . . it is beyond our ability to understand.

The Lord said: "And worlds without number have I created; and I also created them for mine own purpose; and by the Son I created them, which is mine Only Begotten. . . ."

"And the Lord God spake unto Moses, saying: The heavens, they are many, and they cannot be numbered unto man; but they are numbered unto me, for they are mine" (Moses 1:33, 37).

He further said:

"And were it possible that man could number the particles of the earth, yea, millions of earths like this, it would not be a beginning to the number of thy creations" (Moses 7:30).

Isn't that exciting, Mike?

From *The Amazing Universe* we read: "As the sum of knowledge grows,

the astronomer continues to seek answers to man's most profound questions: What is the grand design of the universe? How was it created? How did we get here? . . . Are we alone?" (Herbert Friedman, *The Amazing Universe* [Washington, D.C., National Geographic Society, 1975], p. 10).

We again read, "It is impossible to any sensitive person to look at a star-filled sky without being stirred by thoughts of creation and eternity" (Friedman, p. 166). "A super-giant elliptical [galaxy] may contain more than ten trillion stars, and measure 300,000 light-years across.

"*The sheer immensity of such systems suggests eternal qualities of stability and predictability*" (Friedman, p. 134; italics added). See, Mike, the scientific world sees the evidence of a supreme being.

The heavens were created for man

With all this massive, orderly creation, are you, Michael, a single human being, important? The scriptures state:

"When I consider thy heavens, the work of thy fingers, the moon and the stars, which thou hast ordained;

"What is man, that thou art mindful of him? and the son of man, that thou visitest him?"

"For thou has made him a little lower than the angels, and hast crowned him with glory and honour.

"Thou madest him to have dominion over the works of thy hands; thou hast put all things under his feet" (Psalm 8:3-6).

Yes, you, Michael, are *everything*; you are *why* the heavens were created.

Heirs to all that God has

Mike, you must realize a truth: that God knows who you are and what you may become. He knows where you are and what he expects of you.

You, Michael, are God's son, hence heir to all he has. His purpose and goal is to bring to pass *your* immortality and eternal life. You are the most

important thing that exists — his most important creation. So we must be master of our beings and control ourselves, and not be controlled by some habit or by someone else. We must be lifters and not leaners. Reach for the stars.

"Be a remarkable one"

You, Mike, with the Lord's help, have an unlimited potential. Let's follow the perfect example of the Master, our Savior. How easy it is to have hope: "Hope is the strongest weapon in the spiritual arsenal of youth" (*Royal Bank Newsletter*, vol. 66, no. 6).

The sun is *our* star, the only source of all light and energy for us. It makes life possible.

One star — a remarkable one. There are about two hundred billion blazing *ones*, or suns, in our star system alone, and over ten billion star systems; yet one sun is a remarkable one. *You*, Michael, are like a sun — a remarkable *one*.

Jesus, the Redeemer, had no office or public function, yet he shaped the world's history. He wishes you to understand that you should be a remarkable *one*, for the power is in *you* to make things happen.

Philemon Merrill — a remarkable one

Here is a true story that relates a simple experience of a nineteen-year-old who became a remarkable *one*. He was magnified and had great powers beyond his natural abilities as the Lord acted through him. There was a young nineteen-year-old admirer of Joseph Smith, Philemon Merrill, who had come with other loyal followers to rescue their prophet from the hands of sheriffs Reynolds and Wilson. While returning to Nauvoo, the company rested "in a little grove of timber." One of the lawyers for the sheriff and the kidnappers boasted of his wrestling powers. He offered a wager that he could throw any man in Illinois. Stephen Markham, a bodyguard of Joseph's and a huge man, also an

experienced wrestler, took up the challenge. The boaster threw Stephen, and a taunting shout went up from the Prophet's enemies.

As the taunts continued, Joseph Smith turned to young Philemon Merrill and said, "Get up and throw that man."

The boy was about to refuse, to excuse himself by saying he was not a wrestler, but the look in the Prophet's eye silenced his tongue. "He arose to his feet filled with the strength of a Samson." Philemon "lifted his arms" and told the lawyer to take his choice of sides.

"The man took the left side with his right hand under," which gave him a decided advantage. Philemon Merrill's friends protested, but young Philemon felt such confidence in the words of the Prophet that it made little difference to him what advantage his antagonist took. As they began to grapple, Joseph instructed him, "'Philemon, when I count three, throw him!'"

"On the instant after the word dropped from Joseph's lips," Philemon Merrill, "with the strength of a giant, threw the lawyer over his left shoulder, and he fell striking his head upon the earth."

Little wonder it is reported that "awe fell upon the opponents of the Prophet when they saw this, and there were no more challenges to wrestle during the journey" (George Q. Cannon, *Life of Joseph Smith the Prophet*, [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1964], pp. 450-51).

Joseph Smith — a remarkable one

Here's another example of a remarkable one, Michael.

John Taylor, in his book *The Gospel Kingdom*, relates how the one is magnified by the Spirit and makes extraordinary things happen:

"Some . . . years ago, in Far West, a mob — one of those semi-occasional occurrences — had come against us with evil intent, placing

themselves in position to give us battle. . . . We had one fellow who . . . ordered our people to retreat. As soon as Joseph heard this sound, he exclaimed, 'Retreat! where in the name of God shall we retreat to?' He then led us out to the prairie, facing the mob, and placed us in position. And the first thing we knew a flag of truce was seen coming towards us. . . .

" . . . Joseph Smith, our leader, then sent word back by this messenger. Said he, 'Tell your general to withdraw his troops or I will send them to hell.' *I thought that was a pretty bold stand to take, as we only numbered about two hundred to their thirty-five hundred.* But they thought we were more numerous than we really were. It may be that our numbers were magnified in their eyes. But they took the hint and left. . . . The Lord, through simple means, is able to take care of and deliver his people, but they must put implicit faith and confidence in him" (*The Gospel Kingdom*, sel. G. Homer Durham [Salt Lake City: Bookcraft, 1964], pp. 354-55).

Another example of a remarkable one.

Each person is grander than all the planets and suns

Let me quote Elder James E. Talmage, a former member of the Quorum of the Twelve: "What is man [or if I may add, what is Michael Brewerton] in this boundless setting of sublime splendor? I answer you: Potentially now, actually to be, he [or Michael] is greater and grander, more precious according to the arithmetic of God, than all the planets and suns of space. For him were they created; they are the handiwork of God; man is his son. In this world man is given dominion over a few things; it is his privilege to achieve supremacy over many things" (Aug. 9, 1931).

With the exception of the few years when the Savior graced the earth, this, Mike, is the most exciting time to live. We have the gospel in its fulness,

so many scriptures are being fulfilled, and so much history is being made. You are an important part of it.

Let me express my true feelings to you about the Church. I know, Michael, in a decisive, indelible manner — due to the Spirit — that Jesus is our Redeemer. He lives, as does his Father. He is the living Son of a living God. President Benson and the First Presidency are his living servants through whom His will is given to all the world. Watch them, Mike, listen to them, follow them. This is the only church of Jesus Christ on the earth, Michael, and you are just as important

as any human being in all history. You are of infinite worth. I love you, pal. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Monson

Elder Ted E. Brewerton of the First Quorum of the Seventy has just spoken to us.

We shall now hear from Elder M. Russell Ballard of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, and he will be followed by President Howard W. Hunter, Acting President of the Council of the Twelve Apostles.

Elder M. Russell Ballard

Proclaim the gospel to all people

The Prophet Joseph Smith was often asked to inquire of the Lord to learn what people should do. In the case of John Whitmer, the Lord said, "And now, behold, I say unto you, that the thing which will be of the most worth unto you will be to declare repentance unto this people, that you may bring souls unto me, that you may rest with them in the kingdom of my Father" (D&C 15:6).

Jesus repeatedly called upon his disciples to preach the gospel to every living soul. Those who would believe were to be baptized in his name and enter into his church. After the Savior's forty-day fast and the temptation by Satan, "Jesus began to preach, and to say, Repent: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand.

"And Jesus, walking by the sea of Galilee, saw two brethren, Simon called Peter, and Andrew his brother, casting a net into the sea: for they were fishers.

"And he saith unto them, Follow me, and I will make you fishers of men.

"And they straightway left their nets, and followed him. . . .

"And Jesus went about all Galilee, teaching in their synagogues, and

preaching the gospel of the kingdom" (Matthew 4:17-20, 23).

With loving patience, Jesus taught his disciples, and especially his twelve Apostles, to "preach the kingdom of God" (Luke 9:2). After the three years of his ministry, crowned by the Atonement, which included his glorious resurrection, Jesus gathered his eleven disciples in Galilee.

"And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.

"Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost:

"Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world" (Matthew 28:18-20).

These instructions were clear. When Peter, the chief Apostle, finally understood them, he became a powerful leader. For example, on the day of Pentecost, he stood "with the eleven, lifted up his voice, and said unto them, Ye men of Judea, . . .

"This Jesus hath God raised up, whereof we all are witnesses. . . .

"Therefore let all the house of Israel know assuredly, that God hath

made that same Jesus, whom ye have crucified, both Lord and Christ.

"Now when they heard this, they were pricked in their heart, and said unto Peter and to the rest of the apostles, Men and brethren, what shall we do?"

"Then Peter said unto them, Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins, and ye shall receive the gift of the Holy Ghost. . . .

"Then they that gladly received his word were baptized: and the same day there were added unto them about three thousand souls" (Acts 2:14, 32, 36-38, 41).

When Jesus visited this continent, Nephi went forth and bowed himself before the Lord.

"And the Lord commanded him that he should arise. And he arose and stood before him.

"And the Lord said unto him: I give unto you power that ye shall baptize this people when I am again ascended into heaven.

"And again the Lord called others, and said unto them likewise; and he gave unto them power to baptize" (3 Nephi 11:20-22).

To every people through all ages his message remains the same: "Preach the kingdom of God" (Luke 9:2).

Share the message of the Restoration

The First Presidency has said that one of the threefold missions of the Church is to proclaim the gospel. If we accept this mission, we should be willing to center our efforts on bringing souls unto the Lord on condition of repentance.

Two years ago I spoke on this subject, and I continue to feel an urgent need that we must constantly remind and help each other in our responsibilities to share the message of the Restoration with others.

Stories of helping others receive the gospel

We often hear members say, "I know I should share the gospel, but I don't know how to do it." Perhaps the following success stories that have come to me may help you. These experiences resulted when members of the Church exercised their faith and followed some simple steps, such as setting a date to have someone prepared to be taught by the missionaries.

From England:

"In my calling as branch president, I decided one day to invite our whole community to join us in fasting [and giving a fast offering] for the people of Ethiopia. I had four thousand leaflets produced, which we distributed to homes in our area.

"One of the leaflets was delivered to a nonmember, and his wife felt impressed to take part. It was the name of the Church on the leaflet which first impressed them.

"The husband came to the chapel with the fast offering as invited, and I met him there. I gave him a tour of our small building, shared my testimony with him, and invited him to come to church Sunday. He came, and I introduced him to our missionaries, who arranged to call on the home.

"I was privileged to join with the missionaries on several joint teaching visits, and I developed a close relationship with the family.

"On the evening of March 2, the night before the date I had set, I baptized the wife. Her husband will follow soon, and their daughter.

"We have now met other families through this one, who are being taught. As for my wife and me, we have set another date!"

From Oregon:

"I set a date of just under two months and proceeded to ask for divine guidance in all of my daily prayers, and to fast for strength not to lose sight of my goal.

"My date came and went, with a few pangs of guilt. However, I received

a message one week later that an old friend of mine that I had gone to school with wanted me to call. I gave him a call and invited him over that night. My friend went with me to pick up some pizza. As we drove into town, I told him that I was a member of the LDS church. He was interested, so I related some of the many blessings I had received. I then asked him to attend church with me that next Sunday, which he did.

"From the beginning, he accepted it all. We invited him to be baptized. He said he didn't want to be rushed into anything. At this time, I was impressed to read to him from the Book of Mormon, using the words that Alma used at the waters of Mormon. As I read those verses from Mosiah 18 to him, I paused at each question that Alma asked and asked him if he were willing to do it also. He said yes to all of it. Then I read him verse 10 and asked him, 'What have you against being baptized?'"

"He looked at me and said, 'You're right, I have nothing to wait for.' So the date was set, and I baptized and confirmed him a member of the Church."

From Florida:

"As I knelt in prayer, I expressed a sincere desire to share the gospel with someone and asked my Heavenly Father to please send someone to me.

"The very next morning there was a knock on my door, and it was a neighbor wanting to borrow a pan. Although she had lived by us for some time, we had not had much contact. Two days later both she and her husband came over to visit with us. During our conversation she mentioned that they had been looking for a church. I told her how my husband and I were once in that very same position and how our church filled that very special need we had. We invited them to church that Sunday, and they eagerly accepted. Afterward, we asked them if they would be interested in learning more by having the missionary lessons in our home. They told us that, indeed, they would be interested.

"On Christmas Day, my husband baptized and confirmed them members of the Church. They have grown so strong, and they set a shining example to all. They are looking forward to the day when they and their new baby girl can be sealed in the temple for time and eternity."

Then, from far-off Buenos Aires:

"In our family prayers we began to include the names of nonmembers who had not yet joined the Church. My children prayed for them. Our prayers were different. We were changing our attitude toward missionary work from waiting for opportunities to share the gospel to asking the Lord to prepare specific people, by name, to receive the lessons.

"We have seen one person come into the Church who is now fully active. Three other families, chosen with the Lord's help, have received the third discussion. All have been to church at least twice. All have been in our home for friendship and encouragement. They are receiving the opportunity to accept or reject the gospel message."

Seek the Lord's help in sharing the gospel

My brothers and sisters, from the experiences of these people and many more like them, we learn that we can give the saving ordinances of the gospel to others when we allow the Lord to help us with someone we know and love. Sharing our feelings about God and religion should be easy since most Latter-day Saints are loving, sharing, and trusting people. With a relationship of trust established and with help from the Lord, we generally can feel comfortable moving beyond the realm of friendship and can invite our friends to learn more about the Church.

Four steps of helping others receive the gospel

There are many ways to share the gospel. I know that the following four

simple steps will help you in your effort to find and to share the gospel with others because many members have used them and have had successful missionary experiences.

Step one: Prayerfully set a date by which you will have someone prepared to hear the gospel. We must start somewhere, and this simple act of faith on our part will serve to motivate us. Do not worry if you do not have someone already in mind. Let the Lord help you.

Step two: Prayerfully choose a friend or someone you already know, someone with whom you may have already discussed the gospel, or given a Book of Mormon or other Church literature, or taken to church.

Step three: Share your date and your plans with your bishopric, ward mission leader, and the full-time missionaries. They will help you.

The most important step is *step four*: With the help of the Spirit, invite your nonmember friend to hear the missionary discussions. This step, extending an invitation to hear the gospel, requires the most faith — faith to do as you are prompted by the Holy Ghost.

In talking of faith and saving souls, you should understand that when the Spirit is present, people are not offended when you share your feelings about the gospel. By prayerfully following these steps, you are putting a plan into effect that translates your faith into action.

Preparing people to feel the Spirit

There are many good ways that you can use to prepare someone to feel the Spirit. A few examples are: bear your testimony, pray together, read the scriptures, give a Book of Mormon, share a spiritual experience, take your friend to church, present a gospel film or tape, and discuss the gospel. Please note that all of these same steps and principles will also work when we use them to invite the inactive member of the Church to come back into full activity.

In the fiftieth section of the Doctrine and Covenants, we are assured that “he that receiveth the word by the Spirit of truth receiveth it as it is preached by the Spirit of truth.

“Wherefore, he that preacheth and he that receiveth, understand one another, and both are edified and rejoice together” (D&C 50:21–22).

“Bring many souls unto the Lord”

The key to success in bringing souls unto Christ is to act at a time when you feel the Spirit and you sense that your friend does also.

Remember, brothers and sisters, through our faith, our trust in the Lord, and our good works, we can bring many souls unto the Lord. We can enjoy the blessings of living with them in the kingdom of our Father.

“Who will be there to greet us?”

Shortly after the death of Sister LeGrand Richards, I was assigned to be Elder Richards’ junior companion to assist him in creating the Atlanta Georgia Stake. As we were flying toward his beloved Southern States Mission, he said to me, “Brother Ballard, I am not afraid to die; the only thing I worry about is, will I be able to find Mommy over there.”

I was impressed to say to Elder Richards that in his case that could be a real problem. Immediately, I had his full attention. He looked me directly in the eye and said, “What do you mean by that?”

With my emotions near the surface, I answered this great missionary, “Elder Richards, when you die, so many people there will be anxious to greet you because you introduced the gospel to them that you might have difficulty finding Mommy in the crowd.” His response was, “Oh, you don’t mean that.”

We all might ask ourselves the question, Who will be there to greet us?

We can succeed in sharing the gospel

Oh, that I could have the power to touch your hearts that you would have the faith to take the simple steps that will bring the light of the gospel to many more of our Father's children. The more I am involved in this work, the more I realize that Satan would have you and me believe that we cannot succeed in sharing the gospel. He lies to us. In fact, he is the father of all lies. Do not listen to him. Listen to the prompting of the Holy Ghost, and then act in faith in sharing the gospel.

I testify to you, my brothers and sisters, that I know the Lord lives. I know that when we are willing to seek his help and guidance, when we trust in him completely, he will bless us to understand what to do and how to proceed in the wonderful work of sharing this glorious message with others.

We do appreciate all you have done in the past. The leaders of the

Church have great faith that, united together, the members and the missionaries of this church can do much more in the future to build the kingdom of God.

May the Lord bless us all with increased faith to move his work forward, I humbly pray in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Monson

We have just heard from Elder M. Russell Ballard of the Council of the Twelve Apostles. Brother Ballard, when Elder LeGrand Richards asked me that same question, "Will I be able to find Mommy there?" I gave him a different answer. I said, "Brother Richards, don't worry about it. Mommy will find you!"

It will now be our opportunity to hear from President Howard W. Hunter, Acting President of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, who will be our concluding speaker.

President Howard W. Hunter

In ancient times, one test of the purity of gold was performed with a smooth, black, siliceous stone called a touchstone. When rubbed across the touchstone, the gold produced a streak or mark on its surface. The goldsmith matched this mark to a color on his chart of graded colors. The mark was redder as the amount of copper or alloy increased or yellower as the percentage of gold increased. This process showed quite accurately the purity of the gold.

The touchstone method of testing the purity of gold was quick and was satisfactory for most practical purposes. But the goldsmith who still questioned the purity completed a more accurate test by using a process that involved fire.

The Lord's touchstone: the two great commandments

I suggest to you that the Lord has prepared a touchstone for you and me, an outward measurement of inward discipleship that marks our faithfulness and will survive the fires yet to come.

On one occasion while Jesus was teaching the people, a certain lawyer approached him and posed this question: "Master, what shall I do to inherit eternal life?"

Jesus, the master teacher, replied to the man, who obviously was well-versed in the law, with a counter-question, "What is written in the law? how readest thou?"

The man replied with resolute summary the two great commandments: "Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy strength, and

with all thy mind; and thy neighbour as thyself."

With approval Christ responded, "This do, and thou shalt live" (Luke 10:25-28).

Eternal life, God's life, the life we are seeking, is rooted in two commandments. The scriptures say that "on these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets" (Matthew 22:40). Love God and love your neighbor. The two work together; they are inseparable. In the highest sense they may be considered as synonymous. And they are commandments that each of us can live.

The answer of Jesus to the lawyer might be considered as the Lord's touchstone. He said on another occasion, "Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren, ye have done it unto me" (Matthew 25:40). He will measure our devotion to him by how we love and serve our fellowmen. What kind of mark are we leaving on the Lord's touchstone? Are we truly good neighbors? Does the test show us to be twenty-four-karat gold, or can the trace of fool's gold be detected?

"Who is my neighbour?"

As if excusing himself for asking such a simple question of the Master, the lawyer sought to justify himself by further inquiring, "And who is my neighbour?" (Luke 10:29).

We all ought to be eternally grateful for that question, for in the Savior's reply came one of his richest and most appreciated parables, one that each of us has read and heard over and over again:

"A certain man went down from Jerusalem to Jericho, and fell among thieves, which stripped him of his raiment, and wounded him, and departed, leaving him half dead.

"And by chance there came down a certain priest that way: and when he saw him, he passed by on the other side.

"And likewise a Levite, when he was at the place, came and looked on him, and passed by on the other side.

"But a certain Samaritan, as he journeyed, came where he was: and when he saw him, he had compassion on him,

"And went to him, and bound up his wounds, pouring in oil and wine, and set him on his own beast, and brought him to an inn, and took care of him.

"And on the morrow when he departed, he took out two pence, and gave them to the host, and said unto him, Take care of him; and whatsoever thou spendest more, when I come again, I will repay thee" (Luke 10:30-35).

Then Jesus asked the lawyer, "Which now of these three, thinkest thou, was neighbour unto him that fell among the thieves?" (Luke 10:36). There the Master holds out the touchstone of Christianity. He asks that our mark be measured on it.

Both the priest and the Levite in Christ's parable should have remembered the requirements of the law: "Thou shalt not see thy brother's ass or his ox fall down by the way, and hide thyself from them: thou shalt surely help him to lift them up again" (Deuteronomy 22:4). And if an ox, how much more should one be willing to help a brother in need. But as Elder James E. Talmage wrote, "Excuses [not to do so] are easy to find; they spring up as readily and plentifully as weeds by the wayside" (*Jesus the Christ*, 3rd ed. [Salt Lake City: The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, 1916], p. 431).

The Samaritan gave us an example of pure Christian love. He had compassion; he went to the man who had been injured by the thieves and bound up his wounds. He took him to an inn, cared for him, paid his expenses, and offered more if needed for his care. This is a story of the love of a neighbor for his neighbor.

Love every neighbor

An old axiom states that a man "all wrapped up in himself makes a small

bundle." Love has a certain way of making a small bundle large. The key is to love our neighbor, including the neighbor that is difficult to love. We need to remember that though we make our friends, God has made our neighbors—everywhere. Love should have no boundary; we should have no narrow loyalties. Christ said, "For if ye love them which love you, what reward have ye? do not even the publicans the same?" (Matthew 5:46).

Love and serve neighbors to be justified before God

Joseph Smith wrote a letter to the Saints, published in the *Messenger and Advocate*, on the subject of loving one another to be justified before God. He wrote:

"Dear Brethren:—It is a duty which every Saint ought to render to his brethren freely—to always love them, and ever succor them. To be justified before God we must love one another: we must overcome evil; we must visit the fatherless and the widow in their affliction, and we must keep ourselves unspotted from the world: for such virtues flow from the great fountain of pure religion. Strengthening our faith by adding every good quality that adorns the children of the blessed Jesus, we can pray in the season of prayer; we can love our neighbor as ourselves, and be faithful in tribulation, knowing that the reward of such is greater in the kingdom of heaven. What a consolation! What a joy! Let me live the life of the righteous, and let my reward be like this!" (*History of the Church*, 2:229).

Willard Richards's test

These two virtues, love and service, are required of us if we are to be good neighbors and find peace in our lives. Surely they were in the heart of Elder Willard Richards. While in Carthage Jail on the afternoon of the martyrdom of Joseph and Hyrum, the jailer suggested that they would be safer in

the cells. Joseph turned to Elder Richards and asked, "If we go into the cell will you go with us?"

Elder Richards's reply was one of love: "Brother Joseph, you did not ask me to cross the river with you—you did not ask me to come to Carthage—you did not ask me to come to jail with you—and do you think I would forsake you now? But I will tell you what I will do; if you are condemned to be hung for 'treason,' I will be hung in your stead, and you shall go free."

It must have been with considerable emotion and feeling that Joseph replied, "But you cannot."

To which Elder Richards firmly answered, "I will" (B. H. Roberts, *A Comprehensive History of the Church*, 2:283).

Elder Richards' test was perhaps greater than most of us will face: the test of fire rather than of the touchstone. But if we were asked to do so, could we lay down our lives for our families? our friends? our neighbors?

The touchstone of compassion is a measure of our discipleship; it is a measure of our love for God and for one another. Will we leave a mark of pure gold or, like the priest and the Levite, pass by on the other side?

May the Lord bless us in our quest to be true disciples and good neighbors. I pray that each of us may be good Samaritans, in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Monson

President Howard W. Hunter, Acting President of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, has been our concluding speaker. He meets every test of the "touchstone."

We remind the brethren of the general priesthood meeting which will convene in the Tabernacle this evening at 6:00 P.M.

The nationwide CBS Tabernacle Choir broadcast tomorrow morning will be from 9:30 to 10:00 A.M. Those desiring to attend this broadcast must be in their seats no later than 9:15 A.M.

We are grateful for the presence of the Murray Region Family Choir and for the inspiration the music has added to this meeting.

The choir will now sing in closing, "Let Earth's Inhabitants Rejoice."

Following the singing, the benediction will be offered by Elder Hans B.

Ringger of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

The choir sang "Let Earth's Inhabitants Rejoice."

Elder Hans B. Ringger offered the benediction.

GENERAL PRIESTHOOD MEETING

THIRD SESSION

The general priesthood meeting convened in the Tabernacle at 6:00 P.M. on Saturday, October 4, 1986.

President Thomas S. Monson, Second Counselor in the First Presidency, conducted.

The music for this session was provided by the Tabernacle Choir and Mormon Youth Combined Men's Choruses, directed by Brothers Jerold Ottley and Robert Bowden with Brother Robert Cundick at the organ.

President Monson opened this session with the following remarks:

President Thomas S. Monson

Brethren, it's wonderful to meet with you this evening. President Ezra Taft Benson, who presides at this conference, has asked me to conduct this general priesthood session.

We extend our love and best wishes to all of the brethren participating in this session.

These services are being relayed by closed-circuit and satellite transmission to members of the priesthood gathered in the Assembly Hall and in locations in many countries around the world. For those of you brethren listening in who did not have access to the afternoon session today, may I report that Elder Joseph B. Wirthlin was sustained as a member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles and Elder Hugh W. Pinnock was sustained as a President of the First Quorum of the Seventy. We welcome these brethren.

We note that Elders Charles Didier and Robert E. Wells are seated on the stand in the Assembly Hall, and Jacob de Jager and William R. Bradford are seated on the stand in the BYU Marriott Center.

The singing during this session will be furnished by the Tabernacle Choir and Mormon Youth Combined Men's Choruses, under the direction of Brothers Jerold Ottley and Robert Bowden with Brother Robert Cundick at the organ.

We shall begin by the choir singing that wonderful favorite, "Come, All Ye Sons of God." Following the singing, Elder John Sonnenberg of the First Quorum of the Seventy will offer the invocation.

The choir sang "Come, All Ye Sons of God."

Elder John Sonnenberg offered the invocation.

President Monson

The choir will now favor us with that beautiful number, "Oh Say, What Is Truth?" Following the choir number, Elder David B. Haight of the Council of the Twelve Apostles will speak to us.

The choir sang "Oh Say, What Is Truth?"

Elder David B. Haight spoke without further announcement.

Elder David B. Haight

What a stirring sight to look upon this vast audience of men and boys! I can visualize grandfathers, fathers, bishops, deacons, teachers, and priests seated together, some as families or quorums; also full-time missionaries, students, and new converts — all bearers of the Holy Priesthood of God. And beyond this historical Salt Lake Tabernacle are hundreds more such assemblies of priesthood bearers anxiously awaiting encouragement and instruction from our prophet and his noble counselors.

Miraculous rescue from a crevasse

This past summer, Clarence Neslen, Jr., took his family to Jasper National Park in Alberta, Canada. They enjoyed exploring the Columbia Icefields, jumping over crevasses in the famous Athabasca Glacier. It was an exciting experience until eleven-year-old Cannon, attempting to jump across a crevasse, missed and fell into the deep chasm. He became wedged between the walls of ice. As his father looked down some thirty feet to where his son was trapped, he was further alarmed as he saw a river of icy water flowing beneath the crevasse.

Several young men were also exploring the glacier. They heard the cries for help and came running. They had a small rope but soon realized that it was not strong enough to pull Cannon to safety. If it broke, Cannon would most assuredly fall into the rushing river of freezing water.

Sister Neslen and others ran to a nearby lodge for help. The nearest park ranger camp was seventy-five miles away. They learned by telephone that two park rangers were near the icefields. Located by radio, they rushed to the rescue. Time was short, decisions urgent, and silent prayers were sent heavenward.

Brother Neslen tried to calm his son and soothe his fears. Hypothermia was setting in. Young Cannon's shirt

had been pushed up as he fell. His bare skin was now pressed against the cold walls of the glacier. To keep his son from unconsciousness, the father called down to him to keep praying, to wiggle his fingers and toes, and to sing his favorite songs. Over and over Cannon sang, "I am a child of God, and he has sent me here, has given me an earthly home with parents kind and dear" (*Hymns*, 1985, no. 301). All were strengthened by Cannon's faith and determination. But he was beginning to weaken. His father kept assuring him that help would soon arrive and that his Heavenly Father would hear his prayers.

The two rangers arrived. Spikes were driven into the ice, and ropes were attached to a ranger, who was lowered to rescue Cannon. But the walls were too narrow for him. Their only chance was to lower a looped rope and pray he was alert enough to grasp it and then have the strength to hold on as they tried to pull him out.

Brother Neslen offered the most fervent prayer of his life, he said. He pleaded with the Lord to save his son's life. "A feeling of assurance and calm came over me," he said, "and I knew that he would be saved."

Cannon had lapsed into unconsciousness. His father called down encouragement, rousing his son sufficiently that Cannon's icy fingers now were able to catch hold of the rope. "Hold on with all of your might!" his father called down to him. Cannon was carefully pulled up — inch by inch, foot by foot — all thirty feet. When he was finally pulled to safety, he was unconscious. His fingers had miraculously frozen around the rope and had to be pried loose.

He was immediately wrapped in blankets and rushed to a waiting ambulance, but there was not enough warmth to raise his body temperature sufficiently. A paramedic undressed Cannon, then took off his own coat and shirt and held Cannon against his bare

chest so that his body heat would radiate to the boy. Cannon slowly responded to the loving care of his rescuers. The prayers of all had been answered.

Young Cannon Neslen, a newly ordained deacon, is here in this audience tonight. We thank our Father in Heaven that his life was spared. He was spared for a purpose. He told his father that, while wedged in the ice, he felt a comforting assurance that he would be saved. He knows God loves him and that He has a special mission for him to perform in this life.

Rescue from spiritual crevasses

Not unlike Cannon Neslen, who accidentally fell into a crevasse, some of your friends — and perhaps even some of you — have slipped into spiritual crevasses.

Spiritual crevasses symbolize the temptations and pitfalls that too many of our youth are tragically encountering: alcohol, with its wine coolers and keg parties, drug tampering and dependency, R- and X-rated films and videos, which often culminate in sexual immorality. On the edge of those ominous crevasses are parents and others who, with fervent prayers, cry for help and assistance. Like Cannon's father, they, too, pray that their sons or daughters will hold onto the extended lifeline. Their love, and the teachings of the scriptures and the assurance of the eternal blessings of the Savior's atonement, are sure lifelines to safety.

Youth are not the only ones who slip into crevasses.

A stake president recently told me that a respected member who had held Church leadership positions was enticed by some business friends to try the cocaine drug "crack." The men were depressed. Their company was failing, and they succumbed to the evil enticement of illegal drugs.

He wasted \$18,000 buying "crack," lost his job, underwent a personality change, and finally was hospitalized. Through it all, his wife stayed

by him. She found a job, and they began the struggle of putting his life back together. His Church friends helped him get another job.

His mind is seriously affected. He is still somewhat dependent on some drugs. The hope and prayer of his family is that he will be able to hold onto the lifeline.

Satan tries to take our eyes off dangerous crevasses

When Satan was cast down to earth with his innumerable hosts, he became "the father of all lies, to deceive and to blind men, and to lead them captive, . . . even as many as would not hearken unto my voice" (Moses 4:4).

One of Satan's methods is to distract and entice us so that we will take our eyes off the dangerous crevasses. He has succeeded to such an extent that many no longer recognize sin as sin. Movies, television, and magazines have glorified sin into what they think is an acceptable life-style: "[fornication], adultery, incest, . . . serial marriages, drug abuse, violence and double-dealing of every imaginable variety, [that is] often portrayed as [normal] behavior; where people who do good are not . . . rewarded and those who do evil are not punished." So stated a *Los Angeles Times* writer (Mark I. Pinsky, "Why Don't Moral Crusaders Get into a Lather about Sleazy Soaps?" *Salt Lake Tribune*, 9 Aug. 1986, sec. C, p. 7).

Assuredly we live in a time spoken of by Isaiah when men "call evil good, and good evil" (Isaiah 5:20).

Don't trifle with evil

If any of you are walking in ice fields near open crevasses, do you see the warning signs? "Danger — don't go near the edge"? Don't trifle with evil. You will lose. We pray that you will not display the somewhat arrogant attitude of some who say, "I can handle it!" or "Everyone else does it!"

A friend, visiting relatives in another state for a high school graduation, noticed a few students chewing tobacco. When he asked his nephew about it, the young man replied, "Everybody does it!"

My friend's nephew did not chew tobacco, but he did believe most boys did. Even in schools where in reality only a few students are using drugs, drinking alcohol, or smoking, nonusers commonly believe that most of their fellow students are doing it.

Everyone is *not* doing it. You don't! And you influence your friends. And others watch you. You help set the standard.

Young men, "put on the armor of righteousness"

Young men, you are a royal brotherhood — not because you're better than anyone else — but because the Lord has blessed you with special privileges and responsibilities.

You were foreordained to come to earth at a time when the fulness of the gospel was on the earth. You were foreordained to receive his priesthood. The Prophet Joseph Smith said, "Every man who has a calling to minister to the inhabitants of the world was ordained to that very purpose in the Grand Council of heaven before this world was" (*Teachings of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, sel. Joseph Fielding Smith [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1938], p. 365).

You are the Lord's special resource for teaching the gospel to all his other children. You are different from other teenagers who have neither your understanding nor your responsibilities.

You are one of his spirit sons, singled out with a special calling. And we know that he loves you. You have the gift of the Holy Ghost. You can discern good from evil. And with the power of the priesthood, you have the authority to represent your Heavenly Father.

Now, my brethren, let us who have been given this most precious

responsibility of the holy priesthood "arise," as father Lehi declared, and "put on the armor of righteousness" (2 Nephi 1:23).

Scriptures can help us avoid dangers

To help each of us avoid the pitfalls and crevasses in life, the Lord has provided the lifeline of the precious truths in the scriptures, which, if held onto, will allow us to escape both physical and spiritual danger.

The Word of Wisdom was given so that we might have clear minds and healthy bodies; the Sermon on the Mount, to make us sensitive to one another's needs; and the Ten Commandments — cut in stone by the finger of God — forbidding us to sin. He declared, "Thou shalt not."

I urge each of you to develop a personal companionship with the scriptures.

President Kimball's scripture reading as a youth

President Spencer W. Kimball read the Bible when he was fourteen years old — all sixty-six books and 1,519 pages. "If I could do it by coal-oil light," he said, "you can do it by electric light" (*The Teachings of Spencer W. Kimball*, ed. Edward L. Kimball [Salt Lake City: Bookcraft, 1982], p. 131).

President Kimball was a very special teacher for all of us. He didn't have a car or a bicycle, but he did have nine cows to milk every morning and night.

He said, "I thought, 'What a waste of time, to sit on a three-legged stool. Maybe there is something else I could do while I am milking.'"¹⁸ He placed a copy of the Articles of Faith on the ground beside him and went through them, over and over, until he had memorized them. Then he repeated the Ten Commandments over and over until he learned them. He memorized important scriptures that would help him on his mission — all while he milked the cows. He didn't have time to waste; he had things to do with his life (see *The*

Teachings of Spencer W. Kimball, p. 131).

It would be a wonderful thing for you young men to use your time wisely by learning of God's ways.

Many are accepting President Benson's charge

President Ezra Taft Benson has challenged each of us to read the Book of Mormon — the most correct of any book on earth and the keystone of our religion. We understand that thousands of young men have accepted the challenge and are now reading the Book of Mormon.

As the angel Moroni sealed up the gold plates, he was inspired to promise future generations — that is, us — that on certain conditions God will manifest the truth of those records by the power of the Holy Ghost, and that — listen carefully — “by the power of the Holy Ghost ye may know the truth of all things” (see Moroni 10:4–5).

Imagine such a promise. If you desire with a sincere heart, with faith in Christ, you can understand all things.

Book of Mormon delivered by an angel

Jeffrey Holland, president of Brigham Young University, while working on his Ph.D. at a prominent eastern American university, got to know well one of the reference librarians who had helped him with some research.

One day he said, “Ilene, I need to know how many books we have in the university library which claim to have been delivered by an angel.”

As you can imagine, the librarian gave him a peculiar look and said, “I don't know of any books that have been delivered by angels. Swords maybe, or chariots, but I don't know of any books.”

“Well, just run a check for me,

would you? It may take a little doing, but I really would like to know.”

The librarian dutifully did some checking of the nine million books in the library. For several days she had nothing to report, but then one day she smilingly said, “Mr. Holland, I have a book for you. I found one book which, it is claimed, was delivered by an angel,” and she held up a paperback copy of the Book of Mormon. “I'm told you can get them for a dollar. My goodness,” she continued, “an angel's book for a dollar! You would think angels would charge more, but then again,” she said, “where would they spend it?” (see Pat Holland, President's Welcome Assembly, Brigham Young University, 9 Sept. 1986).

Think of it — one book has been delivered by an angel, and it teaches of your eternal salvation. And each of you owns a true copy!

“Hold onto the lifeline of the gospel”

May the Lord bless each of you with your life's opportunities. Put your trust in Him to avoid the crevasses of sin and evil. Hold onto the lifeline of the gospel. You can make correct choices — the ones you know in your heart will be for your best good. We love you and testify of the truthfulness of the gospel of Christ. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Monson

Elder David B. Haight of the Council of the Twelve Apostles has just spoken to us.

We shall now be pleased to listen to Elder Joseph Anderson, who will celebrate his ninety-seventh birthday next month and who during his lifetime served as secretary to four Presidents of the Church, as an Assistant to the Twelve, and then as a member of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

Elder Joseph Anderson

Associations with prophets of God

I feel greatly honored in being invited to bear testimony regarding my acquaintance and relationship with the leadership of the Church during the past nearly sixty-five years.

The major part of my life has been devoted to association with prophets of the living God. It was in February 1922 that I became the secretary to the President of the Church, President Heber J. Grant, and I continued in that position until he passed away in 1945.

During the administrations of his successors, George Albert Smith, David O. McKay, Joseph Fielding Smith, and Harold B. Lee, I was secretary to the First Presidency; and I have served as a General Authority since 1970 with Presidents Joseph Fielding Smith, Harold B. Lee, Spencer W. Kimball, and Ezra Taft Benson. Over the years, these men have been sustained by the Church as prophets, seers, and revelators. Whenever the gospel has been on earth, there have been prophets of God, men holding the priesthood of God, through whom the Lord has made known His will.

What a glorious blessing it has been to serve with prophets and their associates! I think of the General Authorities today. I can testify to you that they are truly men of God. When we meet in the quorum and other meetings with these Brethren, the Spirit of the Lord is there in rich measure; particularly is this the case when we meet in the temple.

Keys of former dispensations restored through Joseph Smith

What about the Prophet Joseph Smith? Do you believe that he was a prophet? I want to testify that he was perhaps the greatest prophet who ever lived, except, of course, the Savior of the world. He gave the world a knowledge of the true and living God. Through Joseph, the Lord introduced

this, the greatest of all dispensations, the dispensation of the fulness of times. John the Baptist restored the keys of the Aaronic Priesthood, and Peter, James, and John restored the keys of the Melchizedek Priesthood. Joseph saw the Father and the Son, and at the dedication of the Kirtland Temple, Moses, Elias, and Elijah appeared to him and restored to him the keys of former dispensations. This is the last dispensation, a time of preparation for the coming of the Lord Jesus Christ in glory, His second coming. There were given to Joseph Smith the keys for carrying the message of life and salvation to the living and the dead.

The following is an excerpt from Joseph Smith's letter written in 1842 to Mr. John Wentworth of Chicago:

"No unhallowed hand can stop the work from progressing; persecutions may rage, mobs may combine, armies may assemble, calumny may defame, but the truth of God will go forth boldly, nobly, and independent, till it has penetrated every continent, visited every clime, swept every country, and sounded in every ear, till the purposes of God shall be accomplished, and the Great Jehovah shall say the work is done" (*History of the Church*, 4:540).

Living prophets given the keys to guide Israel

Those who have succeeded the Prophet Joseph Smith have been given these same keys that I have mentioned. Each of these Brethren of the General Authorities has been called of God, by prophecy and by the laying on of hands by those who are in authority to preach the gospel and administer in the ordinances thereof. They are set apart from all other men upon this earth. They are authorized by ordination to do things that no other men upon this earth can do.

President Lee said upon one occasion that just as the waters are purest at

the mountain source, the purest word of God, and the least apt to be polluted, is that which comes from the lips of the living prophets who are set up to guide Israel in our own day and time.

What a great prophet is our present President, Ezra Taft Benson, who, with his counselors, the Council of the Twelve, other General Authorities, and other inspired leadership, is directing the work of God under inspiration and revelation from the Lord Jesus Christ, who is our Savior and Redeemer.

President Grant's testimonies of early Church leaders

It has been my good fortune and blessing to have become somewhat acquainted with all the Presidents of the Church.

During my association with President Grant, we did much traveling together—on occasion going by train to New York and other places which required our being together in a drawing room on the train, normally for several days at a time.

President Grant became an Apostle in the days of John Taylor, who was with the Prophet Joseph in Carthage Jail at the time of the Prophet Joseph's martyrdom. President Grant knew Brigham Young, Orson Pratt, Wilford Woodruff, Lorenzo Snow, and others who served as Apostles during the leadership of the Prophet Joseph. President Grant retold to me on various occasions the testimonies and experi-

ences of those great men regarding the Prophet Joseph and the manifestations they personally enjoyed.

It was also my privilege to have in my custody the records of the General Authority council meetings held in the temple, which later council meetings I recorded during my many years as secretary. Yes, I have known all these Brethren in a very real sense.

Prophets of this dispensation know God and Christ

The Savior, in praying to our Heavenly Father just before his crucifixion, said, "This is life eternal, that they might know thee the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom thou hast sent" (John 17:3).

These Brethren to whom I have referred know God and Jesus Christ, whom He has sent.

I know that God lives, that Jesus is the Christ, that these Brethren whom I have mentioned were and are true prophets of the living God and have served and do serve under the direction of the Lord, who is the true head of the Church. I say this in the name of our Lord, Jesus Christ, amen.

President Monson

We have just listened to Elder Joseph Anderson, an emeritus member of the First Quorum of the Seventy. President Benson has invited me to say a few words on this occasion at this time on the program.

President Thomas S. Monson

Tonight, those who hold the priesthood fill the Tabernacle on Temple Square, have overflowed to the adjacent Assembly Hall, and are assembled in chapels and halls ranging in size from the mammoth Marriott Center at Brigham Young University to the smallest building located many miles away. All of you have come to be uplifted, to be instructed, to be inspired.

A favorite word of my nine-year-old granddaughter describes the responsibility to speak to such a vast throng: *awesome*.

Courage counts!

I seek your prayers; I need your faith; I petition our Heavenly Father for

that noble attribute of courage, for I know *courage counts!*

This truth came to me in a most vivid and dramatic manner some thirty-one years ago. I was serving as a bishop. The general session of our stake conference was being held in the Assembly Hall. Our stake presidency was to be reorganized. The Aaronic Priesthood, including members of bishoprics, were providing the music for the conference. As we concluded singing our first selection, President Joseph Fielding Smith, our conference visitor, stepped to the pulpit and read for sustaining approval the names of the new stake presidency. I am confident that the other members of the stake presidency had been made aware of their callings, but I had not. After reading my name, President Smith announced: "If Brother Monson is willing to respond to this call, we shall be pleased to hear from him now."

As I stood at the pulpit and gazed out on that sea of faces, I remembered the song we had just sung. Its title was "Have Courage, My Boy, to Say No." That day I selected as my acceptance theme, "Have Courage, My Boy, to Say Yes."

Life's journey is not traveled on a freeway devoid of obstacles, pitfalls, and snares. Rather, it is a pathway marked by forks and turnings. Decisions are constantly before us. To make them wisely, courage is needed: the courage to say *no*, the courage to say *yes*. Decisions do determine destiny.

The call for courage

The call for courage comes constantly to each of us. It has ever been so, and so shall it ever be. The battlefields of war witness acts of courage. Some are printed on pages of books or contained on rolls of film, while others are indelibly impressed on the human heart.

The courage of a military leader was recorded by a young infantryman wearing the gray uniform of the Confederacy during America's Civil War.

He describes the influence of General J.E.B. Stuart in these words: "At a critical point in the battle, he leaped his horse over the breastworks near my company, and when he had reached a point about the center of the brigade, while the men were loudly cheering him, he waved his hand toward the enemy and shouted, 'Forward men. Forward! Just follow me!'"

"The men were wild with enthusiasm. With courage and resolution, they poured over the breastworks after him like a raging torrent, and the objective was seized and held" (Emory M. Thomas, *Bold Dragoon: The Life of J.E.B. Stuart* [New York: Harper and Row, 1986]).

At an earlier time, and in a land far distant, another leader issued the same plea: "Follow me" (Matthew 4:19). He was not a general of war. Rather, He was the Prince of Peace, the Son of God. Those who followed Him then, and those who follow Him now, win a far more significant victory, with consequences that are everlasting. But the need for courage is constant. Courage is ever required.

Scriptural examples of courage

The holy scriptures portray the evidence of this truth. Joseph, son of Jacob, the same who was sold into Egypt, demonstrated the firm resolve of courage when to Potiphar's wife, who attempted to seduce him, he declared: "How . . . can I do this great wickedness, and sin against God? And . . . he hearkened not unto her" and got out (Genesis 39:9-10).

In our day, a father applied this example of courage to the lives of his children by declaring, "If you ever find yourself where you shouldn't ought to be, get out!"

The prophet Daniel demonstrated supreme courage by standing up for what he knew to be right and by demonstrating the courage to pray, though threatened by death were he to do so (see Daniel 6).

Courage characterized the life of Abinadi, as shown in the Book of Mor-

mon by his willingness to offer his life rather than to deny the truth. (See Mosiah 11:20, 17:20.)

Who can help but be inspired by the lives of the two thousand stripling sons of Helaman who taught and demonstrated the need of courage to follow the teachings of parents, the courage to be chaste and pure? (See Alma 56.)

Perhaps each of these accounts is crowned by the example of Moroni, who had the courage to persevere to the end in righteousness. (See Moroni 1-10.)

“He will not fail thee, nor forsake thee”

All were fortified by the words of Moses: “Be strong and of a good courage, fear not, nor be afraid: . . . for the Lord thy God, he it is that doth go with thee; he will not fail thee, nor forsake thee” (Deuteronomy 31:6). He did not fail them. He will not fail us. He did not forsake them. He will not forsake us.

It was this knowledge that prompted the courage of Columbus—the quiet resolve to record in his ship’s log again and again, “This day we sailed on.” It was this witness that motivated the Prophet Joseph to declare, “I am going like a lamb to the slaughter; but I am calm as a summer’s morning” (D&C 135:4).

Have courage to stand for principle

It is this sweet assurance that can guide you and me—in our time, in our day, in our lives. Of course we will face fear, experience ridicule, and meet opposition. Let us have the courage to defy the consensus, the courage to stand for principle. Courage, not compromise, brings the smile of God’s approval. Courage becomes a living and an attractive virtue when it is regarded not only as a willingness to die manfully, but as the determination to live decently. A moral coward is one who is afraid to do what he thinks is right because others will disapprove or laugh. Remember that all men have their

fears, but those who face their fears with dignity have courage as well.

From my personal chronology of courage, let me share with you two examples: one from military service, one from missionary experience.

Courage of a World War II seaman

Entering the United States Navy in the closing months of World War II was a challenging experience for me. I learned of brave deeds, acts of valor, and examples of courage. One best remembered was the quiet courage of an eighteen-year-old seaman—not of our faith—who was not too proud to pray. Of 250 men in the company, he was the only one who each night knelt down by the side of his bunk, at times amidst the jeers of the curious and the jests of unbelievers, and, with bowed head, prayed to God. He never wavered. He never faltered. He had courage.

Courage of Randall Ellsworth

Missionary service has ever called for courage. One who responded to this call was Randall Ellsworth. While serving in Guatemala as a missionary for The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, Randall Ellsworth survived a devastating earthquake that hurled a beam down on his back, paralyzing his legs and severely damaging his kidneys. He was the only American injured in the quake, which claimed the lives of some eighteen thousand persons.

After receiving emergency medical treatment, he was flown to a large hospital near his home in Rockville, Maryland. While Randall was confined there, a newscaster conducted with him an interview that I witnessed through the miracle of television. The reporter asked, “Can you walk?”

The answer: “Not yet, but I will.”

“Do you think you will be able to complete your mission?”

Came the reply: “Others think not, but I will. With the President of my church praying for me, and through the

prayers of my family, my friends, and my missionary companions, I will walk, and I will return again to Guatemala. The Lord wants me to preach the gospel there for two years, and that's what I intend to do."

There followed a lengthy period of therapy, punctuated by heroic yet silent courage. Little by little, feeling began to return to the almost lifeless limbs. More therapy, more courage, more prayer.

At last, Randall Ellsworth walked aboard the plane that carried him back to the mission to which he had been called—back to the people whom he loved. Behind he left a trail of skeptics and a host of doubters, but also hundreds amazed at the power of God, the miracle of faith, and the example of courage.

On his return to Guatemala, Randall Ellsworth supported himself with the help of two canes. His walk was slow and deliberate. Then one day, as he stood before his mission president, Elder Ellsworth heard these almost unbelievable words spoken to him. "You have been the recipient of a miracle," said the mission president. "Your faith has been rewarded. If you have the necessary confidence, if you have abiding faith, if you have supreme courage, place those two canes on my desk and walk."

After a long pause, first one cane and then the other was placed on the desk, and a missionary walked. It was

halting, it was painful—but he walked, never again to need the canes.

This spring I thought once more of the courage demonstrated by Randall Ellsworth. Years had passed since his ordeal. He was now a husband and a father. An engraved announcement arrived at my office. It read, "The President and Directors of Georgetown University announce commencement exercises of Georgetown University School of Medicine." Randall Ellsworth received his Doctor of Medicine degree. More effort, more study, more faith, more sacrifice, more courage had been required. The price was paid, the victory won.

My brethren, let us be active participants—not mere spectators—on the stage of priesthood power. May we muster courage at the crossroads, courage for the conflicts, courage to say *no*, courage to say *yes*, for *courage counts*. Of this truth I testify in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Monson

The choir and congregation will now join in singing "High on the Mountain Top," following which President Gordon B. Hinckley, First Counselor in the First Presidency, will speak to us.

The choir and congregation sang "High on the Mountain Top."

President Gordon B. Hinckley spoke without further announcement.

President Gordon B. Hinckley

I noted in the public press the other day that the war between Iran and Iraq has gone on for seven years. No one can ever estimate the terrible suffering incident to that conflict. Lives numbered in the tens of thousands have been lost. The terrible wounds of war have left bodies maimed and minds destroyed. Families have been left without fathers. Young boys who have been recruited as soldiers have died in many instances,

while those yet alive have had woven into the very fabric of their natures elements of hatred which will never leave them. The treasure of the involved nations has been wasted and will never be recovered.

To us who look upon it from afar it seems so unnecessary and such a terrible waste of human life and national resources. Seven years is a long time. "Will it ever end?" we ask.

The unceasing war between truth and error

But there is another war that has gone on since before the world was created and which is likely to continue for a long time yet to come. John the Revelator speaks of that struggle:

"And there was war in heaven: Michael and his angels fought against the dragon; and the dragon fought and his angels,

"And prevailed not; neither was their place found any more in heaven.

"And the great dragon was cast out, that old serpent, called the Devil, and Satan, which deceiveth the whole world: he was cast out into the earth, and his angels were cast out with him" (Revelation 12:7-9).

That war, so bitter, so intense, has gone on, and it has never ceased. It is the war between truth and error, between agency and compulsion, between the followers of Christ and those who have denied Him. His enemies have used every stratagem in that conflict. They've indulged in lying and deceit. They've employed money and wealth. They've tricked the minds of men. They've murdered and destroyed and engaged in every other unholy and impure practice to thwart the work of Christ.

The war during biblical times

It began in the earth when Cain slew Abel. The Old Testament is replete with accounts of the same eternal struggle.

It found expression in the vile accusations against the Man of Galilee, the Christ, who healed the sick and lifted men's hearts and hopes, He who taught the gospel of peace. His enemies, motivated by that evil power, seized Him, tortured Him, nailed Him to the cross, and spoke in mockery against Him. But by the power of His godhood, He overcame the death His enemies had inflicted and through His sacrifice brought salvation from death to all men.

The war after Christ's earthly ministry

That eternal war went on in the decay of the work He established, in the corruption which later infected it, when darkness covered the earth and gross darkness the people (see Isaiah 60:2).

But the forces of God could not be vanquished. The light of Christ touched the heart of a man here and a man there, and vast good came to pass notwithstanding much of oppression and suffering.

There came a time of renaissance, with struggles for liberty — struggles for which much of blood and sacrifice was paid. The Spirit of God moved upon men to found a nation wherein freedom of worship and freedom of expression and freedom of agency were protected. There followed then the opening of the dispensation of the fullness of times with a visit to earth of God the Eternal Father and His Beloved Son, the Resurrected Lord Jesus Christ. This glorious event was followed by visits of angels restoring the ancient keys and priesthood.

The war after the Restoration

But the war was not over. It was renewed and redirected. There was contempt. There was persecution. There were drivings from one place to another. There was the murder of the young prophet of God and of his beloved brother.

Our people fled their homes, their comfortable homes, their farms, their fields, their shops, their beautiful temple built at such tremendous sacrifice. They came to these valleys, thousands of them dying along the way. They came, as President Brigham Young said, to establish a place where "the Devil can't come and dig us out."

But the adversary has never stopped trying. Ninety years ago, in the October conference of 1896, President Wilford Woodruff, then an aged man,

standing where I stand in this Tabernacle," said:

"There are two powers on the earth and in the midst of the inhabitants of the earth — the power of God and the power of the devil. In our history we have had some very peculiar experiences. When God has had a people on the earth, it matters not in what age, Lucifer, the son of the morning, and the millions of fallen spirits that were cast out of heaven, have warred against God, against Christ, against the work of God, and against the people of God. And they are not backward in doing it in our day and generation. Whenever the Lord set His hand to perform any work, those powers labored to overthrow it" (*Deseret Evening News*, 17 Oct. 1896, p. 9).

President Woodruff knew whereof he spoke. He had then only recently passed through those difficult and perilous days when the government of the nation had come against our people, determined to destroy them. The buildings on this Temple Square, this tabernacle in which we meet tonight and the temple then under construction, were escheated to the federal government. Many citizens were disfranchised. But in faith they moved forward. They kept going. They put their trust in the Almighty, and He revealed unto them the path they should follow. In faith they accepted that revelation and walked in obedience.

The war continues today

But the war did not end. It abated somewhat, and we're grateful for that. Nonetheless, the adversary of truth has continued his struggle.

Notwithstanding the present strength of the Church, it seems that we are constantly under attack from one quarter or another. But we go on. We must go on. We have gone forward, and we will continue to go forward. In some seasons the issues are major. At other times they are only local skir-

mishes. But they are all part of a pattern.

Opposition to the construction of temples

In a few days we will dedicate the beautiful Denver Temple.

When it was announced that we would build a temple in that city and had selected a site on which it should stand, opposition rose against us. We gave up that site and tried another. Again we were thwarted. But we were determined to go forward, putting our trust in the Lord that He would guide us in accomplishing His purposes. Two other possible sites were selected. At the time, President Kimball and President Romney were both ill, and mine was a serious responsibility. I asked President Benson, then President of the Council of the Twelve, if we might go to Denver together, and there with Elder Russell Taylor we looked over these sites. I give you my testimony that we were guided by the Spirit in choosing the ground on which that beautiful new structure now stands. It will be dedicated later this month as a house of God.

We might expect that the adversary of righteousness would seek to thwart its construction and the work to be done therein. He had done so in the days of Kirtland when enemies threatened to push over the walls which were then being laid. He did so in the days of Far West when enemies drove our people from the state of Missouri. It was so in Nauvoo, where the temple had barely been completed when we were driven out. It was so here on this Temple Square when, during the forty years of the temple construction, there was one threat after another. I could describe problems in other places where today stand or will stand beautiful houses of the Lord.

We must be united in battle

Opposition has not come only in the construction of temples. It has been

felt in the undying efforts of many, both within and without the Church, to destroy faith, to belittle, to demean, to bear false witness, to tempt and allure and induce our people to practices inconsistent with the teachings and standards of this work of God.

Brethren, the war goes on. It is as it was in the beginning. There may not be the intensity, and I am grateful for that. But the principles at issue are the same. The victims who fall are as precious as those who have fallen in the past. It is an ongoing battle. We of the priesthood are all part of the army of the Lord. We must be united. An army that is disorganized will not be victorious. It is imperative that we close ranks, that we march together as one. We cannot have division among us and expect victory. We cannot have disloyalty and expect unity. We cannot be unclean and expect the help of the Almighty.

Young men, keep your minds and bodies strong

You boys who are here, you deacons, teachers, and priests, are all a part of this. The Lord has laid upon you in your priesthood offices the duty to preach the gospel, to teach the truth, to encourage the weak to be strong, to "invite all to come unto Christ" (D&C 20:59).

You cannot afford to partake of things that will weaken your minds and your bodies. These include cocaine, "crack," alcohol, tobacco. You cannot be involved in immoral activity. You cannot do these things and be valiant as warriors in the cause of the Lord in the great, everlasting contest that goes on for the souls of our Father's children.

Melchizedek Priesthood holders, be valiant

You men of the Melchizedek Priesthood, you cannot be unfaithful or untrue to your wives, to your families, to your priesthood responsibilities if you are to be valiant in moving the

work of the Lord forward in this great battle for truth and salvation. You cannot be dishonest and unscrupulous in your business affairs without tarnishing your armor.

In our meetings, we occasionally sing an old hymn:

*Who's on the Lord's side? Who?
Now is the time to show.
We ask it fearlessly:
Who's on the Lord's side? Who?
We wage no common war,
Cope with no common foe.
The enemy's awake;
Who's on the Lord's side? Who?
(Hymns, 1985, no. 260.)*

Commitment and devotion needed to win the war

I had a letter from a friend in the East the other day. He spoke of a conversation he had had with another member of the Church. He had asked his associate whether he felt close to his Heavenly Father. He replied that he did not feel close. Why not? He said, "Candidly, because I don't want to." Then he went on to say, "If I were close to Heavenly Father, He would probably want some commitment from me, and I am not ready for that."

Think of it — a man who has taken upon himself the name of the Lord in baptism, a man who has renewed his covenants with the Lord in his sacrament meetings, a man who has accepted the priesthood of God and yet has said that if he were close to his Heavenly Father, some commitment might be expected of him, and he was not ready for that.

In this work there must be commitment. There must be devotion. We are engaged in a great eternal struggle that concerns the very souls of the sons and daughters of God. We are not losing. We are winning. We will continue to win if we will be faithful and true. *We can do it. We must do it. We will do it.* There is nothing the Lord has asked of us that in faith we cannot accomplish.

Move forward in faith

I think of the children of Israel when they fled Egypt. They camped beside the Red Sea. Looking back, they saw Pharaoh and his armies coming to destroy them. Fear gripped their hearts. With the armies behind them and the sea before them they cried out in terror.

"And Moses said unto the people, Fear ye not, stand still, and see the salvation of the Lord, which he will shew to you to day: for the Egyptians whom ye have seen to day, ye shall see them again no more for ever.

"The Lord shall fight for you, and ye shall hold your peace.

"And the Lord said unto Moses, . . . speak unto the children of Israel, *that they go forward*" (Exodus 14:13-15; italics added).

The sea parted, and the children of Israel moved to their salvation. The Egyptians followed to their own destruction.

Shall we not also in faith move forward? He who is our eternal leader, the Lord Jesus Christ, has challenged us in words of revelation. Said He:

"Wherefore, lift up your hearts and rejoice, and gird up your loins, and take upon you my whole armor, that ye may be able to withstand the evil day. . . .

"Stand, therefore, having your loins girt about with truth, having on the breastplate of righteousness, and your feet shod with the preparation of the gospel of peace, which I have sent mine angels to commit unto you;

"Taking the shield of faith wherewith ye shall be able to quench all the fiery darts of the wicked;

"And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of my Spirit, . . . and be faithful until I come, and ye shall be caught up, that where I am ye shall be also" (D&C 27:15-18).

Each of us is involved in the war, and we are winning

The war goes on. It is waged across the world over the issues of

agency and compulsion. It is waged by an army of missionaries over the issues of truth and error. It is waged in our own lives, day in and day out, in our homes, in our work, in our school associations; it is waged over questions of love and respect, of loyalty and fidelity, of obedience and integrity. We are all involved in it — men and boys, each of us. We are winning, and the future never looked brighter.

God bless us, my beloved brethren of the priesthood, in the work that is so clearly laid out before us. May we be faithful. May we be valiant. May we have the courage to be true to the trust God has placed in each of us. May we be unafraid. "For [to quote the words of Paul to Timothy] God hath not given us the spirit of fear; but of power, and of love, and of a sound mind.

"Be not thou therefore ashamed of the testimony of our Lord" (2 Timothy 1:7-8).

In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Monson

We have just listened to President Gordon B. Hinckley, First Counselor in the First Presidency.

President Ezra Taft Benson, our beloved prophet leader, will be our concluding speaker.

Before President Benson speaks, we note that the nationwide CBS Tabernacle Choir broadcast will be from 9:30 to 10:00 Sunday morning. Those desiring to attend must be in their seats before 9:15 A.M.

As you leave this priesthood meeting tonight, we remind you to obey traffic rules, to use caution, and to be courteous in driving.

We are grateful to you brethren of the Tabernacle Choir and Mormon Youth Combined Men's Chorus for your inspiring music and express sincere thanks for the service you have given here tonight.

Following President Benson's closing remarks, the choir will sing

"The Priesthood of Our Lord." The benediction will be pronounced by

Elder Waldo P. Call of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

President Ezra Taft Benson

Privilege and responsibility of holding the priesthood

My beloved brethren: This night, as I look out over this great body of priesthood holders and think of the similar congregations throughout the world, I am stirred with a great sense of gratitude and joy for the blessings our Heavenly Father has given us.

The privilege of holding the priesthood, which is the power and authority to act in God's name, is a great blessing and privilege and one that carries with it equally great obligations and responsibilities. When I ponder what kind of men and boys we should be as priesthood holders, I cannot help but think of the Savior's questions to the Nephite twelve when He asked, "Therefore, what manner of men ought ye to be? Verily I say unto you, even as I am" (3 Nephi 27:27).

Our charge to be like the Savior

To be like the Savior—what a challenge for any person! He is a member of the Godhead. He is the Savior and Redeemer. He was perfect in every aspect of His life. There was no flaw nor failing in Him. Is it possible for us as priesthood holders to be even as He is? The answer is yes. Not only *can* we, but that is our charge, our responsibility. He would not give us that commandment if He did not mean for us to do it.

The Apostle Peter spoke of the process by which a person can be made a partaker "of the divine nature" (2 Peter 1:4). This is important, for if we truly become partakers of the divine nature, we shall become like Him. Let us examine closely what Peter teaches

us about this process. Here is what he said:

"And beside this, giving all diligence, add to your faith virtue; and to virtue knowledge;

"And to knowledge temperance; and to temperance patience; and to patience godliness;

"And to godliness brotherly kindness; and to brotherly kindness charity" (2 Peter 1:5–7).

The virtues outlined by Peter are part of the divine nature, or the Savior's character. These are the virtues we are to emulate if we would be more like Him. Let us discuss a few of these important traits.

Faith — the foundation for building a godlike character

The first characteristic, to which all the others are added, is *faith*. Faith is the foundation upon which a godlike character is built. It is a prerequisite for all other virtues.

When I think of how we show faith, I cannot help but think of the example of my own father. I recall vividly how the spirit of missionary work came into my life. I was about thirteen years of age when my father received a call to go on a mission. It was during an epidemic in our little community of Whitney, Idaho. Parents were encouraged to go to sacrament meeting, but the children were to remain home to avoid contracting the disease.

Father and Mother went to sacrament meeting in a one-horse buggy. At the close of the meeting, the storekeeper opened the store just long enough for the farmers to get their mail, since the post office was in the store. There were no purchases, but in this way the farmers saved a trip to the post

office on Monday. There was no rural postal delivery in those days.

As Father drove the horse homeward, Mother opened the mail, and, to their surprise, there was a letter from Box B in Salt Lake City — a call to go on a mission. No one asked if one were ready, willing, or able. The bishop was supposed to know, and the bishop was Grandfather George T. Benson, my father's father.

As Father and Mother drove into the yard, they were both crying — something we had never seen in our family. We gathered around the buggy — there were seven of us then — and asked them what was the matter.

They said, "Everything's fine."

"Why are you crying then?" we asked.

"Come into the living room and we'll explain."

We gathered around the old sofa in the living room, and Father told us about his mission call. Then Mother said: "We're proud to know that Father is considered worthy to go on a mission. We're crying a bit because it means two years of separation. You know, your father and I have never been separated more than two nights at a time since our marriage — and that's when Father was gone into the canyon to get logs, posts, and firewood."

And so Father went on his mission. Though at the time I did not fully comprehend the depths of my father's commitment, I understand better now that his willing acceptance of this call was evidence of his great faith. Every holder of the priesthood, whether young or old, should strive to develop that kind of faith.

Virtue — akin to holiness

Peter goes on to say that we must add to our faith *virtue*. A priesthood holder is *virtuous*. Virtuous behavior implies that he has pure thoughts and clean actions. He will not lust in his heart, for to do so is to "deny the faith" and to lose the Spirit (D&C 42:23) — and there is nothing more important in

this work than the Spirit. You've heard me say that many times.

He will not commit adultery "nor do anything like unto it" (D&C 59:6). This means fornication, homosexual behavior, self-abuse, child molestation, or any other sexual perversion. This means that a young man will honor young women and treat them with respect. He would never do anything that would deprive them of that which, in Mormon's words, is "most dear and precious above all things, which is chastity and virtue" (Moroni 9:9).

Virtue is akin to holiness, an attribute of godliness. A priesthood holder should actively seek for that which is virtuous and lovely and not that which is debasing or sordid. Virtue will garnish his thoughts unceasingly (see D&C 121:45). How can any man indulge himself in the evils of pornography, profanity, or vulgarity and consider himself totally virtuous?

Whenever a priesthood holder departs from the path of virtue in any form or expression, he loses the Spirit and comes under Satan's power. He then receives the wages of him whom he has chosen to serve. As a result, sometimes the Church must take disciplinary action, for we cannot condone or pardon unvirtuous and unrepentant actions. All priesthood holders must be morally clean to be worthy to bear the authority of Jesus Christ.

Knowledge — balance spiritual and secular learning

The next step Peter describes in the growth process is to add *knowledge* to our faith and virtue. The Lord has told us that "it is impossible for a man to be saved in ignorance" (D&C 131:6). In another place God commanded, "Seek ye out of the best books words of wisdom; seek learning, even by study and also by faith" (D&C 88:118). Every priesthood holder should make learning a lifetime pursuit. While any study of truth is of value, the truths of salvation are the most important truths any person can learn. The Lord's question, "For what is a man profited, if

he shall gain the whole world, and lose his own soul?" (Matthew 16:26) can be applied to educational pursuits as well as the pursuit of worldly goods. The Lord might also have asked, "For what is a man profited, if he shall learn everything in the world and not learn how to be saved?"

We must balance our secular learning with spiritual learning. You young men should be as earnest in enrolling in seminary and learning the scriptures as you are in working toward high school graduation. Young adults enrolled in universities and colleges or other postsecondary training should avail themselves of the opportunity to take institute of religion courses or, if attending a Church school, should take at least one religion course every term. Joining our spiritual education to our secular learning will help us keep focused on the things that matter most in this life. Though I am speaking to you priesthood holders, the same admonition applies to the women of the Church as well as to the men.

Spiritual learning must take first place

President J. Reuben Clark, Jr., spoke of the desired balance in these words: "There is spiritual learning just as there is material learning, and the one without the other is not complete; yet, speaking for myself, if I could have only one sort of learning, that which I would take would be the learning of the spirit, because in the hereafter I shall have opportunity in the eternities which are to come to get the other, and without spiritual learning here my handicaps in the hereafter would be all but overwhelming" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1934, p. 94).

President Spencer W. Kimball said it this way: "Youth, beloved youth, can you see why we must let spiritual training take first place?—Why we must pray with faith, and perfect our own lives like the Savior's? Can you see that the spiritual knowledge may be complemented with the

secular in this life and on for eternities but that the secular without the foundation of the spiritual is but like the foam upon the milk, the fleeting shadow?

"Do not be deceived! One need not choose between the two but only as to the sequence, for there is opportunity for one to get both simultaneously; but can you see that the seminary courses should be given even preferential attention over the high school subjects; the institute over the college course; the study of the scriptures ahead of the study of man-written texts; the association with the Church more important than clubs, fraternities, and sororities; the payment of tithing more important than paying tuitions and fees?

"Can you see that the ordinances of the temple are more important than the PhD or any and all other academic degrees?" ("Beloved Youth, Study and Learn," in *Life's Directions: A Series of Fireside Addresses* [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1962], p. 190).

When our formal education has been completed, we should make daily study of the scriptures a lifetime pursuit. What I said last April to priesthood leaders applies to every priesthood holder as well:

"I add my voice to these wise and inspired brethren and say to you that one of the most important things you can do as priesthood leaders is to immerse yourselves in the scriptures. Search them diligently. Feast upon the words of Christ. Learn the doctrine. Master the principles that are found therein. . . . Few other efforts . . . will bring greater dividends to your calling. . . . Few other ways [will result in] greater inspiration. . . .

"You must . . . see that studying and searching the scriptures is not a burden laid upon [us] by the Lord, but a marvelous blessing and opportunity" ("The Power of the Word," *Ensign*, May 1986, p. 81).

Temperance—have self-control

Another attribute described by Peter as being part of the divine nature

is *temperance*. A priesthood holder is *temperate*. This means he is restrained in his emotions and verbal expressions. He does things in moderation and is not given to overindulgence. In a word, he has self-control. He is the master of his emotions, not the other way around.

A priesthood holder who would curse his wife, abuse her with words or actions, or do the same to one of his own children is guilty of grievous sin. "Can ye be angry, and not sin?" asked the Apostle Paul (JST, Ephesians 4:26).

If a man does not control his temper, it is a sad admission that he is not in control of his thoughts. He then becomes a victim of his own passions and emotions, which lead him to actions that are totally unfit for civilized behavior, let alone behavior for a priesthood holder.

President David O. McKay once said, "A man who cannot control his temper is not very likely to control his passion, and no matter what his pretensions in religion, he moves in daily life very close to the animal plane" (*Improvement Era*, June 1958, p. 407).

Patience — be understanding and learn to wait on the Lord

To our temperance we are to add *patience*. A priesthood holder is to be *patient*. Patience is another form of self-control. It is the ability to postpone gratification and to bridle one's passions. In his relationships with loved ones, a patient man does not engage in impetuous behavior that he will later regret. Patience is composure under stress. A patient man is understanding of others' faults.

A patient man also waits on the Lord. We sometimes read or hear of people who seek a blessing from the Lord, then grow impatient when it does not come swiftly. Part of the divine nature is to trust in the Lord enough to "be still and know that [he is] God" (D&C 101:16).

A priesthood holder who is patient will be tolerant of the mistakes and failings of his loved ones. Because he

loves them, he will not find fault nor criticize nor blame.

Kindness — extend this to all

Another attribute mentioned by Peter is *kindness*. A priesthood holder is *kind*. One who is kind is sympathetic and gentle with others. He is considerate of others' feelings and courteous in his behavior. He has a helpful nature. Kindness pardons others' weaknesses and faults. Kindness is extended to all — to the aged and the young, to animals, to those low of station as well as the high.

These are the true attributes of the divine nature. Can you see how we become more Christlike as we are more virtuous, more kind, more patient, and more in control of our emotional feelings?

The Apostle Paul used some vivid expressions to illustrate that a member of the Church must be different from the world. He commended us to "put on Christ" (Galatians 3:27), "put off . . . the old man," and "put on the new man" (Ephesians 4:22, 24).

Charity — "the greatest of all"

The final and crowning virtue of the divine character is *charity*, or the pure love of Christ (see Moroni 7:47). If we would truly seek to be more like our Savior and Master, then learning to love as He loves should be our highest goal. Mormon called charity "the greatest of all" (Moroni 7:46).

The world today speaks a great deal about love, and it is sought for by many. But the pure love of Christ differs greatly from what the world thinks of love. Charity never seeks selfish gratification. The pure love of Christ seeks only the eternal growth and joy of others.

When I think of charity, I again think of my father and that day he was called on his mission. I suppose some in the world might say that his acceptance of that call was proof he did not really love his family. To leave seven

children and an expectant wife at home alone for two years, how could that be true love?

But my father knew a greater vision of love. He knew that "all things shall work together for good to them that love God" (Romans 8:28). He knew that the best thing he could do for his family was to obey God.

While we missed him greatly during those years, and while his absence brought many challenges to our family, his acceptance proved to be a gift of charity. Father went on his mission, leaving Mother at home with seven children. (The eighth was born four months after he arrived in the field.) But there came into that home a spirit of missionary work that never left it. It was not without some sacrifice. Father had to sell our old dry farm in order to finance his mission. He had to move a married couple into part of our home to take care of the row crops, and he left his sons and wife the responsibility for the hay land, the pasture land, and a small herd of dairy cows.

Father's letters were indeed a blessing to our family. To us children, they seemed to come from halfway around the world, but they were only from Springfield, Massachusetts; and Chicago, Illinois; and Cedar Rapids and Marshalltown, Iowa. Yes, there came into our home, as a result of Father's mission, a spirit of missionary work that never left it.

Later the family grew to eleven children, seven sons and four daughters. All seven sons filled missions, some of them two or three missions. Later, two daughters and their husbands filled full-time missions. The two other sisters, both widows — one the mother of eight and the other the mother of ten — served as missionary companions in Birmingham, England.

It is a legacy that still continues to bless the Benson family even into the third and fourth generations. Was not this truly a gift of love?

"Become partakers of the divine nature"

This is what the Savior means when He speaks of the kind of men we should be. Does not His own life reflect perfect diligence, perfect faith, perfect virtue? If we are to be like Him, we too must become partakers of the divine nature.

The Savior declared that life eternal is to know the only true God and His Son Jesus Christ (see John 17:3). If this is true, and I bear you my solemn witness that it is true, then we must ask how we come to know God. The process of adding one godly attribute to another, as described by Peter, becomes the key to gaining this knowledge that leads to eternal life. Note Peter's promise, which immediately follows the process described:

"For if these things be in you, *and abound*, they make you that ye shall neither be barren nor unfruitful in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ" (2 Peter 1:8; italics added).

Oh, my beloved brethren, I pray that these qualities and attributes of the Savior may abound in us so that when we stand at the Judgment and He asks each one of us, "What manner of man are you?" we can raise our heads in gratitude and joy and answer, "Even as thou art." This is my humble prayer for each and every priesthood holder in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

Statement: stake seventies quorums to be discontinued

Now, brethren, I would like to read to you a statement recently approved by the First Presidency and the Quorum of the Twelve:

"In harmony with the needs of the growth of the Church across the world, the First Presidency and Council of the Twelve Apostles have given prayerful consideration to the role of the stake seventies quorums in the Church and have determined to take the following action relative thereto:

"1. The seventies quorums in the stakes of the Church are to be discontinued, and the brethren now serving as seventies in these quorums will be asked to return to membership in the elders quorums of their wards. Stake presidents, in an orderly fashion, may then determine who among such brethren should be ordained to the office of high priest.

"This change does not affect the First Quorum of the Seventy, members of which are all General Authorities of the Church.

"2. Particular emphasis is to be given in stake missions to cooperating with the full-time proselyting missionaries by finding, friendshiping, fellowshipping, and fostering member participation in all missionary activities. A missionary-minded elder or

high priest will be called as the stake mission president with his counselors being selected from among the elders or high priests.

"Additional detailed instructions regarding this announcement will be provided local priesthood leaders by letter from the First Presidency.

"At this time, we commend all who have served both past and present as members of stake seventies quorums of the Church and who have so ably given of their time, talents, and resources in spreading forth the gospel of Jesus Christ."

The choir sang "Priesthood of Our Lord."

Elder Waldo P. Call offered the benediction.

SECOND DAY MORNING MEETING

FOURTH SESSION

The fourth session of the 156th Semiannual General Conference commenced at 10:00 A.M. on Sunday, October 5, 1986. President Ezra Taft Benson conducted.

The Tabernacle Choir provided the music with Jerold Ottley directing and Robert Cundick at the organ.

Prior to the opening of the session, the choir sang "Arise, O God, and Shine" without announcement.

President Benson made the following remarks:

President Ezra Taft Benson

We welcome all who are in attendance for this, the fourth general session of the 156th Semiannual General Conference of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.

We also extend our greeting to all who are seated in the Assembly Hall, where Elders George P. Lee and Rex C.

Reeve are seated on the stand, and to the many others who are participating by radio, television, or cable—with time offered by owners and operators, to whom we are indebted—or by satellite transmission.

We acknowledge the presence this morning of government, education, and civic affairs leaders, and officers and members of the Church from many lands who have assembled to worship and to counsel together in this conference.

The Tabernacle Choir, under the direction of Brother Jerold Ottley with Brother Robert Cundick at the organ, is providing the music for this session.

The choir opened these services by singing "Arise, O God, and Shine" and will now sing "More Holiness Give Me," following which Elder Robert L. Backman, a member of the Presidency of the First Quorum of the Seventy, will offer the invocation.

The choir sang "More Holiness Give Me."

Elder Robert L. Backman offered the invocation.

President Benson

We shall now be pleased to listen to President Gordon B. Hinckley, First Counselor in the First Presidency.

President Gordon B. Hinckley

Know God and Jesus Christ

My brethren and sisters, I have chosen a text this morning that is familiar to all of you. It is the first article of our faith. It is the pivotal position of our religion. It is significant that in setting forth the primary elements of our doctrine, the Prophet Joseph put this number one.

"We believe in God, the Eternal Father, and in His son, Jesus Christ, and in the Holy Ghost."

The preeminence given that declaration is in accord with another statement the Prophet made. Said he:

"It is the first principle of the gospel to know for a certainty the character of God" (*History of the Church*, 6:305).

These tremendously significant and overarching declarations are in harmony with the words of the Lord in His great intercessory prayer:

"And this is life eternal, that they might know thee the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom thou hast sent" (John 17:3).

I was handed a tract the other day. It was written by a critic, an enemy of the Church whose desire is to undermine the faith of the weak and the unknowing. It repeats fallacies that have been parroted for a century and more. It purports to set forth what you and I, as members of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, believe.

Without wishing to argue with any of our friends of other faiths, many of whom I know and for whom I have the highest regard, I take this occasion to set forth my position on this most important of all theological subjects.

Testimony of God

I believe without equivocation or reservation in God, the Eternal Father. He is my Father, the Father of my spirit, and the Father of the spirits of all men. He is the great Creator, the Ruler of the Universe. He directed the creation of this earth on which we live. In His image man was created. He is personal. He is real. He is individual. He has "a body of flesh and bones as tangible as man's" (D&C 130:22).

In the account of the creation of the earth, "God said, Let us make man in our image, after our likeness" (Genesis 1:26).

Could any language be more explicit? Does it demean God, as some would have us believe, that man was created in His express image? Rather, it should stir within the heart of every man and woman a greater appreciation for himself or herself as a son or daughter of God. Paul's words to the Corinthian Saints are as applicable to us today as they were to those to whom he wrote. Said he:

"Know ye not that ye are the temple of God, and that the Spirit of God dwelleth in you?"

"If any man defile the temple of God, him shall God destroy; for the temple of God is holy, which temple ye are" (1 Corinthians 3:16-17).

God has a body

I remember the occasion of more than fifty years ago when, as a missionary, I was speaking in an open-air meeting in Hyde Park, London. As I was presenting my message, a heckler inter-

rupted to say, "Why don't you stay with the doctrine of the Bible which says in John [4:24], 'God is a Spirit'?"

I opened my Bible to the verse he had quoted and read to him the entire verse:

"God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth."

I said, "Of course God is a spirit, and so are you, in the combination of spirit and body that makes of you a living being, and so am I."

Each of us is a dual being of spiritual entity and physical entity. All know of the reality of death when the body dies, and each of us also knows that the spirit lives on as an individual entity and that at some time, under the divine plan made possible by the sacrifice of the Son of God, there will be a reunion of spirit and body. Jesus' declaration that God is a spirit no more denies that he has a body than does the statement that I am a spirit while also having a body.

God is all-powerful and all-loving

I do not equate my body with His in its refinement, in its capacity, in its beauty and radiance. His is eternal. Mine is mortal. But that only increases my reverence for Him. I worship Him "in spirit and in truth." I look to Him as my strength. I pray to Him for wisdom beyond my own. I seek to love Him with all my heart, might, mind, and strength. His wisdom is greater than the wisdom of all men. His power is greater than the power of nature, for He is the Creator Omnipotent. His love is greater than the love of any other, for His love encompasses all of His children, and it is His work and His glory to bring to pass the immortality and eternal life of His sons and daughters of all generations (see Moses 1:39).

He "so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life" (John 3:16).

This is the Almighty of whom I stand in awe and reverence. It is He to

whom I look in fear and trembling. It is He whom I worship and unto whom I give honor and praise and glory. He is my Heavenly Father, who has invited me to come unto Him in prayer, to speak with Him, with the promised assurance that He will hear and respond.

Thanks be to God

I thank Him for the light and knowledge and understanding He has bestowed upon His children. I thank Him for His voice, which has spoken eternal truth with power and promise. I thank Him for His revelation of Himself as set forth in the Old Testament, for His declaration, as set forth in the New Testament, at the baptism of His Beloved Son in the waters of Jordan when His voice was heard saying, "This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased" (Matthew 3:17).

I thank Him for His similar declaration on the Mount of Transfiguration when He spoke again to Jesus and His Apostles, and angels also, when "after six days Jesus taketh Peter, James, and John his brother, and bringeth them up into an high mountain apart,

"And was transfigured before them: and his face did shine as the sun, and his raiment was white as the light.

"And, behold, there appeared unto them Moses and Elias talking with him.

"Then answered Peter, and said unto Jesus, Lord, it is good for us to be here: if thou wilt, let us make here three tabernacles; one for thee, and one for Moses, and one for Elias.

"While he yet spake, behold, a bright cloud overshadowed them: and behold a voice out of the cloud, which said, This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased; hear ye him" (Matthew 17:1-5).

I thank Him for that voice again heard when the risen Lord was introduced to the people of this hemisphere with the voice of God declaring, "Behold my Beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased, in whom I have glorified my name" (3 Nephi 11:7).

I stand in awe and reverence and gratitude for His appearance in this dispensation when, as He introduced the risen Lord to one who had sought Him in prayer, the Father declared: "This is My Beloved Son. Hear Him!" (Joseph Smith—History 1:17).

Testimony of the Lord Jesus Christ

I believe in the Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of the eternal, living God. I believe in Him as the Firstborn of the Father and the Only Begotten of the Father in the flesh. I believe in Him as an individual, separate and distinct from His Father. I believe in the declaration of John, who opened his gospel with this majestic utterance:

"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.

"The same was in the beginning with God. . . .

"And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth" (John 1:1-2, 14).

I believe that He was born of Mary of the lineage of David as the promised Messiah, that He was in very deed begotten of the Father, and that in His birth was the fulfillment of the great prophetic declaration of Isaiah:

"For unto us a child is born, unto us a son is given: and the government shall be upon his shoulder: and his name shall be called Wonderful, Counsellor, The mighty God, The everlasting Father, The Prince of Peace" (Isaiah 9:6).

I believe that in His mortal life He was the one perfect man to walk the earth. I believe that in His words are to be found that light and truth which, if observed, would save the world and bring exaltation to mankind. I believe that in His priesthood rests divine authority—the power to bless, the power to heal, the power to govern in the earthly affairs of God, the power to bind in the heavens that which is bound upon the earth.

Christ's atoning sacrifice

I believe that through His atoning sacrifice, the offering of His life on Calvary's Hill, He expiated the sins of mankind, relieving us from the burden of sin if we will forsake evil and follow Him. I believe in the reality and the power of His resurrection. I believe in the grace of God made manifest through His sacrifice and redemption, and I believe that through His atonement, without any price on our part, each of us is offered the gift of resurrection from the dead. I believe further that through that sacrifice there is extended to every man and woman, every son and daughter of God, the opportunity for eternal life and exaltation in our Father's kingdom, as we hearken and obey His commandments.

None so great has ever walked the earth. None other has made a comparable sacrifice or granted a comparable blessing. He is the Savior and the Redeemer of the world. I believe in Him. I declare His divinity without equivocation or compromise. I love Him. I speak His name in reverence and wonder. I worship Him as I worship His Father, in spirit and in truth. I thank Him and kneel before His wounded feet and hands and side, amazed at the love He offers me.

God be thanked for His Beloved Son who reached out long ago and said to each of us:

"Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.

"Take my yoke upon you, and learn of me; for I am meek and lowly in heart: and ye shall find rest unto your souls.

"For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light" (Matthew 11:28-30).

Christ is the living, resurrected Son of God

He lives, the firstfruits of the Resurrection. I know He lives today as really, as certainly, as individually, as He lived when, as the risen Lord, He

beckoned His discouraged disciples to "come and dine. . . . And [He] taketh bread, and giveth them, and fish likewise" (John 21:12-13).

The scripture tells of others to whom He showed Himself and with whom He spoke, as the living, resurrected Son of God.

Likewise in this dispensation He has appeared, and those who saw Him declared:

"And now, after the many testimonies which have been given of him, this is the testimony, last of all, which we give of him: That he lives!

"For we saw him, even on the right hand of God; and we heard the voice bearing record that he is the Only Begotten of the Father—

"That by him, and through him, and of him, the worlds are and were created, and the inhabitants thereof are begotten sons and daughters unto God" (D&C 76:22-24).

This is the Christ in whom I believe and of whom I testify.

The Holy Ghost is the third member of the Godhead

That knowledge comes from the word of scripture, and that testimony comes by the power of the Holy Ghost. It is a gift, sacred and wonderful, borne by revelation from the third member of the Godhead. I believe in the Holy Ghost as a personage of spirit who occupies a place with the Father and the Son, these three comprising the divine Godhead.

The importance of that place is made clear from the words of the Lord who said:

"All manner of sin and blasphemy shall be forgiven unto men: but the blasphemy against the Holy Ghost shall not be forgiven unto men.

"And whosoever speaketh a word against the Son of man, it shall be forgiven him: but whosoever speaketh against the Holy Ghost, it shall not

be forgiven him, neither in this world, neither in the world to come" (Matthew 12:31-32).

That the Holy Ghost was recognized in ancient times as a member of the Godhead is evident from the conversation between Peter and Ananias when the latter held back a part of the price received from the sale of a piece of land.

"But Peter said, Ananias, why hath Satan filled thine heart to lie to the Holy Ghost? . . . thou hast not lied unto men, but unto God" (Acts 5:3-4).

The Holy Ghost stands as the third member of the Godhead, the Comforter promised by the Savior who would teach His followers all things and bring all things to their remembrance, whatsoever He had said unto them (see John 14:26).

The Holy Ghost is the Testifier of Truth, who can teach men things they cannot teach one another. In those great and challenging words of Moroni, a knowledge of the truth of the Book of Mormon is promised "by the power of the Holy Ghost." Moroni then declares, "And by the power of the Holy Ghost ye may know the truth of all things" (Moroni 10:4-5).

I believe this power, this gift, is available to us today.

Members of the Godhead are real and individual

And so, my beloved brethren and sisters, I believe in God, the Eternal Father, and in His Son, Jesus Christ, and in the Holy Ghost.

I was baptized in the name of these three. I was married in the name of these three. I have no question concerning their reality and their individuality. That individuality was made apparent when Jesus was baptized by John in Jordan. There in the water stood the Son of God. His Father's voice was heard declaring His divine Sonship, and the Holy Ghost was manifest in the form of a dove (see Matthew 3:16-17).

I am aware that Jesus said that they who had seen Him had seen the Father. Could not the same be said by many a son who resembles his parent?

When Jesus prayed to the Father, certainly He was not praying to Himself!

Members of the Godhead are perfectly united

They are distinct beings, but they are one in purpose and effort. They are united as one in bringing to pass the grand, divine plan for the salvation and exaltation of the children of God.

In His great, moving prayer in the Garden before His betrayal, Christ pleaded with His Father concerning the Apostles, whom He loved, saying:

"Neither pray I for these alone, but for them also which shall believe on me through their word;

"That they all may be one; as thou, Father, art in me, and I in thee, that they also may be one in us" (John 17:20-21).

It is that perfect unity between the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost that binds these three into the oneness of the divine Godhead.

Miracle of miracles and wonder of wonders, they are interested in us, and we are the substance of their great concern. They are available to each of us. We approach the Father through the Son. He is our intercessor at the throne of God. How marvelous it is that we may so speak to the Father in the name of the Son.

I bear witness of these great, transcendent truths. I do so by the gift and power of the Holy Ghost, in the sacred name of Jesus Christ, amen.

The choir sang "Lord Accept into Thy Kingdom" and "We Ever Pray for Thee" without announcement.

President Benson

President Gordon B. Hinckley, First Counselor in the First Presidency, has just spoken to us, followed by the Tabernacle Choir singing "Lord Accept into Thy Kingdom" and "We Ever Pray for Thee."

Elder Neal A. Maxwell of the Council of the Twelve Apostles will now address us.

Elder Neal A. Maxwell

The holy scriptures represent mankind's spiritual memory. And when man's connection with scripture is severed, mortals are tragically deprived of an awareness of spiritual history, blinding the eyes of faith. Thereby shorn of true identity, mortals keep their legs intact, but each walks in his own way. Their arms are acquisitive, but do not reach out in an understanding embrace of life. Their ears function, but they no longer hear the word of the Lord. Though created in God's image, those thus severed soon forget their Maker. Yet it is not surprising, "For how knoweth a man the master whom he has not served, and who is a stranger unto him, and is far from the

thoughts and intents of his heart?" (Mosiah 5:13).

"God will yet reveal many great and important things"

By contrast, one of the unique features of the living Church of Jesus Christ is its ever-expanding body of fundamental spiritual knowledge about man's identity and purpose, which enlarges "the memory of this people" (Alma 37:8). In fact, our ninth article of faith declares that God "will yet reveal many great and important things pertaining to the Kingdom of God." Thus nourished by a menu blending antiquity and futurity, Church mem-

bers need never "faint in [their] minds" (Hebrews 12:3). Instead, we can be intellectually vibrant.

Lost books are among the treasures yet to come forth. Over twenty of these are mentioned in the existing scriptures. Perhaps most startling and voluminous will be the records of the lost tribes of Israel (see 2 Nephi 29:13). We would not even know of the impending third witness for Christ except through the precious Book of Mormon, the second witness for Christ! This third set of sacred records will thus complete a triad of truth. Then, just as the Perfect Shepherd has said, "My word also shall be gathered in one" (v. 14). There will be "one fold and one shepherd" (1 Nephi 22:25) in a welding together of all the Christian dispensations of human history (see D&C 128:18).

Whereas previous prophets were sometimes left to surmise — as Moroni supposed the Jews also had a record of the Creation from Adam on down (see Ether 1:3) — ours, instead, is a time of fulness, including "things which never have been revealed from the foundation of the world" (D&C 128:18). Moreover, "and the day cometh that the words of the book which were sealed shall be read upon the house tops; and they shall be read by the power of Christ; and all things shall be revealed unto the children of men which ever have been among the children of men, and which ever will be even unto the end of the earth" (2 Nephi 27:11; see also 2 Nephi 30:16, 18; Ether 4:7; D&C 101:32, 121:28).

Thus, just as there will be many more Church members, families, wards, stakes, and temples — later on, there will also be many more nourishing and inspiring scriptures. However, we must first feast worthily upon that which we already have!

Scriptures essential to belief in God and his plan

Without this precious, spiritual perspective, the human family is sel-

dom more than one generation away from deep doubt and even disbelief. Laman and Lemuel doubted and murmured because, wrote Nephi, "they knew not the dealings of that God who had created them" (1 Nephi 2:12); they were provincial, just like forgetful Israel: "and there arose another generation after them, which knew not the Lord, nor yet the works which he had done for Israel" (Judges 2:10; see also Deuteronomy 32:6, Mosiah 10:14).

If people are without the truths of God's plan of salvation for very long, some may not even "believe [these truths] when they are taught" (Mosiah 1:5). An untaught "rising generation" comes not to "believe . . . concerning the resurrection, . . . neither . . . the coming of Christ" (Mosiah 26:1-2). Belief in Deity and in the resurrection are usually the first to go: "they had brought no records with them; and they denied the being of their Creator" (Omni 1:17).

Our loving Father is ever anxious to dispel such ignorance:

"And after God had appointed that these things should come unto man, behold, then he saw that it was expedient that man should know concerning the things whereof he had appointed unto them;

"Therefore he sent angels to converse with them. . . .

" . . . And made known unto them the plan of redemption, which had been prepared from the foundation of the world; and this he made known unto them according to their faith and repentance and their holy works" (Alma 12:28-30).

The message is ever constant and ever relevant:

"Is it not as necessary that the plan of redemption should be made known unto this people as well as unto their children?

"Is it not as easy at this time for the Lord to send his angel to declare these glad tidings unto us as unto our children, or as after the time of his coming?" (Alma 39:18-19).

Revelation necessary to understand God's plan

Today's mortals, born long "after the time of his [first] coming," surely need to know of the plan, which gives, said the Prophet Joseph Smith, "a comprehensive view of our condition and true relation to God." The Prophet said this subject should be studied "more than any other, . . . day and night" (*Teachings of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, sel. Joseph Fielding Smith [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1938], p. 324).

God's plan, however, is not something to be deduced by logic alone, nor is human experience deep enough or long enough to inform us adequately. It requires revelation from God.

"Behold, great and marvelous are the works of the Lord. How unsearchable are the depths of the mysteries of him; and it is impossible that man should find out all his ways. And no man knoweth of his ways save it be revealed unto him; wherefore, brethren, despise not the revelations of God" (Jacob 4:8).

How else would we really know the truth of who we really were, "really are, and . . . really will be"? (Jacob 4:13; see also D&C 93:24). There can be no true felicity without true identity.

Therefore, the process of revelation typically involves angels and prophets (see Alma 12:28–29). Several times in the closing period of his life, Joseph Smith noted the fourteen years of particularly intensive revelation which he had experienced, including angelic visitations (see *Teachings of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, pp. 349, 360; *The Personal Writings of Joseph Smith*, comp. Dean C. Jessee [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1984], p. 407).

Importance of this dispensation's revelations

The Restoration's Messiah-centered scriptures expand mankind's spiritual memory significantly and further educate

us concerning the unfolding of God's plan ever since the world began. The Restoration has provided sweeping sermons about God's plan with its rescuing Redeemer, such as from Moses, Abinadi, Ether, Alma, Ammon, and Aaron (see Mosiah 13:33–35; Ether 13:2–14; Alma 12:30–33, 18:36–39, 22:12–14). These answer the rhetorical question of one prophet who said, "Why not speak of the atonement of Christ?" (Jacob 4:12). Brothers and sisters, given man's true self-interest, why should we really speak much of anything else?

Read scriptures with a believing attitude

He who truly searches the scriptures will surely see how they testify of Christ (see John 5:39). He will also see how interactive and cross-supportive the scriptures are. If some see not, it will be "because they sought it not by faith" (Romans 9:32), but instead stared uncomprehendingly with slit-eyed skepticism. Said Jesus to the unseeing:

"For had ye believed Moses, ye would have believed me: for he wrote of me.

"But if ye believe not his writings, how shall ye believe my words?" (John 5:46–47).

Those who understood and believed not *that* which Moses wrote did not, in effect, believe *this* which Jesus spoke. This episode underscores the important words of Mormon about the relationship of the biblical record and the Book of Mormon:

"For behold, *this* is written for the intent that ye may believe *that*; and if ye believe *that* ye will believe *this* also."

Mutually supportive, the scriptures produce much-needed historical perspective "concerning your fathers, and also the marvelous works which were wrought by the power of God among them" (Mormon 7:9; italics added).

Scriptures reveal God's purposes

The various scriptures tell us vital things about God's "tender mercies" (1 Nephi 1:20, Ether 6:12; see also Luke 1:78) and His dealings with our predecessors. What is past is truly prologue; hence an unvarying, all-seeing God, desiring to save mercurial and myopic man, is not interested in our retroactive adulation, but in preventing our prospective ruin.

Thus, it is from the scriptures that we learn of God's plans for mankind on this planet. He told us, through Isaiah, that He formed this earth to be inhabited (see Isaiah 45:18). Through Moses, God described His purpose: "to bring to pass the immortality and eternal life of man" (Moses 1:39). Furthermore, by viewing the heavens and the galaxies, those who have eyes to see will see "God moving in His majesty and power" (D&C 88:47).

We are thus enveloped in a planned universe, and we live on a purposeful planet; and these truths describe "things as they really are" (Jacob 4:13). No wonder the gospel is such glorious and good news!

Scriptures provide "precious perspective"

If ever a generation needed this precious perspective, our severed generation does. If ever a generation needed to be saved from itself, ours does. Surely these needs will intensify as the bewildered and beset nations of the earth, as foreseen by Jesus, wallow hopelessly in distress, "with perplexity" (Luke 21:25).

In fact, we misread and misuse life — except with this plain and precious perspective of the gospel, which puts the things of the world in their lesser places. Then, on that essentially unchanging mortal stage, we can see things for what they really are, such as the demanding cadence called for by the cares of the world. Like birds and animals performing some inborn ritual, amusing to everyone but the partici-

pants, these maneuverings of materialism would be comedy if they were not tragedy. So would the posturings as to power and the thirsty seeking of the praise of the world. The plays are so transparent when seen in the gospel's light.

Share in God's attributes to share in his power

Nevertheless, why are the ways of the world felt even by serious disciples so insistently and so incessantly? Could it be that in the far distant, premortal past, having admired the Father and having seen His glory, we now unconsciously envy His glory? Yet, if we really wish to share in His kingdom, why do we sternly resist what the revelations tell us of the required preparatory schooling and the risks of unrighteous power? God's ultimate power is safe, precisely because He possesses ultimate love, justice, mercy, and knowledge. We cannot share in His power without sharing in His attributes.

But, we may say, do we not have His spiritual genes? Yes, but we do not have His gentleness.

Yet we are of His spiritual lineage! Yes, but we do not have His capacity to love.

Surely, we belong to Him! Of course, but we cannot reenter His house until our behavior would let us feel at home.

Importance of prophetic utterances

No wonder the prophets are repetitious in their warnings. After all, if one were permitted only a few surviving lines to family, friends, and posterity, those might be headlines. Sometimes what comes is almost a warning shout, especially when hearers are unstirred by the still, small voice (see Jacob 6:8–13, Moroni 10:27–34).

Besides, the prophets, who are the major makers of our spiritual memory, saw not only their own times, but ours as well; they have communicated with us as

if we were present, for "behold, Jesus Christ hath shown you unto me, and I know your doing" (Mormon 8:35).

Little wonder that Joseph Smith, in his last witnessing words from Carthage Jail the night before he was slain, bore "powerful testimony to the guards of the divine authenticity of the Book of Mormon, the restoration of the Gospel, the administration of angels" (*Teachings of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, p. 383; see also Alma 9:21, 12:29, 19:34).

Without the prophets, the scriptures, how else would we really know about what "God had appointed . . . unto man . . . the plan of redemption"? (Alma 12:28, 30).

When searched, the scriptural truths of the unfolding plan of salvation are both electrifying and subduing. Gratefully pondered, they lead to lyrical expressions, such as in the 1842 litany by the Prophet Joseph Smith: "And again, what do we hear? Glad tidings from Cumorah! Moroni, an angel from heaven, declaring the fulfillment of the prophets — the book to be revealed. A voice of the Lord in the wilderness . . . declaring the three witnesses to bear record of the book! The voice of Michael on the banks of the Susquehanna! . . . The voice of Peter, James, and John in the wilderness . . . declaring themselves as possessing the keys of the kingdom, and of the dispensation of the fulness of times!" (D&C 128:20).

A crescendo of revelations to precede Christ's coming

Future revelations, brothers and sisters, will include astounding events as well as great and important truths. So much so, that Moses' and Israel's exulting song after safely crossing the

Red Sea (see Exodus 15) and the Prophet Joseph's 1842 litany will gladly give way to the crescendo of glorious events associated with Christ's coming in majesty and power.

The valley of Adam-ondi-Ahman will ring again — this time with the sounds of dispensational reunion, as it glows with gathering! (See Daniel 7:13–14; D&C 107:53–57, 116:1.) Those of Enoch's utterly unique city of "one heart" will greet those of the New Zion with holy embraces and holy kisses amid the sounds of sweet sobbing! (See Moses 7:62–63.) The "hills shall tremble" at the presence of the lost tribes, and hearts, as well as ice, will melt, as they come "filled with songs of everlasting joy" (see D&C 133:26–33).

And it will all occur at the direction of the "Redeemer of Israel, our only delight." Hence, "as children of Zion, good tidings for us, . . . the hour of redemption is near" (*Hymns*, 1985, no. 6).

In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Benson

We have just heard from Elder Neal A. Maxwell of the Council of Twelve Apostles.

The choir and congregation will now join in singing "Redeemer of Israel," following which we shall hear from Elder Joseph B. Wirthlin, who was sustained yesterday as a new member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles.

The choir and congregation sang "Redeemer of Israel."

Elder Joseph B. Wirthlin spoke without further announcement.

Elder Joseph B. Wirthlin

Pledge of commitment

My beloved brethren and sisters, in all humility and gratitude I ask for

your prayers and your faith in this great and humbling and sacred assignment that has been given me. To our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ, and to Presi-

dent Ezra Taft Benson, our prophet, seer, and revelator, I pledge that I will do my best, that I will do all I can to build up the kingdom of God here upon the earth.

As I left President Benson's office Friday, I was in deep shock — and I still am. I suppose that will linger for many years, but I will put forth my best effort in whatever assignment is given me.

Tributes to family and associates

I pay tribute to my beloved earthly father, who taught me humility, diligence, honesty, trustworthiness, a love of the Constitution of our beloved country, and reverence and honor for God's chosen servants, especially our prophet.

To my mother, who saw a glimpse of eternity several nights prior to her passing, I pay tribute also — first for life itself, and then for the great lessons she taught me. She would never permit a shoddy performance, and she made sure that we children didn't take too long accomplishing our tasks.

I also pay tribute to my beloved wife, Elisa. She is similar, I'm sure, to Rebecca of old. If she had been one of our pioneers, perhaps even coming from New York with a handcart, she probably would have been one of the first to arrive. She has never put as much as a feather in the way of my Church service, and she has reared our children in truth and righteousness.

To our eight children, seven wonderful daughters and one noble son — and he got along very well with his sisters — I pay tribute to them. Each has had his or her marriage sealed in the temple.

To my associates through the years, I pay tribute. They have all lifted me up and made me a better servant. Their names are too numerous to mention, but I honor them and pray that the Lord will always bless them.

I've loved every assignment I've ever had in the kingdom. And in that service, every day seemed like Sunday,

because it was in the service of the Lord.

Progress of the Church in Europe

I would like to report briefly on our experience in Europe. I thank the First Presidency that Sister Wirthlin and I have had the opportunity to preside in the Europe Area of the Church. These past two years have been thrilling and have been filled with tremendous experiences that we will never forget. The following expression from a devoted Church member living in Eastern Europe vividly demonstrates what I mean:

"If you could only see the faith and enthusiasm of our members here. Believe me, our religion is the only thing left for us, and we dearly love it."

Whether we live in Eastern Europe or not, this truth, like a towering mountain, stands out. Our religion is really the only thing we will have left ultimately, and we must love it dearly.

This eternal truth was demonstrated many times during our two-year sojourn in the Europe Area. This area stretches from the far north of Finland, Sweden, and Norway to the southernmost tip of Africa and includes about 230,000 members of the Church. I would like to share a few of the experiences that have kept our faith burning brightly.

Conversion of Asencão Frango

In Portugal, in the city of Funchal, on the Madeira Island, lived a lady named Asencão Frango who had been a nun for twenty years. As a matter of fact, she was a Mother Superior at a home for poor children and orphans. Toward the end of a four-year teaching assignment early in her life as a nun, doctors discovered a cancer in her throat. Her mother had died of this same disease. Although she knew that her deteriorating health might lead to certain death, she had a strong feeling that she had not finished her work on earth. She prayed with great faith for the restoration of her health and was

healed, with no further problems or need for medical care.

When her church decided to close the children's home where she was assigned, she maintained it herself for four years, using an inheritance she had received from her deceased parents, until the children living there were raised and on their own or were adopted.

Hearing of a new religion, she attended her first meeting of our church with a friend, out of curiosity. It was held on the dirt floor of a member's garage, but the spirit of the meeting impressed her. The elders began teaching her the discussions and challenged her to be baptized. She declined, saying that she already had been baptized. The elders persisted by inviting her to read the Book of Mormon. The elders told her, "If this book is the true word of God, then Joseph Smith is a true prophet and The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints is true. If so, you need to be baptized into God's true church."

She read the Book of Mormon and gained a strong testimony of its divinity. Later, she stopped the missionaries after a discussion of the Godhead and requested baptism. Just one year afterward, she stood on the doorstep of President Reuben P. Ficklin's mission home in Lisbon. She obtained her temple recommend and could hardly wait to enter the Swiss Temple to pledge sacred covenants with her Heavenly Father.

Stockholm Temple inspires Lutheran bishop

In Sweden, Bishop Krister Stendahl of the Lutheran church visited the Stockholm Temple a few days prior to its dedication. He had this inspiring description of his experience, as published in a prominent Swedish newspaper:

"Imagine that a new, gleaming white temple with slender pinnacles and towers has been erected to the glory of God. Not a church, not a chapel, but

a temple for sacred ordinances, performed quietly and in solemn dignity.

"A temple where the innermost room is named 'the celestial.' A temple where the faithful perform vicarious work according to Paul's statement on baptism for the dead (1 Corinthians 15:29).

"All in consequence of the wisdom and calling of Joseph Smith. . . .

"What shall we think and say about this? To pretend that it does not concern us that the Mormons — The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints — have built a temple in our midst would be conceited or condescending.

"Therefore I will rejoice with them over this temple that they have erected with much sacrifice to the glory of God. To experience their joy and pride over the beauty of the temple warms one's heart in a special way" (*Svenska Kyrkans Tidning*, 11 July 1985, p. 1).

Freiberg DDR Temple is fulfillment of a prophetic prayer

President Thomas S. Monson has given me permission to share with you his impressions when he rededicated the German Democratic Republic for the advancement of the work of the Church:

"At 7:30 A.M. [April 27, 1975, we traveled to] the location which had been selected for the special prayer which I felt prompted to offer in this land. . . . We walked through the woods . . . into a clearing overlooking the Elbe River, with Meissen on the right and Dresden on the left, Meissen being the birthplace of Karl G. Maeser, the founder of Brigham Young University. . . . During the prayer, I said, 'Today marks the dawning of a new beginning for this beautiful land.' As I used these words, we heard the unmistakable sound of a rooster crowing, followed by the pealing of a cathedral bell in the distance. The day had been overcast, but during the prayer the sun shone brilliantly upon us, warming our bodies and giv-

ing us the assurance that our Heavenly Father was pleased with the prayer which was being offered. . . . As we returned to our automobiles, the sun disappeared from the sky and the overcast condition which previously existed once again prevailed" (personal journal of Thomas S. Monson).

In his prayer of rededication, President Monson said, "Heavenly Father, wilt Thou open up the way that the faithful may be accorded the privilege of going to Thy holy temple, there to receive their holy endowments and to be sealed as families for time and all eternity" (journal of Thomas S. Monson).

This prayer was offered on Sunday, April 27, 1975, at a time when any thought of a temple was beyond the realm of possibility. It was fulfilled on June 29, 1985, with the dedication of the beautiful temple in Freiberg, GDR.

Temple-building in Europe Area is a modern miracle

As you know, temples are now or soon will be within the reach of many members in the Europe Area, from the Stockholm Sweden Temple in the north to the Johannesburg South Africa Temple to the south, with the London and Swiss temples in between. Many lands in the Europe Area are becoming the lands of temples. The Frankfurt Temple, located in a suburb named Friedricksdorf, which was an early settlement of the Huguenots, is nearing completion. The building of these temples in the Europe Area is a modern-day miracle. Temple work is proceeding at an accelerating pace.

Church growing rapidly in Ghana

We traveled to Ghana in West Africa. There the Church is growing rapidly and is on very solid footing. We traveled along the beautiful coast to a chapel that recently had been completed. After holding a meeting there, we traveled through the village of Cape Coast with President and Sister Ernest J. Miller.

As the sun was setting, we saw a large crowd of villagers. Young, old, and middle-aged all were pulling on a huge net and drawing it out of the water. We stopped and inquired about what they were doing. They were pulling in the fish caught that day. In the net were large and small fish of many kinds. Each villager put his hands to the net to help bring in the catch. The thought ran through my mind of the gathering of Israel in the last days as referred to in Jeremiah. The Lord said, "I will send for many fishers, . . . and they shall fish them" (Jeremiah 16:16).

Pull in the gospel net

That, brethren and sisters, is the mission of all of us as members of the Church: to put our hands on the net and pull in thousands of fine men and women who are searching for the truth. With this kind of effort, the Europe Area has pulled in these nets of converts, with a thirty-three percent increase in the number of convert baptisms in two years.

Understand and live the gospel

As I reflected upon our experiences in Europe, these thoughts impressed me. The gospel of Jesus Christ is more enduring than fame, more precious than riches, more to be desired than happiness. Understanding and living the gospel leads to the possession of a Christlike character. The aim of each of us is to live a great and exemplary life. A noble character is needed especially in this age when evil is rampant. I should like to caution our youth to live the gospel, develop strong character, and not indulge in those things that deviate from righteousness.

Our Heavenly Father has endowed us with hearts of courage and faith, with strong wills, and with the ability to understand and to see clearly the difference between right and wrong. He has mercifully clothed us, each member, with the gift of the Holy Ghost, which gives us insight and personal power.

And so, even though the tasks of life become heavy, and although sorrow thrusts a drooping burden upon us, the light that emanates from our Savior beckons us on, undismayed. A righteous self-discipline can and will rule our lives.

In closing, brothers and sisters, I want to say that this is the way we tried to represent the Church in Europe. I testify that God lives, that Jesus is the Christ, that President Ezra Taft Benson is our prophet, seer, and revelator, and that he bears the keys of the kingdom. I love this church with all my heart and

will do my best to serve, in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Benson

I was so overcome by Brother Wirthlin's testimony that I forgot that I was conducting.

Elder Joseph B. Wirthlin, a new member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, has just spoken to us.

Elder L. Tom Perry of the Council of the Twelve Apostles will now address us.

Elder L. Tom Perry

Elder Wirthlin, I too add my welcome to a most unique body of men. You'll find men with dark hair and grey hair, some even with wider parts than others. And their personalities are just as varied as their hairstyles. That's the great blessing of belonging to the Council of the Twelve. For out of these divergent personalities comes a sweet unity under the inspiration of the Lord. It's most unique. Welcome, welcome, Brother Joseph.

Teach children the joy of honest labor

In Proverbs we read, "Train up a child in the way he should go; and when he is old, he will not depart from it" (22:6).

One of the great challenges of life for parents from the very beginning has been succeeding in the very important task of rearing children. This great responsibility seems destined to bring the greatest joys and some of the greatest sorrows life has in store for us here in mortality.

Every child, of course, is different, and what works for one may not elicit the correct response from another. However, I believe that second only to ensuring that every child receives an understanding of the gospel

of our Lord and Savior is teaching them the joy of honest labor.

I was taught this by goodly parents. How grateful I am for a father who had the patience to teach me how to work. I remember as a lad, when I was only seven years old, we were remodeling our house and tearing out some of the walls. In those days two-by-sixes were used as studding. To the studs was nailed the lath, and over the lath came the plaster. When tearing out walls, the slats and the plaster were easy to knock off, but, of course, that left the nails in the two-by-sixes.

Lessons learned while stacking wood and straightening nails

Each night after the workers had finished, I had the responsibility of gathering up the two-by-sixes and taking them out to the back lawn, where there stood two sawhorses. There I was to make a pile of the two-by-sixes and then, one at a time, put them on the sawhorses, and with a crowbar remove the nails. After the nails had been pulled out of the studs, I was told to straighten them. Finally, I threw the straightened nails into a large green bucket and stacked the two-by-sixes in a neat pile.

Be productive in all labors

There was so much in this project that was of value to me in my young life. First, I was taught to be productive, to work, to be busily engaged, and not to waste my time in idleness.

From the very beginning, the Lord commanded Adam to till the earth and have dominion over the beasts of the field, to eat his bread by the sweat of his brow. I have always been interested in how often the scriptures have admonished us to cease to be idle and to be productive in all of our labors. King Benjamin in his final address noted his example before the people by saying:

"I say unto you that as I have been suffered to spend my days in your service, even up to this time, and have not sought gold nor silver nor any manner of riches of you; . . .

"And even I, myself, have labored with mine own hands that I might serve you, and that ye should not be laden with taxes, and that there should nothing come upon you which was grievous to be borne — and of all these things which I have spoken, ye yourselves are witnesses this day" (Mosiah 2:12, 14).

Teaching children the joy of honest labor is one of the greatest of all gifts you can bestow upon them. I am convinced that one of the reasons for the breakup of so many couples today is the failure of parents to teach and train sons in their responsibility to provide and care for their families and to enjoy the challenge this responsibility brings. Many of us also have fallen short in instilling within our daughters the desire of bringing beauty and order into their homes through homemaking.

Oh, how essential it is that children be taught early in life the joy that comes from starting and fashioning a job that is the workmanship of their own hands. Teach children the joy of honest labor. Provide a foundation for life that builds confidence and fulfillment in each life. "Happy is the man who has work he loves to

do. . . . Happy is the man who loves the work he has to do" (Anonymous).

Conserve resources

Second, as a lad doing the job my father had assigned to me, I was taught not to waste, to conserve resources where possible. When the nails were pulled from them, the two-by-sixes could be used again — and we did use them.

I have always enjoyed reading some of the counsel Brigham Young used to give to the Saints. His counsel was so practical. Listen to what he said about waste:

"Pick up everything. . . .

"Never consider that you have bread enough around you to suffer your children to waste a crust or a crumb of it. . . . Remember it, do not waste anything, but take care of everything. . . .

"If you wish to get rich, save what you get. A fool can earn money; but it takes a wise man to save and dispose of it to his own advantage" (*Discourses of Brigham Young*, sel. John A. Widtsoe [Salt Lake City: Deseret Book Co., 1941], p. 292).

I wonder what kind of signals we are sending to our children when we purchase homes that are status symbols. We waste space and resources when we buy a larger home than is needed, a larger home than is practical for us to afford. We encumber ourselves with mortgages so large that they require the income of both husband and wife to make payments. Then we build consumer debt to the point of absorbing completely all of our disposable income, leaving no margin of safety for the rainy days that come into everyone's life. Do not such signals from heads of households only feed the philosophy of "I want it now" in the lives of our children?

Some even have the mistaken belief that after turning their ears away from the counsel of the prophets to avoid unnecessary debt, they can then turn to their bishops to bail them out of

their foolishness. About all the poor bishops can do is weep with them and help them move to more affordable housing, and then counsel them on how they can cut their losses.

As I remember events in my life, I do not believe there was any degree of difference in the happiness that I enjoyed when my two brothers and I shared a single bedroom than when we had a home large enough that each of us enjoyed a bedroom. Let us teach our children the art of conservation and the elimination of waste.

Work builds discipline and character

Third, I will never forget my consternation as I watched the workmen using new nails as they built the walls back up and completed remodeling our home. The pile of nails that I had straightened and put in the green bucket grew and grew and was never used. I went to my father and said, "Wouldn't it be better to save the new nails and use the ones I have straightened?" I was proud of the work I had accomplished.

My father showed me something very important. He took a new nail and, using an odd angle, drove it into a board. He was able to drive it straight and true. Then he took one of the nails I had straightened so carefully, and, using the same odd angle, hit it again and again. It soon bent and was impossible to drive into the board. So I learned that a used or bent nail is never as strong as a new one. But then why had my father asked me to straighten those nails?

As a boy, I never remembered receiving a satisfactory answer. It was not until I had a son of my own that I started to understand. When my son was about three years old, I took him out to the garden to help me weed. I assumed that he, being low to the ground at the time, would have a real advantage at weeding. Unfortunately for my garden, he had a difficult time distinguishing between the weeds and the young plants.

I then tried Lee at milking a cow we owned together with a neighbor. He quickly developed the hand action of a fine milker, but, sadly, his aim was not very good. Whenever I checked on him, he was always surrounded by a white puddle, and the milk bucket was nearly empty. He would look up at me and smile proudly, and my initial inclination to be angry would quickly dissipate — but I was frustrated. I expected him to help me, but he only seemed to create more work.

It was in such moments of frustration that I remembered straightening the nails for my father, and I began to understand. Work is something more than the final end result. It is a *discipline*. We must learn to do, and do well, before we can expect to receive tangible rewards for our labors. My father must have known that if he focused on the outcome of my labors, he would only become frustrated with how inadequately I did things then. So he found tasks that were difficult and would challenge me, to teach me the discipline of hard work. He was using the straightened nails not to rebuild our home but to build my character.

Finish each task and take pride in accomplishments

Finally, I was instructed to stack the used two-by-sixes in a neat pile so the workmen could use them the next day. My work was never finished until this was done and the tools were put away.

Let us also teach our children to see that the work assigned is carried to its completion, to take pride in what they accomplish. There is a real satisfaction that comes from finishing a task, especially when it is the best work we know how to do.

Value of childhood lessons learned about work

These lessons instilled in me a joy and appreciation for honest labor and prepared me for that time in my life

when I would have the responsibility of providing for a family. The principles I was taught by my wise father of honest labor, of not wasting, of discipline, and of seeing a task to its completion were basic to my success in any profession I might choose to follow. These lessons placed me in a position to face with confidence the challenges of an ever-changing world.

Is this not the same lesson that Paul was preaching when he declared: "Neither did we eat any man's bread for nought; but wrought with labour and travail night and day, that we might not be chargeable to any of you:

"Not because we have not power, but to make ourselves an ensample unto you to follow us" (2 Thessalonians 3:8-9).

A Primary teacher's influence

An event occurred in my life about a month ago which impressed upon me the blessings that accrue to one over the years from good, early childhood training. I was delivered a note as I arrived at the airport that one of my very best friends had passed away and her funeral was in just an hour and a half in a community fifty miles from the airport. I made a quick change from air to surface transportation and started the drive to the funeral.

This great soul who had just passed away had been my Primary teacher for three years during my days as a Trail Builder when I was eight, nine, and ten years old. As I drove to Sister Call's funeral that morning, my mind was flooded with pleasant memories of my early childhood.

I especially remembered the powerful example of early childhood training — goodly parents who were always there to teach, inspire, love, and

give strong encouragement to help me chart the right course in my life. I remembered a kind aunt who lived next door, who fortified and provided a second witness to the teachings of my parents.

Then I remembered dear Sister Call, a Primary teacher who extended herself much beyond her classroom call. Her lessons included many field trips to teach us of life, labor, and the joy of association. Her special way of weaving her lessons into our lives gave us an understanding of our personal worth.

As I drove along the highway, my heart was filled with overwhelming gratitude for parents, extended family, and Church leaders who had the patience, love, and concern to build a foundation in the life of a child during those very critical years.

Should not *all* children receive such a blessing early in their lives? This is the Lord's work in which we are engaged. He has charted the course and revealed the fundamental principles that will lead us back to His presence. May we have the strength and the courage to follow Him is my prayer in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

The choir sang "How Wondrous and Great" without announcement.

President Benson

Elder L. Tom Perry of the Council of the Twelve Apostles has just addressed us, followed by the Tabernacle Choir singing "How Wondrous and Great."

President Thomas S. Monson, Second Counselor in the First Presidency, will now address us. He will be our concluding speaker.

President Thomas S. Monson

Have you ever cleaned an attic or rummaged through an old storeroom? One discovers a bit of history and a whole lot of sentiment. A few weeks ago we emptied the attic of our mountain cabin. Seventy years of treasures, each with its own special memory, passed in review. Leading the parade was an old high chair with metal wheels. This was followed by glass milk bottles that once had pasteboard caps and by a copy of *Life* magazine with a story from World War II.

A story from the past

Featured in the magazine was an account of a once proud airplane, a mighty bomber, found rather well preserved in an isolated corner of the vast Sahara Desert. The bomber and crew had participated in the famous raid over Rumania's Ploiesti oil fields. The craft had been struck by antiaircraft fire, which completely destroyed its communication and navigational equipment. As the stricken plane turned toward its desert landing field, a sudden sandstorm obliterated familiar points of reference. The field's landing lights were shrouded by sand. The plane droned on, even far beyond the landing field, into the desert wastes until, with fuel exhausted, it settled on the Sahara, never to fly again. All crew members perished. Home and the safety and shelter there to be found had been denied. Victory, hopes, dreams — all had been swallowed by the silence of the desert's dust.

The Liahona provided Lehi heavenly guidance

Centuries earlier, a righteous and loving father by the name of Lehi took his beloved family into this same desert wasteland. He journeyed in response to the voice of the Lord. But the Lord did not decree that such a "flight" be undertaken without heavenly help. The

words of Nephi describe the gift provided on the morning of the historic trek:

"And it came to pass that as my father arose in the morning, and went forth to the tent door, to his great astonishment he beheld upon the ground a round ball of curious workmanship; and it was of fine brass. And within the ball were two spindles; and the one pointed the way whither we should go into the wilderness" (1 Nephi 16:10).

War and man-made means of destruction could not confuse or destroy this curious compass. Neither could the sudden desert sandstorms render useless its guiding powers. The prophet Alma explained that this "Liahona," as it was called, was a compass prepared by the Lord. It worked for them according to their faith and pointed the way they should go (see Alma 37:38–40).

Patriarchal blessings provide heavenly guidance

The same Lord who provided a Liahona to Lehi provides for you and for me today a rare and valuable gift to give direction to our lives, to mark the hazards to our safety, and to chart the way, even safe passage — not to a promised land, but to our heavenly home. The gift to which I refer is known as your patriarchal blessing. Every worthy member of the Church is entitled to receive such a precious and priceless personal treasure.

"Patriarchal blessings," wrote the First Presidency in a letter to stake presidents, "contemplate an inspired declaration of the lineage of the recipient and, when so moved upon by the Spirit, an inspired and prophetic statement of the life mission of the recipient, together with such blessings, cautions and admonitions as the patriarch may be prompted to give for the accomplishment of such life's mission, it being always made clear that the realization of all promised blessings is conditioned upon faithfulness to the gospel of our

Lord, whose servant the patriarch is" (First Presidency letter to stake presidents, 28 June 1958).

The calling of a patriarch

Who is this man, this patriarch, through whom such seership and priesthood power flow? How is he called? The Council of the Twelve Apostles has special responsibility pertaining to the calling of such men. From my own experience I testify that patriarchs are called of God by prophecy. How else could our Heavenly Father reveal those to whom such prophetic powers are to be given? A patriarch holds an ordained office in the Melchizedek Priesthood. The patriarchal office, however, is one of blessing — not of administration. I have never called a man to this sacred office but what I have felt the Lord's guiding influence in the decision. May I share with you one treasured experience?

Many years back I had been assigned to name a patriarch for a stake in Logan, Utah. I found such a man, wrote his name on a slip of paper, and placed the note inside my scriptures. My further review revealed that another worthy patriarch had moved to this same area, making unnecessary the naming of a new patriarch. None was named.

Nine years later I was again assigned a stake conference in Logan. Once more a patriarch was needed for the stake I was to visit. I had been using a new set of scriptures for several years and had them in my briefcase. However, as I prepared to leave my home for the drive to Logan, I took from the bookcase shelf an older set of scriptures, leaving the new ones at home. During the conference I began my search for a patriarch: a worthy man, a blameless servant of God, one filled with faith, characterized by kindness. Pondering these requirements, I opened my scriptures and there discovered the slip of paper placed there long years before. I read the name written on the paper: Cecil B. Kenner. I asked the

stake presidency if by chance Brother Kenner lived in this particular stake. I found he did. Cecil B. Kenner was that day ordained a patriarch.

Profile of a patriarch

Patriarchs are humble men. They are students of the scriptures. They stand before God as the means whereby the blessings of heaven can flow from that eternal source to the recipient on whose head rests the hands of the patriarch. He may not be a man of letters, a possessor of worldly wealth, or a holder of distinguished office. He, however, must be blessed with priesthood power and personal purity. To reach to heaven for divine guidance and inspiration, a patriarch is to be a man of love, a man of compassion, a man of judgment, a man of God.

"Your patriarchal blessing is to you a personal Liahona"

A patriarchal blessing is a revelation to the recipient, even a white line down the middle of the road, to protect, inspire, and motivate activity and righteousness. A patriarchal blessing literally contains chapters from your book of eternal possibilities. I say eternal, for just as life is eternal, so is a patriarchal blessing. What may not come to fulfillment in this life may occur in the next. We do not govern God's timetable. "For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways, saith the Lord.

"For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways, and my thoughts than your thoughts" (Isaiah 55:8-9).

Your patriarchal blessing is yours and yours alone. It may be brief or lengthy, simple or profound. Length and language do not a patriarchal blessing make. It is the Spirit that conveys the true meaning. Your blessing is not to be folded neatly and tucked away. It is not to be framed or published. Rather, it is to be read. It is to be loved. It is to be followed. Your patriarchal

blessing will see you through the darkest night. It will guide you through life's dangers. Unlike the struggling bomber of yesteryear, lost in the desert wastes, the sands and storms of life will not destroy you on your eternal flight. Your patriarchal blessing is to you a personal Liahona to chart your course and guide your way.

Choose the right path

In Lewis Carroll's classic, *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*, Alice finds herself coming to a crossroads with two paths before her, each stretching onward but in opposite directions. She is confronted by the Cheshire Cat, of whom Alice asks, "Which path shall I take?"

The cat answers, "That depends where you want to go. If you do not know where you want to go, it doesn't really matter which path you take" (see *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* [London: J.M. Dent, 1954], p. 54).

Unlike Alice, each of us knows where he or she wants to go. It does matter which way we go, for the path we follow in this life surely leads to the path we shall follow in the next.

A patriarch's prophetic promise fulfilled

Patience may be required as we watch, wait, and work for a promised blessing to be fulfilled.

One afternoon Percy K. Fetzer, a righteous patriarch, came to my office by appointment. He was weeping as we visited together. He explained that he had just returned from the land of Poland, where he had been privileged to give patriarchal blessings to our worthy members there. After a long pause, the patriarch revealed that he had been impressed to promise to members of a German-speaking family by the name of Konietz declarations which could not be fulfilled. He had promised missions. He had promised temple blessings. These were beyond the reach of those whom he had blessed. He whispered that he had tried to withhold the

promises he knew were unattainable. It had been no use. The inspiration had come, the promises spoken, the blessings provided.

"What shall I do? What can I say?" he repeated to me.

I replied, "Brother Fetzer, these blessings have not come from you; they have been given of God. Let us kneel and pray to Him for their fulfillment."

Within several years of that prayer, an unanticipated pact was signed between the Federal Republic of Germany and the Polish nation which provided that German nationals trapped in Poland at war's end could now enter Germany. The Konietz family, whose members had received these special patriarchal blessings, came to live in West Germany. I had the privilege to ordain the father a bishop in the Dortmund stake of the Church. The family then made that long-awaited trek to the temple in Switzerland. They dressed in clothing of spotless white. They knelt at a sacred altar to await that ordinance which binds father, mother, brothers, and sisters not only for time, but for all eternity. He who pronounced that sacred sealing ceremony was the temple president. More than this, however, he was the same servant of the Lord, Percy K. Fetzer, who, as a patriarch years before, had provided those precious promises in the patriarchal blessings he had bestowed.

How far is Heaven?

It's not very far.

When you live close to God,

It's right where you are.

Your patriarchal blessing is your passport to peace in this life. It is a Liahona of light to guide you unerringly to your heavenly home. Of these sacred truths I testify, in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Benson

President Thomas S. Monson, Second Counselor in the First Presidency, has been our concluding speaker.

The Tabernacle Choir will sing in closing, "Lord, I Would Follow Thee." The benediction will be offered by Elder H. Burke Peterson of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

This conference will then be adjourned until two o'clock this afternoon.

The choir sang "Lord, I Would Follow Thee."

Elder H. Burke Peterson offered the benediction.

SECOND DAY AFTERNOON MEETING

FIFTH SESSION

The fifth session of the 156th Semiannual General Conference commenced at 2:00 P.M. on Sunday, October 5, 1986.

President Ezra Taft Benson presided, and President Gordon B. Hinckley, First Counselor in the First Presidency, conducted this session.

Music was provided by the Tabernacle Choir, directed by Donald Ripplinger with John Longhurst at the organ.

President Hinckley made the following remarks at the outset of the meeting.

President Gordon B. Hinckley

President Ezra Taft Benson, who presides at this conference, has asked that I conduct this session.

We extend a sincere welcome to all assembled this afternoon in the Tabernacle on Temple Square in Salt Lake City in the fifth and concluding session of the 156th Semiannual General Conference of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.

We also welcome those seated in the Assembly Hall, where Elder

Vaughn J. Featherstone and Bishop Robert D. Hales are seated on the stand.

We send our greetings and blessings to members of the Church and many friends everywhere who are participating in these proceedings by radio, television, cable, or by means of satellite transmission.

The Tabernacle Choir, with Donald Ripplinger directing and John Longhurst at the organ, is providing the music for this session. The choir will begin this service by singing "Let Zion in Her Beauty Rise." The invocation will be offered by Elder F. Arthur Kay of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

The choir sang "Let Zion in Her Beauty Rise."

Elder F. Arthur Kay offered the invocation.

President Hinckley

Elder Russell M. Nelson of the Council of the Twelve Apostles will be our first speaker, following which the choir will sing "Joy in the Morning."

Elder Russell M. Nelson

"Joy cometh in the morning"

The title of my message is taken from the thirtieth Psalm, verse 5: "Joy

cometh in the morning." As I discussed this scripture with members of our family, they recalled that "men are, that they might have joy" (2 Nephi 2:25),

but they had not pondered the intriguing concept that "joy cometh in the morning."

One of our family said: "News reports appear almost daily concerning people who have problems with drugs, drinking, and emotional distress. How can they, and we, attain the joy spoken of in the scriptures?"

"The gospel of Jesus Christ offers hope," I answered. "It declares joy to be part of our divine destiny. And to experience joy in the morning becomes our special challenge. The true test," I continued, "is to be able to look in the mirror, first thing in the morning, and feel real joy."

One of our daughters, who had recently announced that she was expecting a new addition to the family, said, "But Dad, that's the hardest time of the day for me!"

Factors needed to feel joy in the morning

"My dear ones," I replied, "in order to experience true joy in the morning, or at any time, at least three factors are needed. You need to feel good about the people with whom you live and work — your companions in life. You must feel good about yourself — not in any sense of conceit, but simply a proper esteem for yourself, well deserved. And possibly most important, you must feel good about your relation to God and sincerely love him."

As I so counseled my family in that conversation, we all might consider those three steps to achieve real joy in life.

Joy comes to those who are courteous

Joy in the morning begins with courtesy to companions. When shades of slumber first admit the light of dawn, I reach gently for my beloved companion nearby. I gain sweet reassurance that all is well with her even before my eyes are fully opened. That reminds me, incidentally, of advice given by

President David O. McKay, who said, "During courtship we should keep our eyes wide open, but after marriage keep them half-shut" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1956, p. 9).

My sweetheart has done that. Through our many long years of post-graduate study, professional responsibilities, and a growing family, she did not complain. Recently I overheard a conversation she had with young mothers enduring similar stress. They asked her how she had managed with ten children and a husband whose time to help was so limited. Kindness was reflected in her reply: "Through our struggling years I didn't expect much, so I was rarely disappointed."

She is special. With her, it is easy to obey the scriptural injunction to "live joyfully with the wife whom thou lovest all the days of [thy] life" (Ecclesiastes 9:9).

Not all of us are blessed with such wonderful eternal companions — not yet anyway. Many of us who are married cannot be together as much as we would like. Thankfully, we all have companionship of family and friends.

Privilege of rendering significant service

Recently another General Authority was my partner for mission tours to dusty places. On occasion, when I returned from a morning shower, I found to my surprise that this considerate companion had shined my shoes. Gratefully I wondered if each of the thirty thousand missionaries now laboring in the Lord's service would have, and be, as kind a friend as he was to me, thoughtfully rendering simple acts of courtesy to a companion.

Joy cometh in the morning to those who have earned the night's rest of a laborer. One of life's sweetest returns is the privilege of rendering significant service of worth to others. To be able to do for fellow human beings something they could not do for themselves brings matchless satisfaction. Years of preparation are worth it.

And joy is derived in Church service. Alma so expressed this thought: "That perhaps I may be an instrument in the hands of God to bring some soul to repentance . . . is my joy" (Alma 29:9).

Through service in the temples, the concept of courtesy to companions can be nobly extended to those who have passed beyond the veil. The gospel brings glad tidings for the dead and a voice of gladness for the living and the dead — for all, glad tidings of great joy (see D&C 128:19).

Even when death's veil separates us from parents who gave so much that we might be, their righteous influence continues with us. And as they may watch from windows of heaven, their mornings will be brighter if they can truly say, as did the Apostle, "I have no greater joy than to hear that my children walk in truth" (3 John 1:4).

Be chaste

Above all, courtesy to companions cannot be defiled by disobedience to the law of chastity. That sin is joy's deadly poison. The first morning's glance in the mirror cannot reflect joy if there is any recollection of misdeeds the night before. The surest step toward joy in the morning is virtue in the evening! Virtue includes courtesy to companions all day long.

Joy comes to those who have proper self-esteem

The next prerequisite to joy is to feel good about yourself. The second of our Lord's two great commandments carries a double charge: "Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself" (Matthew 22:39). Therefore, love of companion is governed, in part, by esteem of self, and so is joy in the morning.

Each individual should understand the nature of his or her own soul. Profound insight is provided by this revelation:

"For man is spirit. The elements are eternal, and spirit and element,

inseparably connected, receive a fullness of joy;

"And when separated, man cannot receive a fullness of joy" (D&C 93:33-34).

Therefore, spiritual and physical elements each must be nurtured if we are to earn proper self-esteem.

Gratitude, prayer, and scripture study bring spiritual self-esteem

Spiritual self-esteem begins with the realization that each new morning is a gift from God. Even the air we breathe is a loving loan from him. He preserves us from day to day and supports us from one moment to another (see Mosiah 2:21).

Therefore, our first noble deed of the morning should be a humble prayer of gratitude. Scripture so counsels: "Pray unto God, and he will be favourable unto [you]; and [you] shall see his face with joy" (Job 33:26; see also Alma 34:21, 37:37).

I did not fully appreciate the significance of prayerful greetings until I became a father myself. I am so grateful that our children never gave their mother or dad the silent treatment. Now I sense how our Heavenly Father may appreciate our prayers, morning and night. But I can imagine the pangs of his sorrow because of silence from any of his children. To me, such ingratitude seems comparable to sullen goldfish oblivious to kind providers who sprinkle food in their bowl. Indeed, those who pray can "worship God with exceedingly great joy" (Alma 45:1).

I learned long ago that a period of uninterrupted scriptural study in the morning brings enduring enrichment. I feel as did Jeremiah: "Thy word was unto me the joy and rejoicing of mine heart" (Jeremiah 15:16). Sacred scriptures have been repeatedly described as "glad tidings of great joy" (Helaman 16:14, Mosiah 3:3, Alma 13:22; see also Luke 2:10). As we learn and abide their teachings, that joy becomes part of our lives.

Develop personal talents

Joy cometh in the morning when personal talents are developed. Each of us is blessed with different potential. I don't think I could get up early enough to become a portrait painter. But I have appreciated teachings since my earliest childhood from parents who knew the joy that good music brings. And some of the sweetest sounds in our home have been those from songs and instruments of children improving their talents.

Even in Old Testament days, "David spake to the chief of the Levites to appoint their brethren to be the singers with instruments of musick, . . . sounding, by lifting up the voice with joy" (1 Chronicles 15:16).

Confidence to begin each morning ready to meet the challenges of the day comes from spiritual self-esteem.

Exercise regularly and obey the Word of Wisdom

Physical self-esteem also requires nurturing. Our bodies deserve thoughtful care. I echo this declaration of Paul:

"Know ye not that ye are the temple of God, and that the Spirit of God dwelleth in you?

"If any man defile the temple of God, him shall God destroy; for the temple of God is holy, which temple ye are" (1 Corinthians 3:16-17).

Physical conditioning from regular exercise is important. And we can do so much more to keep our bodies strong.

In 1833 the Prophet Joseph Smith received the Word of Wisdom by revelation. It includes these simple directives: we are not to drink alcohol, tea, or coffee, and we are not to use tobacco. Prophets in our generation and in this conference have told us also to avoid harmful drugs. Now medical science increasingly confirms the physical benefits of compliance with these teachings.

The damaging effects of alcohol are so widely known, additional com-

ment is hardly needed. Harm inflicted by alcohol has been demonstrated, for example, by a study of the relationship between alcohol consumption among expectant mothers and the birth weight of their newborn infants. Findings published from the U. S. National Institutes of Health disclosed that consumption of one to two alcoholic drinks a day was associated with a substantially increased risk of producing a growth-retarded infant (see James L. Mills, et. al., "Maternal Alcohol Consumption and Birth Weight," *Journal of the American Medical Association*, 12 Oct. 1984, pp. 1875-79).

Scientists now know that smoking of tobacco is the number one preventable cause of death in all the world. It is the leading preventable cause of heart disease, lung disease, artery disease, and cancer (see William W. Pollin and R. T. Ravenholt, "Tobacco Addiction and Tobacco Mortality," *Journal of the American Medical Association*, 23 Nov. 1984, pp. 2849-54; 1986 *Heart Facts*, American Heart Association, 1986, p. 16; "The Health Consequences of Smoking: A Report of the Surgeon General," publication DHHS (PHS) 84-50204, U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, Public Health Services, Office of Smoking and Health, Rockville, Md., 1983).

Still another report indicates that more than one-fourth of all deaths in the United States are now caused by conditions which physicians classify as addictive disorders (see Pollin and Ravenholt, p. 2849).

Obedience to the Word of Wisdom keeps one free from all such addictions. This protection is pronounced by covenant in the last verse of the eighty-ninth section of the Doctrine and Covenants:

"And I, the Lord, give unto them a promise, that the destroying angel shall pass by them, as the children of Israel, and not slay them" (D&C 89:21).

This reference to the first Passover reminds us that, *in faith*, ancient Israel was obedient to the commandment to take blood and "strike it on the two side posts and on the upper door post of the houses" (Exodus 12:7).

"And the blood shall be to you for a token upon the houses where ye are: and when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and the plague shall not . . . destroy you" (Exodus 12:13).

So, *in faith*, modern Israel is commanded to obey the Word of Wisdom. It becomes our token of a covenant with the Lord—a spiritual separator of covenant Israel from the rest of the world.

Joy cometh in the morning—to those who can stand before the mirror and feel clean, to those whose mouths are free from the taste of flavors forbidden by the Lord, to those whose spirits and bodies are free from feelings of self-remorse.

Joy comes to those who love God

The crowning attribute that leads to joy is love of God. Even that first look in the mirror can be more enjoyable knowing we are created in his image. Each of us can say, as did the Apostle, "Thou hast made known to me the ways of life; thou shalt make me full of joy with thy countenance" (Acts 2:28; see also Psalm 16:11).

God, who gave us life, also gave us commandments to live by, that we might have joy. They have been revealed periodically by prophets from Adam to President Benson. One wrote this expression: "Consider . . . the blessed and happy state of those that keep the commandments of God. For behold, they are blessed in all things, both temporal and spiritual" (Mosiah 2:41).

Seek blessings of repentance

But for those who have not known his ways or who have strayed from them, remember, it is not too late to change. Blessings from faith and repentance still can be yours.

To those who feel defeated and downtrodden, look to the early hours of the day for your rescue. The Lord tells us, "Cease to sleep longer than is needful; retire to thy bed early, that ye may not be weary; arise early, that your bod-

ies and your minds may be invigorated" (D&C 88:124).

The dawning of a brighter day heralds a time of forgiveness. Shadows of yesterday's grief melt in the rays of early morn's opportunity.

Posterity brings joy

Joy comes from our posterity, and we rejoice as they are blessed by the ordinances of salvation and exaltation.

Our family experienced that in a special way recently as our youngest daughter was sealed to her eternal companion in the holy temple. To witness this event, along with other family members, were her parents and all eight of her older sisters and their husbands. For us, there was truly joy in the morning on that day. Then we really felt the scriptural truth, "Men are, that they might have joy" (2 Nephi 2:25).

Morning of the first resurrection

These experiences, glorious as they are, become but prelude to that great day ahead, when the faithful will stand at the latter day upon the earth. They shall abide the Second Coming of the Lord and shall stand with him when he appears (see Malachi 3:2–12, 3 Nephi 24:2–12). On that joyous morning, the mirror will reflect the miracle of the first resurrection. The faithful shall be crowned with glory, immortality, and eternal life (see D&C 75:5, 138:51).

Once again "morning stars [will] sing together, and . . . all the sons [and daughters] of God [will] shout for joy!" (D&C 128:23; see also Job 38:7). For on that morning, "the glory of the Lord shall be revealed, and all flesh shall see it together" (Isaiah 40:5; see also Ezekiel 20:48, Luke 3:6, D&C 101:23).

Then, "there'll be peace and contentment evermore, ev'ry heart, ev'ry voice on that day will rejoice. . . . There'll be joy in the morning on that day" (Natalie Sleeth, "Joy in the Morning," Carol Stream, Illinois: Hope Publishing Co., 1977, pp. 4–5, 9–10).

It shall be ours — through our faithfulness — I testify in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

The choir sang "Joy in the Morning."

President Hinckley

I promise that when I look in the mirror in the morning I will smile.

Elder Franklin D. Richards

Temple work brings joy

We have heard how the Holy Ghost directs us. I remember years ago in a temple meeting that President David O. McKay suggested that even though you prepare a talk ten days before conference, the Lord can inspire you then as well as when you are at the podium. I couldn't help but think of that as I listened to Elder Russell M. Nelson speak about joy and as the choir sang about joy, as I am about to speak to you about happiness and joy in temple work. My dear brothers and sisters, I am indeed happy to be with you in this great conference, and I pray that I may be guided by the Spirit of the Lord in speaking to you.

The First Presidency of the Church has outlined the mission of the Church to be to take the gospel to all mankind, to perfect the Saints, and to do temple and genealogy work for ourselves and the dead.

Many times I have spoken about the joy and happiness one receives in doing missionary work. Today I would like to make specific reference to the joy and happiness one receives in doing temple work. A few months ago, Sister Richards and I returned after having the great privilege of supervising the temple work in the Washington, D.C., Temple for a little over two years.

It may be rather late, but I would like to bring you the love and greetings of the workers and patrons of the Wash-

Elder Russell M. Nelson of the Council of the Twelve has just spoken to us, followed by the Tabernacle Choir singing "Joy in the Morning."

We shall now hear from Elder Franklin D. Richards of the First Quorum of the Seventy, and he will be followed by Elder A. Theodore Tuttle of that same quorum.

ington Temple, and I am pleased to report to you that there is a great spirit and substantial growth and development in the kingdom in that part of the Lord's vineyard.

Those two years in Washington were a period of many beautiful spiritual experiences for Sister Richards and myself, and daily we were able to see evidences of love and service to our fellowmen.

Our Father in Heaven is a loving parent. He has said, "For behold, this is my work and my glory — to bring to pass the immortality and eternal life of man" (Moses 1:39). To this end, He restored the gospel in this dispensation.

Why temples?

The Latter-day Saints build temples because they have been instructed to do so, in order that holy ordinances may be performed in them for both the living and the dead. The performance of these ordinances is possible because genealogical work and temple work are inseparably connected. It is important to realize that the blessings of the temple are not limited to any special class, but are available to all worthy Church members properly accredited.

I would like to refer briefly to three areas having to do with temple attendance.

First, for the living: For the living, such ordinances as baptism, the bestowal of the Holy Ghost, and the

ordination to the priesthood may be performed in any proper place outside of a temple. However, through modern revelation we are told that certain ordinances such as the endowment, eternal marriage, sealing ordinances for both the living and the dead, and baptisms for the dead must be performed in a temple.

The temple endowment embodies sacred covenants upon which blessings are predicated. It is also, in effect, a course of instruction whereby many of the answers are given to the question "What is the purpose of life?"

The endowment, of course, is an ordinance for the individual, whereas sealing ordinances pertain to a family relationship.

Second, for the dead: The ministry of Christ was not confined to the few who lived on the earth in the meridian of time, and it is not confined only to those living now. The Apostle Peter made it clear that those who do not have the opportunity to hear the gospel on this earth will have such an opportunity in the spirit world (see 1 Peter 3:18-20, 4:6). And the apostle Paul in writing to the Corinthians asked, "Else what shall they do which are baptized for the dead, if the dead rise not at all? why are they then baptized for the dead?" (1 Corinthians 15:29).

Temple worship provides an opportunity to do ordinance work for our kindred dead and for others, an opportunity for us to serve the dead. This service is the source of eternal satisfaction. However, it is well to remember that vicarious service for the dead by the living does not affect the right of the dead to accept or reject such vicarious service.

Third, as a retreat: A temple is a retreat from the vicissitudes of life, a place of prayer and meditation providing an opportunity to receive inner peace, inspiration, guidance, and, frequently, solutions to the problems that vex our daily lives.

A temple is a place where the divine spark in man, or the infinite in man, can seek the infinite in God.

Spiritual experiences in the temple

I have witnessed the joy and satisfaction that come to those who serve in the temple. I recall on one occasion a sister coming through the temple door, her face bright with anticipation and her step quickened. She was a temple worker who had been back home for a visit. She grasped my hand and said: "It's so good to be back. I love my service in the temple, and know I cannot be happy, really happy, away from it. It brings me a joy and satisfaction that is found in no other place. I feel a sense of accomplishment in doing something of eternal value. It's a little like the work of the Savior, who did for mankind what they could not do for themselves. This work brings peace to my soul—yes, the peace that passeth understanding."

One day, Sister Richards and I walked into the baptistry about noon and noticed a young girl sitting on one of the benches. As we talked with her, she told us she was from West Virginia and it was her twelfth birthday. Her mother had asked her what she wanted for a birthday present, and she had asked that her mother bring her to the temple so that she could perform baptisms for the dead.

What an opportunity temple workers have to touch the hearts of our brothers and sisters of all ages!

I recall a letter from a bishop in an eastern Canadian ward. He stated in this letter:

"We appreciate the privilege of bringing our youth to the temple. Our kids must be worthy. We see kids waiting for their turn with tears running down their faces. We have had many spiritual experiences. One young man who wasn't going on a mission said, 'Now, I'll have to go.' Our temple trips have been successful beyond our hopes. Lives have literally been changed. The kids consider this a great spiritual experience."

As we do temple work, we develop a spiritual kinship with our Heavenly Father and our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ that brings us peace, happiness, and eternal joy.

In the temple there is an influence and spirit that touches the minds, hearts, and souls of those present. Yes, it is truly the House of the Lord.

Temples are one of the great blessings of this dispensation

It has been said that the story of temple work is a story of love — the love of God for man, and of men for God and for each other.

Let us not allow the wealth, the honors of men, or the vain things of the world to keep us from being worthy of this sacred privilege that can be ours. We are indeed blessed to have come to earth at this time, when these beautiful saving ordinances have been restored to the earth, and to have the privilege of participating in them.

I encourage members of the Church to participate in temple work in every way possible, as a most rewarding way to build the kingdom of God. The purposes of the Lord are being ac-

complished, souls are being saved, and prophecy is being fulfilled. Yes, we can be grateful that we live in the dispensation of the fulness of times — when God the Father and His Son have appeared to the Prophet Joseph Smith; when the gospel in its fulness has been restored; when the priesthood, or the power to act in the name of God, has been restored; and when Christ's church again is established upon the earth. And how we sustain our beloved prophet Ezra Taft Benson who, through revelation, leads and directs the affairs of the kingdom of God on the earth in this day.

May we leave this conference strengthened and motivated with a greater desire to lengthen our stride. May the kingdom of God go forth, that the kingdom of heaven may come, and may the choice blessings of our Father in Heaven be with you, I pray in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

Thank you, Elder Franklin D. Richards. We shall now be privileged to hear Elder A. Theodore Tuttle of the First Quorum of the Seventy.

Elder A. Theodore Tuttle

My beloved brothers and sisters, I would be ungrateful if I did not thank the many of you who have prayed for my well-being over the past few months. Medical science is marvelous, but above and beyond that, it takes special blessings from our Heavenly Father for healing to occur. I appreciate your prayers in my behalf.

Have faith to do what the Lord commands

I was told of a conversation by a Primary teacher, who related what transpired in his class. He was teaching the eleven-year-olds. He asked the question: "Suppose the Lord asked you to

build a spaceship big enough to take you and your family and provisions off this planet? Could you do it?"

Steve spoke up and said, "Yes."

And the teacher said, "Have you ever built a spaceship?"

"No."

"Have you ever built a model spaceship?"

"No."

"Have you ever seen one?"

Steve said, "Yes, on TV." But then he declared, "You said the Lord told me to build it. If the Lord told me to build it, I could do it."

I wonder how many of us as adults have that kind of faith. I would like to read in the Book of Mormon a great

example of this kind of faith. I go to the seventeenth chapter of 1 Nephi:

"And it came to pass that the Lord spake unto me [Nephi], saying: Thou shalt construct a ship, after the manner which I shall show thee, that I may carry thy people across these waters" (v. 8).

Listen to the answer of this great Nephi:

"And I said: Lord, whither shall I go that I may find ore to molten, that I may make tools to construct the ship after the manner which thou hast shown unto me?" (v. 9).

And when his brothers realized that he was actually going to set about to build a ship, they said: "Why, you're a fool. You don't know how to construct a ship" (see v. 17).

And then Nephi set about to teach them a great lesson.

Spiritual history helps us develop faith in the Lord

How do you *develop* faith?

Let's learn a great lesson from what transpired with Nephi. He started to recount the things that had happened that they all knew were a part of their heritage. He went back to the coming of the children of Israel out of Egypt. He said: "You know what happened. There they were right against the Red Sea with the Egyptians coming, and the Lord saved them" (see vs. 26-27).

Then he goes on and talks about how they received manna in the wilderness, how they received water from a rock, how the Lord led them by a pillar of cloud in the daytime and a light at night, and how when they crossed the Jordan, it stopped when the feet of the priests touched the water (see vs. 28-30, 32; see also Exodus 13:21, Joshua 3:15-17). And then Nephi tells how the Lord scattered the people; and then how, when they came among the flying serpents, Moses fashioned a brazen serpent, raised it, and all they had to do was look at that serpent, and they would be healed. The account says that many perished because they wouldn't

even look (see vs. 32, 41; see also Numbers 21:8-9).

He was trying to do what you and I as parents need to do with our families today — to develop faith in the Lord. And the way to do it is to recount the examples of faith that have happened in our history and in our heritage and with our people. That's the value of history. It contains accounts of faith of our own blood and ancestry and of our own people and our children. As has already been said in this conference, we cannot go one generation without losing faith if we do not do this. And to rear a generation of faith for what we must do in these days, you and I simply must develop and increase faith in the Lord Jesus Christ.

Faith precedes the miracle

There's another principle: that is, that faith precedes the miracle. This lesson is found in Ether, chapter 12. You'll recall that Moroni was abridging the records of the twenty-four plates, and this is what he records:

"And it came to pass that Ether did prophesy great and marvelous things unto the people, which they did not believe, because they saw them not" (v. 5).

They couldn't see them; they wouldn't believe them. They needed to be taught that *believing* is seeing. And then Moroni interpolates here:

"And now, I, Moroni, would speak somewhat concerning these things; I would show unto the world that faith is things which are hoped for and not seen; wherefore, dispute not because ye see not, for ye receive no witness until *after* the trial of your faith" (v. 6; italics added).

We need to learn that. We can't have just faith. We cannot have the miracle until *after* the exercise of faith. Moroni sets forth on the next page or so instances of those miracles that have occurred after the trial of the faith of the people. We need to learn that principle as well.

Faith to finance a mission

I recall that when I was twenty years old, I went for an interview with the bishop to go on a mission. When I returned, my mother, all smiles, said, "Well, Ted, what did the bishop say?"

"He said I couldn't go."

"Why not?" my mother asked.

And I said, "Because we don't have enough money."

"If my father could leave two children and another to be born shortly after he left, you can go."

I said, "I know that, but the bishop doesn't."

Parenthetically, I might say that he was doing his job right. He asked me if I had any money. I told him I had a few hundred dollars that I had earned that summer.

He said, "Then what?"

I said, "My dad would send it to me."

He said, "Does your dad have it?"

I said, "No," and he didn't. We had lost our sheep herd during the Depression. My father was a livestock dealer buying lambs and wool on commission, and that was a very uncertain income.

The bishop said, "The Brethren have had some serious experiences, and so you cannot go unless you can guarantee that you'll have sufficient money."

I accepted that, and that's what I told my mother.

That night we waited for Dad to come home and then held a family council. We concluded that we didn't then have enough money — and that we wouldn't, so far as we could see, anytime in the future. We decided to ask our neighbor, Tom Anderson, a rather wealthy man, if he would help. When we explained our situation, he said, "You tell the bishop that I will 'back you.'"

Before the bishop opened his business the next morning, I was there waiting to tell him that Tom Anderson said he would back me. The bishop said, "That's all I need to know."

The interesting thing was that we never did have to call on Brother Anderson. My folks would send that check and with it a note, "This is for this month, and we'll have the next month's, too."

Faith is essential to survival

I am a product of a household of faith. I learned faith in my home. I was taught it. It was drilled into me. I need that faith now as much as I ever did.

I think we all do. We're not going to survive in this world, temporally or spiritually, without increased faith in the Lord — and I don't mean a positive mental attitude — I mean downright solid faith in the Lord Jesus Christ. That is the one thing that gives vitality and power to otherwise rather weak individuals.

I bear you my humble witness that I know that God lives. I know that he lives, that he is our Father, that he loves us. I bear witness that Jesus is the Christ, our Savior and our Redeemer.

I understand better what that means now. I am grateful for his atonement in our behalf and for knowing something about our relationship to him and to our Heavenly Father and about the meaning and purpose of the gospel of Jesus Christ. I am grateful for Joseph Smith. I know he was a prophet, and I know that President Ezra Taft Benson is a living prophet today. I bear that witness in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

He to whom we have just listened is Elder A. Theodore Tuttle of the First Quorum of the Seventy. I should perhaps be guilty of an indiscretion, but I think I will risk it and say that Brother Tuttle has been seriously ill and he needs our faith, the faith of which he has spoken. It will be appreciated if those who have listened to him across the Church would plead with our Father in Heaven, in the kind of faith which he has described, in his behalf.

The choir and congregation will now join in singing "We Thank Thee, O God, for a Prophet," following which Bishop Henry B. Eyring, First Counselor in the Presiding Bishopric, will speak to us.

The choir and congregation sang "We Thank Thee, O God, for a Prophet."

Bishop Henry B. Eyring spoke without further announcement.

Bishop Henry B. Eyring

God honors his promises

At the close of the last general conference, President Benson said this: "I bless you with increased *understanding* of the Book of Mormon. I promise you that from this moment forward, if we will daily sup from its pages and abide by its precepts, God will pour out upon each child of Zion and the Church a blessing hitherto unknown" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1986, p. 100; or *Ensign*, May 1986, p. 78).

I bear my testimony that I have been blessed as He promised, and I have seen new blessings come to people I love. I am grateful that God honors the promises he makes through his prophet.

Some people doubt God's promises

Even as I feel that gratitude, I think of those whose hearts ache over promises yet unfulfilled. Tonight, or tomorrow, many of us will pray with real intent, and perhaps with tears, over someone whose happiness would bring us happiness, who has been promised all the blessings of peace that come with baptism and the gift of the Holy Ghost, and yet who counts the promises worthless. None of us is immune, because all of us have circles of love large enough to include such people. My heart is drawn especially to those asking the question we all have asked: "How can I be sure I have done all I can to help?"

The spark of faith never dies

Fifty years ago, in October conference, President J. Reuben Clark, Jr., of the First Presidency, gave this answer, which I carry copied on a card:

"It is my hope and my belief that the Lord never permits the light of faith wholly to be extinguished in any human heart, however faint the light may glow. The Lord has provided that there shall still be there a spark which, with teaching, with the spirit of righteousness, with love, with tenderness, with example, with living the Gospel, shall brighten and glow again, however darkened the mind may have been. And if we shall fail so to reach those among us of our own whose faith has dwindled low, we shall fail in one of the main things which the Lord expects at our hands" (in Conference Report, Oct. 1936, p. 114).

That lovely metaphor — of a spark, a spark of faith — gives me confidence. President Clark pictured the spark nearly hidden, almost smothered by the ashes of transgression. It may be so small that the person can't feel its warmth. The heart may be hardened. Even the Holy Spirit may have been forced to withdraw. But the spark still lives, and glows, and may be fanned to flame.

Teach faith and repentance to fan the spark

President Clark also suggested what we can do. He did not suggest a single approach to reach all people. But he described what every effort that succeeds in fanning the spark will include.

Teaching is first. But what should we teach? Suppose time and opportunity are scarce, as they generally are with people who don't think they need your teaching. If you had the gift, and the chance, to teach only one thing, what would it be?

For me the answer is illustrated in the success of a great man whose heart ached over someone he loved. His name was Alma, and his son, Alma, went about trying to destroy the true church. You remember that in response to the prayers of his father, and of faithful members of the Church, God sent an angel to rebuke the son.

The rebuke brought young Alma such remorse that he would have been destroyed had he not remembered his father's teaching. He described it this way:

"And now, for three days and for three nights was I racked, even with the pains of a damned soul.

"And it came to pass that as I was thus racked with torment, while I was harrowed up by the memory of my many sins, behold, I remembered also to have heard my father prophesy unto the people concerning the coming of one Jesus Christ, a Son of God, to atone for the sins of the world.

"Now, as my mind caught hold upon this thought, I cried within my heart: O Jesus, thou Son of God, have mercy on me, who am in the gall of bitterness, and am encircled about by the everlasting chains of death" (Alma 36:16-18).

Because his father had taught him that the Savior was his only source of hope, Alma began the process which took him to full repentance. If I had the chance to teach one thing, it would be what it means and how it feels to exercise faith in Jesus Christ unto repentance.

To do it I would try to take the person I loved on a journey from when we were with a loving Father in Heaven to when we can go home to him again. We would see the fall of Adam and Eve and feel its effects on us. We would go to Bethlehem and rejoice at the birth of

the Son of God, and to the Garden and to Golgotha as our hearts break at the transcendent gift of the Atonement. And we would go to the open tomb, and to Galilee, and to this hemisphere to feel hope in keeping the commandments of the risen Lord. Then we would go to a grove in New York to watch the boy Joseph Smith talk with God the Father and his resurrected Son, to begin the errand that restored the ordinances of the gospel, which can lead us home again.

Teach with love and tenderness

President Clark understood that a person in whom faith is an ember won't receive even great teaching unless his heart is softened. And so he said that we must touch the person with the spirit of righteousness, with love, and with tenderness. Now, you and I might rightly feel that what he asks is nearly superhuman. In our efforts to invite others back, we have felt rejection and even ridicule. We may feel fatigue, frustration, and sometimes guilt. How then can we keep reaching out in a spirit of righteousness, with love and tenderness?

The best answer I know comes from another wonderful father. His name was Mormon. He wrote a letter to his son Moroni in a time when they met not only rejection but unbridled hatred, and faced not only frustration but almost certain failure. Mormon wanted Moroni to meet even such a test with love and tenderness and the spirit of righteousness. He gave a formula, the same one given by true prophets in all ages. It has always worked. The promise is sure. Here it is, from Mormon's letter:

"And the first fruits of repentance is baptism; and baptism cometh by faith unto the fulfilling the commandments; and the fulfilling the commandments bringeth remission of sins;

"And the remission of sins bringeth meekness, and lowliness of heart; and because of meekness and lowliness of heart cometh the visitation

of the Holy Ghost, which Comforter filleth with hope and perfect love, which love endureth by diligence unto prayer, until the end shall come, when all the saints shall dwell with God" (Moroni 8:25–26).

If you try to imagine the Savior restoring a lost sheep to the fold, won't you picture him cradling it in his arms? That tenderness and love, Mormon testified to his son, is the natural result of the atonement of Jesus Christ operating in our lives. Our faith leads us to repentance, to the gifts of the Spirit, and from that to the perfect love which the Master Shepherd has, and knows we must have to serve him.

Teach by example

The effects of the Atonement in our lives can also produce in us the example those we love will need. I learned again the other night the example we need to be.

I was chatting with my wife at the end of a long day. Three of our children were in the room, listening. I turned and noticed that one of them was watching me — and watching my face intently. And then he asked me, softly, "Why are you unhappy?" I tried to give a reason for my furrowed brow, but I realized later that he could well have been asking this deeper question: "Can I see in you the hope for peace in this life that Jesus promised?"

To turn my thoughts from what darkened my look to what would brighten it, I went to another letter from Mormon to his son. Both Mormon and Moroni were facing days of difficulty that make my challenges pale. Mormon knew his son might be overcome with gloom and foreboding, so he told him the perfect antidote. He told him that he could choose, by what he put in his mind, to become an example of hope. Here is what he wrote:

"My son, be faithful in Christ; and may not the things which I have written grieve thee, to weigh thee down unto

death; but may Christ lift thee up, and may his sufferings and death, and the showing his body unto our fathers, and his mercy and long-suffering, and the hope of his glory and of eternal life, rest in your mind forever" (Moroni 9:25).

Center on the Savior and his atonement

What we can do to help — teaching, and doing it with the spirit of righteousness, with love, with tenderness, with example — centers on the Savior and his atonement. That is what we would teach. The Atonement working in our lives will produce in us the love and tenderness we need. And by remembering him and his gift, which we promise to do as we take the sacrament each week, we can put a light of hope in our faces which those we love need so much to see.

Live the gospel to ignite the spark of faith

President Clark reminded us, at the end of his suggestions, that there is, and always will be, free agency. The spark won't glow brighter until the person tries living the gospel. That is why we hope so much that those we love will be called and will fulfill some assignment, however small. After their choice to serve others, to sacrifice, to try the commandments with promise, the spark of faith ignites. Even after we have done all we can do, that choice — whether to act on what faith they have — must be theirs.

I bear my testimony that God lives, Jesus is the Christ, and in this dispensation, through prophets from Joseph Smith to Ezra Taft Benson, he has given the power to offer again the full blessings of the gospel of Jesus Christ. I pray that we may never cease to offer the opportunity to choose those blessings to those in whom the spark of faith may yet be fanned to flame. In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

Bishop Henry B. Eyring, First Counselor in the Presiding Bishopric, has just spoken to us.

We shall now hear from Elder F. Burton Howard of the First Quorum of the Seventy, who serves as president of the South America North Area of the Church in São Paulo.

Elder F. Burton Howard

"Come back to the Lord"

From the beginning, prophets have called almost all men to repentance. Those who have not known about the gospel have been exhorted to abandon their sinful ways, keep the commandments, and join with the people of the Lord.

But prophets have also pled with another group — those who were once believers, but who, because of pride or sin or something else, abandoned the faith. In this group are the less active, the critics, the uncommitted, and the rebellious. These are Church members who have grown away from God as they have grown older. To these, the invitation has always been to come back to the Lord.

As we think about members of the Church repenting and returning to activity, the stories of Saul or Alma may come to mind. Some may be waiting for a similar miraculous experience before committing themselves again. However, they will probably wait in vain. For, as the Savior taught his disciples, "if they hear not Moses and the prophets, neither will they be persuaded, though one rose from the dead" (Luke 16:31).

The way back is clearly marked

Without some such incentive to change, others may wonder if it is possible to return to faith from doubt. Can the cynic ever really become as a little child? Can the slave of habit or passion become free again? Is there a way back? If so, is it worth the effort to find and follow it? Where and when does one begin?

There is a way — for surely prophets do not teach in vain. And, just as surely, the Lord hears the prayers of teachers and leaders and parents who pray for the return of those who are lost.

Some may think the way is not clearly marked, for in all of scripture there are but a few instances recorded of former believers ever repenting. Be that as it may, the fact remains that thousands have returned from inactivity. Let me tell you about some who did.

A couple that returned

When I was first called to be a bishop, I inherited a large ward. Many of the eight hundred or so members did not come out to church. I had never met them and resolved to do so.

One Sunday afternoon in November, I went to visit an inactive family. As I came up to the house, a woman was sweeping the porch. I introduced myself as the new bishop and asked if her husband was home.

"Yes," she said, "but he won't talk to you. We are tired of being bothered. My husband asked the other bishop to take our names off the records of the Church. We don't want home teachers. We don't want people collecting fast offerings. We just want to be left alone."

She changed her grip on the broom. "Now get out," she said. "Get off my porch, get out of my yard, and don't come back." The broom was coming at me as I backed down the steps. I stammered a few words of apology, which were ignored. "Git," she said, and I did.

I didn't sleep well that night. I had been humiliated. Worse still, it seemed, my office had been treated with disrespect. By Tuesday night, I had almost decided that the woman and her husband should be excommunicated. A wise counselor, and a careful reading of the instructions from Church headquarters, persuaded me otherwise.

I said hello to them on the street occasionally after that, but I never returned to the home. However, we did assign a relative to visit there each month to watch over them. As far as I know, no gospel message was given, and no other significant Church contact was had with that family during the years I served as bishop.

After a time the ward was divided. I was released and was called to be stake president. On another Tuesday night some years later, one of our bishops came to the stake office and asked if I would be available later in the evening to interview an older couple for a temple recommend. He had been working with them for months, and they were finally ready to go to the temple.

He said, "You may know them, President," and he mentioned the name of the woman with the broom.

I could hardly wait for that interview. About nine o'clock the bishop brought a well-dressed, elderly couple to my office and introduced them. I recognized them as the same people I had known before, but they were different somehow. I invited the good sister to come into the office first. I asked her if she knew who I was, and she replied, "Oh yes, you are the stake president."

"Do you remember a Sunday afternoon in November, thirteen years ago?" I asked. "A young bishop came to your door and wanted to know if you and your husband would like to become more active in the Church. Do you remember turning him away?"

"I don't remember anything like that," she said. "I'm sure I would never have done such a thing."

Then I said, "I have another question. Why have you waited so long to

come back to the Church?"

"Well, we always knew we would have to get active again someday," she replied. "We wanted to. We just never got around to it. My husband used to smoke a lot, and he didn't feel comfortable going to church. I prayed for years that he would quit. When he started to have health problems a couple of years ago, it just seemed like a good time to go back."

I finished the interview and talked with her husband as well. They were completely worthy. Shortly afterward, they went to the temple to be sealed.

Now, did you notice the elements of their return? It wasn't easy. They had always known. She had prayed for years. There was a lot of wasted time. Finally, before it was too late, they talked to the bishop, repentance took place, old attitudes and habits were forgotten, and they came back.

Aminadab's return

Another who came back was Aminadab (see Helaman 5). He had once belonged to the church of God, but he became critical and contentious. He evidently sympathized with the opposition, because he was present when two young missionaries named Nephi and Lehi were taken captive by an army of Lamanites.

A cloud of darkness came upon him, and he heard a still, mild voice whisper, "Repent . . . and seek no more to destroy my servants" (vs. 29-30). Surprised, he turned around and looked at Nephi and Lehi. Their faces shone through the darkness, and they appeared to be lifting their voices to heaven (see v. 36).

Aminadab then recognized them for what they were. In a loud voice he told the Lamanites that the young men were servants of God. As the army turned to look, they too became aware of the darkness which surrounded them. They asked Aminadab how to dispel it, and he, drawing on truth learned, I believe, at another time, said:

"You must repent, and cry unto the [Lord], even until ye shall have faith in Christ; . . . and when ye shall do this, the cloud of darkness shall be removed from overshadowing you" (v. 41).

Now notice again, the scripture speaks of darkness overshadowing those who have abandoned the faith. The effect of darkness is to prevent one from seeing clearly. To find the way back, as Aminadab discovered, one must repent and pray until doubt and darkness disappear and important things can be seen again.

A young priest repents and comes back

One final story — once again from when I was a bishop. One night, while I was in a sound sleep, the doorbell rang. I stumbled to answer it and found a young member of my priests quorum at the door. I knew him well — well enough to have gone on outings with him, to have prayed with and about him, and to have taught him. I knew him as well as a good bishop knows any active eighteen-year-old priest, which was well enough for me to ask what he was doing at my front door in the middle of the night.

He said, "I have to talk to you, bishop. I've just done something serious, and I can't go home."

He was right. It was serious. I invited him in, and we talked. He talked and I listened, then I talked and he listened, until dawn. He had many questions. He had committed a terrible sin. He wanted to know if there was hope. He wanted to know how to repent. He wanted to know if repentance included telling his parents. He wanted to know if there was any chance of his going on a mission. He wanted to know many other things.

I didn't have all of the answers, but I told him there was hope. I told him the way back would be difficult, but it was possible. I explained what I knew about the process of repentance and helped him see what he must do. I told him if he really wanted to go on a mis-

sion that that decision could only be made in the future after he had repented. Then I told him to go home, and he did.

He made his peace with his parents. He asked forgiveness from those he had wronged. He put sin and bad company behind him and did everything he could to repent.

A year or so later, five young men from that quorum went on missions. He was one of them. I was close to them all. I attended each of their farewells. They all served honorable missions. Within a brief time after returning home, they all were married in the temple. My wife and I attended each of the ceremonies. I could take a piece of paper, even today, and write their names and the names of their wives and some of their children. That is how well I knew them.

Sins repented of are forgotten

But now let me tell you something — something very private and very important. I cannot remember the name of the young man who came to my home in the middle of the night. I know he was one of the five, but I don't remember which one.

There was a time I used to worry about that. I thought perhaps my memory might be failing. I consciously tried to recall who it was that had the problem, but I could not.

I was eventually released, and I put the entire incident out of my mind. On a late evening walk some years later, I found myself in the ward where I had once been bishop. The shadowy quiet brought back many memories. I was deep in thought when I realized I was walking in front of a house where one of my priests had lived years before. Suddenly, the story of the young man I have mentioned came to mind, and again I tried to remember which of the five he had been. Had he lived in that house? I wondered. Why couldn't I remember?

As I continued on my way, something happened — something difficult

to explain, but real to me. I seemed to hear a voice which said: "Don't you understand, my son? I have forgotten that. Why should you remember?"

I was chagrined. There was no satisfactory answer to the question. I have never wondered about it again. And I knew more surely than I had ever known before that the Lord is pleased when his children return to him.

All who are shepherds and all lost sheep should note this one last thing. The Lord really meant it when he said, "He who has repented of his sins, the same is forgiven, and I, the Lord, remember them no more" (D&C 58:42).

It is possible to come home

Some years ago it was fashionable in certain circles to use the phrase, "You can never go home again." That is just simply not true. It is possible to return. It is possible for those who have ceased to pray, to pray again. It is possible for those who are lost to find their way through the dark and come home.

And when they do, they will know, as I know, that the Lord is more concerned with what a man is than with what he was, and with where he is than with where he has been. I so testify in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

President Hinckley

Thank you, Brother F. Burton Howard, for those reminders of serious things. Before hearing President Benson's concluding remarks, we should like to express appreciation and sincere gratitude to all who have provided the music for this great

conference — to the Mormon Youth Chorus, the Murray Region Family Choir, and this great Tabernacle Choir who have sung to us so powerfully today, to their conductors and organists and all who have to do with it.

We thank our city officials for the cooperation given, to the Relief Society and Church Health Unit nurses who have been on hand to render service, to the ushers and interpreters.

We express appreciation to the local and national press representatives for coverage given to the conference, and to the owners and managers of the many radio and television stations and cable systems who have given time and facilities to carry sessions of this conference in many countries.

We have had in attendance all of the General Authorities except two: Brother Richard Clarke, who presides over the mission in Cape Town, South Africa, and who has remained at his post, and President Marion G. Romney, President of the Council of the Twelve Apostles, who now eighty-nine years of age lingers in a weakened condition. And as I suggested that we remember Brother Tuttle in our prayers, we should also remember President Romney and do so with faith.

We shall now be pleased to listen to President Ezra Taft Benson, our beloved prophet and leader, after which the Tabernacle Choir will sing "Abide with Me."

The benediction will then be offered by Elder Helio da Rocha Camargo of the First Quorum of the Seventy, and this conference will then stand adjourned for six months.

President Ezra Taft Benson

Thanks for latter-day scripture

My beloved brothers and sisters, on this glorious occasion as we have gathered here together, I wish to give thanks to our Father in Heaven for the gift of modern revelation and particu-

larly for the books of latter-day scripture which He has given us.

I love the Bible, both the Old and the New Testaments. It is a source of great truth. It teaches us about the life and ministry of the Master. From its

pages we learn of the hand of God in directing the affairs of His people from the very beginning of the earth's history. It would be difficult to underestimate the impact the Bible has had on the history of the world. Its pages have blessed the lives of generations.

But as generation followed generation, no additional scripture came forth to the children of men. Without additional revelation to guide them, men began to interpret the Bible differently. Numerous churches and creeds developed, each using the Bible as its authoritative source.

But this in no way lessens the worth of the Bible. That sacred and holy book has been of inestimable worth to the children of men. In fact, it was a passage from the Bible that inspired the Prophet Joseph Smith to go to a grove of trees near his home and kneel in prayer. What followed was the glorious vision that commenced the restoration of the fulness of the gospel of Jesus Christ to the earth. That vision also began the process of bringing forth new scripture to stand shoulder to shoulder with the Bible in bearing witness to a wicked world that Jesus is the Christ and that God lives and loves His children and is still intimately involved in their salvation and exaltation.

Through the prophet Nephi, the Lord warned against those who might say that the Bible was all the scripture the world would need. He said:

"Know ye not that there are more nations than one? Know ye not that I, the Lord your God, have created all men, . . . and I bring forth my word unto the children of men, yea, even upon all the nations of the earth? . . .

"Know ye not that the testimony of two nations is a witness unto you that I am God, that I remember one nation like unto another? . . .

"And I do this that I may prove unto many that I am the same yesterday, today, and forever" (2 Nephi 29:7-9).

Today we have three new books of scripture: the Book of Mormon, the Doctrine and Covenants, and the Pearl of Great Price. I love all of these sacred

volumes. This afternoon I would like to speak particularly about the Book of Mormon and the Doctrine and Covenants. These two great books of latter-day scripture are bound together as revelations from Israel's God for the purpose of gathering and preparing His people for the Second Coming of the Lord. As President John Taylor wrote, the bringing forth of these two sacred volumes "cost the best blood of the nineteenth century" (D&C 135:6), namely the lives of the Prophet Joseph Smith and his brother Hyrum.

To the Prophet Joseph Smith the Lord said, "This generation shall have my word through you" (D&C 5:10). The Book of Mormon and the Doctrine and Covenants are part of the fulfillment of that promise. Together these two great works of scripture bring great blessings to this generation.

Powerful proclamations of modern scripture

Each of these two books of modern scripture contains a powerful proclamation to the world. The Book of Mormon title page declares its purpose is threefold: to show what great things the Lord has done, to teach of the covenants of the Lord, and to convince both Jew and Gentile that Jesus is the Christ.

Section 1 of the Doctrine and Covenants is the Lord's preface to the book. The Doctrine and Covenants is the only book in the world that has a preface written by the Lord Himself. In that preface He declares to the world that His voice is unto all men (see v. 2), that the coming of the Lord is nigh (see v. 12), and that the truths found in the Doctrine and Covenants will all be fulfilled (see vs. 37-38).

New witnesses of Jesus Christ

Each of these two great latter-day scriptures bears powerful and eloquent witness of the Lord Jesus Christ. Virtually every page of both the Doctrine and Covenants and the Book of Mormon teaches about the Master — His great

love for His children and His atoning sacrifice — and teaches us how to live so that we can return to Him and our Heavenly Father.

Essential knowledge and counsel in modern scripture

Each of these two great latter-day books of scripture contains the knowledge and the power to help us live better lives in a time of great wickedness and evil. Those who carefully and prayerfully search the pages of these books will find comfort, counsel, guidance, and the quiet power to improve their lives.

Of the Book of Mormon, President Marion G. Romney has said:

"If our young folks are traditioned in the teachings of the Book of Mormon, they will not only be inspired with righteous courage to choose the right by example, . . . they will also be so schooled in the principles of the gospel of Jesus Christ that they will know what is right.

"From almost every page of the book, there will come to them a moving testimony that Jesus is indeed the Christ, the Son of the Living God, our Redeemer and Savior. *This witness alone will be a sustaining anchor in every storm*" (in Conference Report, Apr. 1960, p. 112; italics added).

Speaking of the revelations in the Doctrine and Covenants, President Joseph Fielding Smith said: "If we will put them into practice, if we will keep the commandments of the Lord, we will know the truth and there shall be no weapon formed against us that shall prosper. There shall be no false doctrines, no teaching of men that will deceive us. . . . If we will search these revelations then we will be fortified against errors and we will be made strong" (in Conference Report, Oct. 1931, p. 17).

The Lord gives modern scripture to preserve his people

Many years before the coming of the Savior to this earth, the prophet Enoch saw the latter days. He observed the great wickedness that would prevail on the earth at this time and foretold the "great tribulations" that would result from such wickedness; but in the midst of what was otherwise a very gloomy prophecy, the Lord promised, "But my people will I preserve" (Moses 7:61). How would He do so? Note what the Lord Himself promised He would do to preserve His people. He said:

"And *righteousness will I send down out of heaven; and truth will I send forth out of the earth*, to bear testimony of mine Only Begotten; . . . and *righteousness and truth will I cause to sweep the earth as with a flood, to gather out mine elect from the four quarters of the earth, unto a place which I shall prepare*" (Moses 7:62; italics added).

The Lord promised, therefore, that righteousness would come from heaven and truth out of the earth. We have seen the marvelous fulfillment of that prophecy in our generation. The Book of Mormon has come forth out of the earth, filled with truth, serving as the very "keystone of our religion" (see Introduction to the Book of Mormon). God has also sent down righteousness from heaven. The Father Himself appeared with His Son to the Prophet Joseph Smith. The angel Moroni, John the Baptist, Peter, James, and numerous other angels were directed by heaven to restore the necessary powers to the kingdom. Further, the Prophet Joseph Smith received revelation after revelation from the heavens during those first critical years of the Church's growth. These revelations have been preserved for us in the Doctrine and Covenants.

These two great works of scripture, then, become a major tool in the Lord's hand for preserving His people in the latter days: the Book of Mormon, written under the hand of inspiration for

our day, preserved through the centuries to come forth in our time, translated by the gift and power of God. It is the keystone of our religion. It is the keystone of our doctrine. It is the keystone of our testimony. It is a keystone in the witness of Jesus Christ. It is a keystone in helping us avoid the deceptions of the evil one in these latter days. Satan rages in the hearts of men and has power over all of his dominions (see D&C 1:35). But the Book of Mormon has greater power — power to reveal false doctrine, power to help us overcome temptations, power to help us get closer to God than any other book (see Introduction to the Book of Mormon).

Study the Book of Mormon to receive God's approval

The Book of Mormon must be reenthroned in the minds and hearts of our people. We must honor it by reading it, by studying it, by taking its precepts into our lives and transforming them into lives required of the true followers of Christ. Speaking of the central role of the Book of Mormon in our worship, President Joseph Fielding Smith said:

"It seems to me that any member of this Church would never be satisfied until he or she had read the Book of Mormon time and time again, and thoroughly considered it so that he or she could bear witness that it is in very deed a record with the inspiration of the Almighty upon it, and that its history is true. . . .

"... No member of this Church can stand approved in the presence of God who has not seriously and carefully read the Book of Mormon" (in Conference Report, Oct. 1961, p. 18; italics added).

Doctrine and Covenants given directly to this generation

Likewise, the Doctrine and Covenants becomes an essential part of our

spiritual life. The Prophet Joseph Smith said, "In these infant days of the Church, there was great anxiety to obtain the word of the Lord upon every subject that in any way concerned our salvation" (*History of the Church*, 1:207).

Thus, the Doctrine and Covenants is a glorious book of scripture given directly to our generation. It contains the will of the Lord for us in these latter days that precede the Second Coming of Christ. It contains many truths and doctrines not fully revealed in other scripture. Like the Book of Mormon, it will strengthen those who carefully and prayerfully study from its pages.

Use modern scripture to bless lives and resist evil

Do we, as Saints of the Most High God, treasure the word He has preserved for us at so great a cost? Are we using these books of latter-day revelation to bless our lives and resist the powers of the evil one? This is the purpose for which they were given. How can we not stand condemned before the Lord if we treat them lightly by letting them do no more than gather dust on our shelves?

My beloved brothers and sisters, I bear my solemn witness that these books contain the mind and the will of the Lord for us in these days of trial and tribulation. They stand with the Bible to give witness of the Lord and His work. These books contain the voice of the Lord to us in these latter days. May we turn to them with full purpose of heart and use them in the way the Lord wishes them to be used, I pray in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

The choir sang "Abide with Me."
Elder Helio da Rocha Camargo offered the benediction.

SALT LAKE TABERNACLE CHOIR AND ORGAN BROADCAST

The following broadcast, announced by J. Spencer Kinard and originating with KSL Radio and Television, Salt Lake City, Utah, was presented from 9:30 to 10:00 A.M. on Sunday, October 5, 1986, through the courtesy of the Columbia Broadcasting System's network throughout the United States, parts of Canada, and through other facilities to several points overseas.

Announcer: Once more we welcome you within these walls with a program of inspirational Music and Spoken Word from the crossroads of the West.

CBS and its affiliated stations bring you at this hour the Mormon Tabernacle Choir from Temple Square in Salt Lake City, with Jerold Ottley conducting the choir, Robert Cundick, Tabernacle organist, and the Spoken Word given by Spencer Kinard.

(Choir: "Be Not Afraid" — Mendelssohn)

Announcer: "Be not afraid, saith God the Lord; thy help is near." The Tabernacle Choir opened today's broadcast with a chorus from Mendelssohn's oratorio, *Elijah*.

Optimism, as the story of *Elijah* teaches us, is a double-edged sword. A sense of strength based upon the flattering words and promises of false prophets can lead individuals and nations to destruction, while those who trust fully in God and live by His word have nothing to fear.

Personal anguish that leads to honest and sincere soul-searching can bring even the most unworthy of us into contact with the Infinite Healer, as we hear in this choral setting of Charles Gounod's "O Divine Redeemer."

(Choir: "O Divine Redeemer" — Gounod)

Announcer: From the English liturgical tradition of the late nineteenth century, Robert Cundick has selected a

work by Liverpool organist, William Faulkes, entitled "Elevation."

(Organ: "Elevation" — William Faulkes)

Announcer: Jesus said, "Suffer the little children to come unto me, and forbid them not: for of such is the kingdom of God" (Mark 10:14).

The choir turns now to the words and music of Natalie Sleeth:

How will they know, these babes for whom we care,

That God is love and with us ev'rywhere,

That life is good with blessings all can share?

How will they know unless we teach them so?

(Choir: "How Will They Know?" — Sleeth)

Announcer: Nowhere in sacred literature is the need for love in our lives more beautifully expressed than in the Apostle Paul's letter to the Corinthians (see 1 Corinthians 13). He called it charity. Today, we usually refer to it as love.

And so, in reverent paraphrase, we express the need for this basic human value — for the greatest of these is love.

Though we pay our church donations and attend all our religious services, and have not love — it is nothing.

Though we conform to church ritual, and proselyte as missionaries, and bear titles of ecclesiastical power or authority, but do it without love — we are as the empty shells which line the seashore, having the semblance of life, but not the spirit.

Though we bequeath our money to great universities and charitable causes; and though magnificent buildings bear our names, monuments our visage, and newspapers our photograph — in the absence of love, we are none the better.

And even if we develop the technology to speed ourselves to the far

reaches of the universe, or to peer at the smallest microbe, or have the knowledge to cure ourselves of all disease and poverty — if love is lacking, it profits us little.

Love is patient and wise — patient with the gentle forbearance which waits on others before itself, and wise with the gentle wisdom of old eyes which, having looked on time, know that the simple act of being kind is greater than all the wisdom of the wise.

Love is not boastful or self-interested, but understands that no man has achieved success without the help and sacrifice of others.

Where love is, there also are faith, hope, and endurance. Without love, the richest man is made poor; with love, the poorest man is made rich.

When war is nothing more than a rusting relic of a frightful past; when the gallows and ghettos have crumbled into dust; when the last terrorist, the last tyrant, the last murderer and rapist have crept silently to rest — love will remain, and will rule, because love knows no death.

Fame dies, honors perish, and the worldly hope men set their hearts upon turns to ashes. But love lives on — through decades, through centuries, through eons — for the greatest of these is love.

(Choir: "Our Savior's Love" — Gates)

Announcer: We spoke earlier of optimism, of trust in God, of knowing that

God cares for us. The choir has recalled this theme in a hymn by Edward L. Hart, with music by Crawford Gates: "Our Savior's Love."

We close now with another song of peace and hope, with words adapted from the twenty-fourth Psalm, by Carl Nygard, Jr.: "The earth is the Lord's and the fullness thereof. Who can rightly ascend the hill of the Lord, And who may enter His House? The pure in heart."

(Choir: "The Earth Is the Lord's" — Nygard)

Announcer: Again we leave you from within the shadows of the everlasting hills. May peace be with you this day . . . and always.

Announcer (on radio): This concludes the two-thousand, nine-hundred, eighty-first performance continuing the fifty-eighth year of this traditional broadcast from the Mormon Tabernacle on Temple Square, brought to you by CBS and its affiliated stations, originating with station KSL in Salt Lake City.

Jerold Ottley conducted the choir, Robert Cundick was at the organ, and the Spoken Word was given by Spencer Kinard.

In another seven days at this same hour, Music and the Spoken Word will be heard again from the crossroads of the West.

This is the CBS Radio Network.

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